Social Security Design and Its Political Support*

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Abstract

The design of social security systems has implications for the political support of intergenerational transfers. We examine the effects of contributive vs. universal pensions, as well as the link between benefits and earnings, on the social security tax rate, labor supply, and capital accumulation. In an overlapping generations model featuring heterogeneous households, our results align with existing ones on the effects of retirees' relative political power, ageing, and income inequality. Additionally, we find taxes to be lower when benefits are earnings-related and, if informal retirees are poorer than formal ones and the pension a comparable share of their consumption, higher when pensions are universal. Calibrated to Argentina, the model accounts for about three fifths of the rise in pension spending over the 2005–2010 expansion of coverage. In the model calibrated to the U.S., France and the UK, ageing is the main determinant of U.S. pension spending and the earnings link the second, ahead of income inequality and voting patterns by a margin that narrows as the intertemporal elasticity of substitution rises. When the electorate also chooses the design of the system, an interior choice requires redistribution through pensions to be costly. With a deadweight cost of flat benefits that rises with the size of the system, calibrated to the U.S., ageing makes benefits more earnings-related, while income inequality moves the design in a direction that depends on that elasticity. Applied to 26 OECD countries at an elasticity of one, the model has pension spending and the earnings link rise together as population growth falls, as the data do, but it also relates the earnings link to inequality, which the data do not.

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1 Introduction

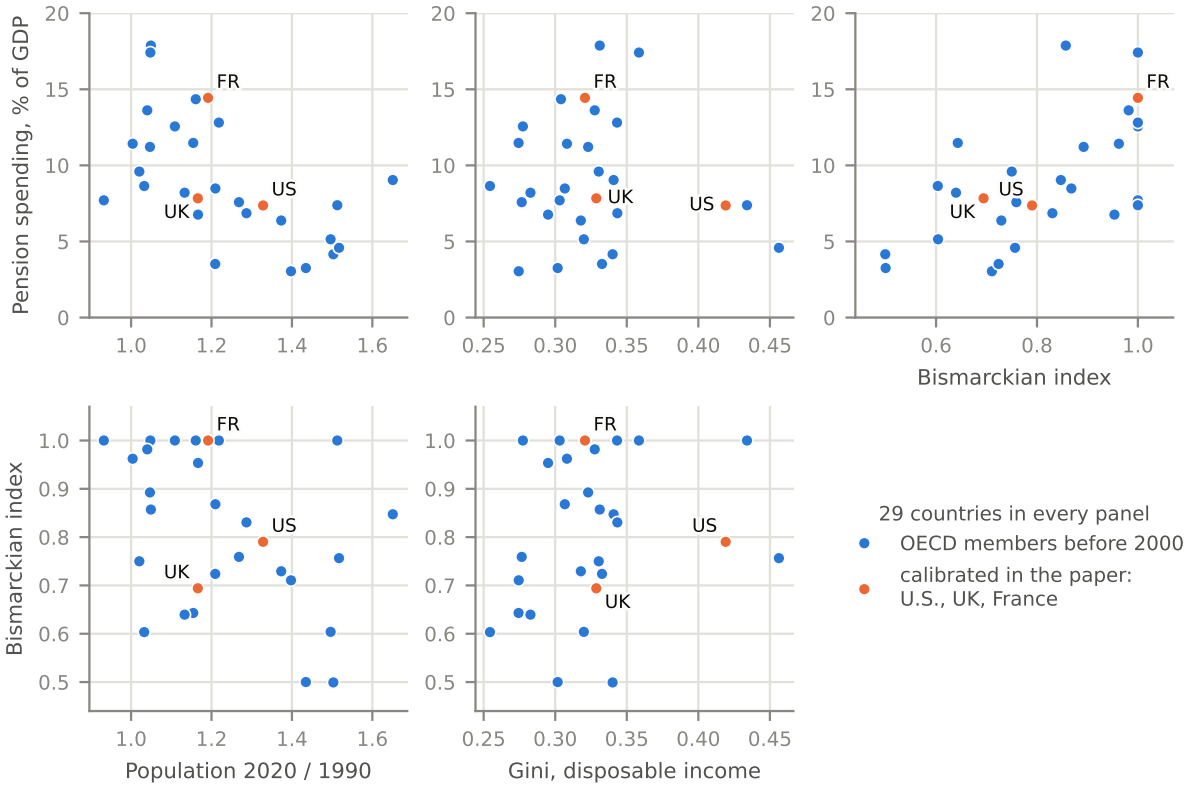
Pensions are the largest transfer programme of most governments. In 2020 public pension spending averaged about 8% of GDP across the OECD and close to 4% in emerging and middle-income economies.[1] Systems differ along two key dimensions. The first concerns eligibility and coverage: some condition benefits on a contribution record, others offer universal entitlements. The second is the link between benefits and past earnings: Bismarckian systems tie the two closely, whereas Beveridgean systems pay flat benefits. Both dimensions shape the labor supply of workers, the redistribution embedded in the system, and the coalition of voters that supports it.

Given their size, it is no surprise that the design of social security systems remains a central concern in policy debates. As populations age, policymakers must navigate difficult trade-offs among intergenerational equity, fiscal sustainability, and labor market efficiency. Moreover, pension arrangements are not determined by actuarial considerations alone: they are the outcome of political processes in which heterogeneous voters and organized interests shape the level and composition of benefits and contributions. A political-economy perspective is therefore critical for understanding why countries differ in the size of their systems and in their design. Figure 1.1 shows how they differ across the 29 countries that were in the OECD before 2000. Pension spending and the Bismarckian–Beveridgean index, the ratio of replacement rates at mean and at half mean earnings, both rise as population growth falls, and they rise together. Neither is related to income inequality. The last fact runs against the leading theory of pension design, that of Conde-Ruiz and Profeta (2007), in which high inequality leads a coalition of the rich and the poor to choose a small Beveridgean system and low inequality leads the middle class to choose a larger Bismarckian one. Their prediction comes from coalitions formed under majority voting, which the probabilistic voting we use rules out, so the fact is not by itself evidence for our model. Few other politico-economic models have integrated the design. We address this gap with a dynamic politico-economic model and ask whether one political process can deliver both the size of the system and its design, and their relation to ageing but not to inequality.

We study the question in an overlapping generations model with capital accumulation and heterogeneous households. Households consume, save, and supply labor, and as

[1] The dispersion is wide even among rich countries: a bit more than 3% of GDP in Ireland and Chile and more than 17% in Italy and Greece (OECD 2021).

Figure 1.1: Population growth, income inequality, pension spending and design



Sources: OECD Social Expenditure Database (pension spending), OECD historical population data (population growth), OECD, *Pensions at a Glance 2021*, table 4.1 (Bismarckian–Beveridgean index) and the UNU-WIDER World Income Inequality Database (Gini coefficient). Details are in the technical documentation (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026). Section 7.3 takes the model to 26 of these countries, without Mexico, Turkey and Korea, where more than a quarter of employment is informal (ILOSTAT).

voters, they choose among policies on labor income taxes and retirement benefits. Policy preferences vary by income and age; we model the resolution of these conflicts through probabilistic voting with elections taking place every period. Policy decisions not only impact economic outcomes, but also affect future policy decisions. Voters take these effects into account. We study Markov equilibria in which only fundamental state variables enter. Households differ in their productivity and propensity to vote. In addition, a share of households work in an informal sector or get income from home production, where labor is not taxed and savings do not enter the capital stock. Preferences are those of Greenwood et al. (1988), so that labor supply depends on the after-tax wage and how current effort raises future benefits. Benefits combine a flat component with an earnings-related one, the weight of the second, θ, setting how Bismarckian benefits are, and informal households receive a universal pension whose level is the second design parameter.

We show that when utility is logarithmic, politico-economic equilibria retain analytical tractability despite the presence of heterogeneity and institutional richness. With hand-to-mouth informal households, the equilibrium tax is a function of parameters and

demographics alone. The analytical frame clarifies how population ageing, retirees' political influence, pension design, and income inequality shape the equilibrium tax rate. A more Bismarckian benefit formula lowers the equilibrium tax, since it shifts benefits from poor retirees, who value them more at the margin, to rich ones, so that retirees as a group support a smaller system. The effect of a more universal pension is ambiguous: it raises the tax when informal retirees are poorer than formal ones and the pension is a comparable share of their consumption. When utility is constant relative risk aversion (CRRA), we show that the state space for equilibrium policies can be reduced to a single aggregate state and provide numerical solutions.[2]

We present two empirical applications of the model. First, we study Argentina as the case in which the design changed: from 2005 a series of tax amnesties raised the coverage of the elderly from 68% to over 90%, and pension spending rose by 1.9% of GDP by 2010. Implementing this reform in our calibrated model accounts for about three fifths of that rise. The model also predicts modest declines in labor supply and savings, and a fall in the savings of the newly covered households relative to other households, the sign that Gonzalez-Rozada and Ruffo (2016) estimate for the amnesties. Second, initially taking the design as given, we calibrate the model to the U.S., France, and the UK, three advanced economies with distinct pension system characteristics, demographics, and inequality profiles. We find that the size of the pension system increases strongly with ageing and with flat benefits, the latter less so as the intertemporal elasticity of substitution rises, and responds much less to income inequality, leisure preferences, and voting profiles, although at a high intertemporal elasticity the voting profile moves it nearly as much as the earnings link does.

We then let the electorate choose the earnings link as well as the tax. Without a cost of redistribution the choice is a corner. The flat component of benefits is a pure transfer within the retired cohort, from retirees above mean income to those below, and an electorate that weighs retirees by their marginal utility wants all of it: we prove that unless propensities to vote rise sharply with income, the design chosen with the tax is fully Beveridgean, whatever the tax rate, the demography and the income distribution.[3]

An interior design requires flat benefits to be more expensive than earnings-related ones. We introduce a deadweight cost of the redistribution the flat component performs, read as the loss from the implicit tax it levies on earnings (Summers 1989) and rising with the square of that tax as in Harberger (1964), so that the share of revenue lost is quadratic in the flat share of benefits, proportional to the dispersion of incomes and rising with the

[2]When informal households can save, the state space includes two states.

[3]We also let the electorate choose the design one period ahead of the benefits it governs, the timing of section 7, and once and for all, an exercise outside the Markov equilibria we study. At the U.S. calibration, and at every intertemporal elasticity of substitution we check, both give a corner: the first the Beveridgean one, and the second the Beveridgean one under log preferences and the Bismarckian one at higher intertemporal elasticities (online appendix).

size of the system. A single cost parameter is calibrated so that the U.S. electorate re-elects its observed design, and it is tested on the UK and France: it accounts for about a quarter of the distance of each from the U.S. design, though no value of it reproduces France's fully Bismarckian one. With this formulation, the model predicts that an ageing population chooses both a more Bismarckian design and higher pension spending, as in figure 1.1, whereas the income distribution moves spending little and moves the design in a direction that depends on the intertemporal elasticity of substitution. Taken with logarithmic utility and the U.S. parameters to 26 of the figure's 29 countries, each with its own demography, income distribution and inherited design, the model reproduces the signs of the relations among pension spending, the index and population growth, with a weaker response of the index to population growth than in the data. Unlike the data, however, it ties more Beveridgean designs to higher inequality.

The paper belongs to the literature on politico-economic equilibria of social security (e.g. Cooley and Soares 1999; Galasso 1999; Forni 2005; Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt 2008; Song 2011), surveyed by Galasso and Profeta (2002). As in Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008) and Song (2011), under log-GHH preferences and with hand-to-mouth informal households the equilibrium has no strategic effects and taxes increase with the political power of retirees and with ageing, and as in Song (2011) they increase with income inequality when propensities to vote are equal; as in Uchida and Ono (2024), the equilibrium tax is a function of parameters and demographics alone; and as in Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2005), the effect of ageing under CRRA preferences is close to the logarithmic one after recalibration. What we add is a pension system that differs in two dimensions, in coverage and in the earnings link, and workers who differ in productivity and in their propensity to vote. Neither adds a state when informal households are hand-to-mouth, and the calibrated model quantifies what each feature of the design does to the tax rate, labor supply and savings.

On the design of the system, Galasso and Profeta (2002) leave open why some systems are Beveridgean and others Bismarckian, and why the Bismarckian ones are larger, two questions that a vote on the size of the system alone cannot answer. Casamatta et al. (2000) study the political support of Bismarckian against Beveridgean benefits, Conde-Ruiz and Profeta (2007) the joint choice of size and design, Koethenbuerger et al. (2008) the trade-off by which more redistributive systems are smaller, and Cremer et al. (2007) the choice of type and generosity. We embed the choice in a dynamic equilibrium with capital accumulation and labor supply, in which the design is chosen every period, one period ahead of the benefits it governs, and take it to the data.

Section 2 presents the model and the equilibrium concepts. Section 3 derives the equilibrium under log-GHH preferences, in which the tax is a function of parameters and demographics alone, and its comparative statics. Section 4 describes how the equilibria are computed outside that case. Section 5 calibrates the model to Argentina and compares

its prediction with the observed reform, section 6 calibrates it to the U.S., France and the UK and ranks the determinants of pension spending, and section 7 lets the electorate choose the design and takes the model to 26 OECD countries. Section 8 concludes. The appendix collects proofs, derivations, and calibration details. An online appendix[4] collects auxiliary tables and figures and presents various robustness checks, and technical documentation accompanies the paper (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026).

2 The Model

2.1 Demographics, Inequality, and Institutions

We consider an economy populated by overlapping generations of workers and retirees. Within each generational cohort, we consider $J+1$ household types indexed $j = 0, \ldots, J$. The $j > 0$ household types allocate time between labor and leisure, pay taxes on labor income, consume, and save. When they reach retirement, they spend the return on their savings and any social security benefits they may receive, and die. Type $j = 0$ households similarly allocate time between labor and leisure, consume, and save for retirement. However, they supply labor to an informal labor market, thus not subject to labor income taxes, and they save for retirement using an informal savings technology. The distribution of the formal household types $j > 0$ is given by γ_j with $\sum_{j>0} \gamma_j = 1$, and each cohort has γ_0 informal households, of type $j = 0$, per formal household, a share $\gamma_0/(1+\gamma_0)$ of the cohort. The ratio of formal workers to formal retirees in period t follows a deterministic process, and is given by ν_t; since γ_0 is constant, it is also the ratio of all workers to all retirees.

The government runs a pay-as-you-go (PAYG) pension system with a balanced budget. Each period, the government imposes a tax on labor supplied in the formal sector and transfers the collected amount directly to retirees. We consider social security systems that differ along two dimensions: whether workers need to qualify to receive full benefits or not and the type of benefits provided, either tied to earnings or flat-rate. We describe the different systems in section 2.4.

Policy decisions are taken by a government that acts in the interest of voters, but lacks commitment.

[4] championape.github.io/SSDclaude

2.2 Technology

In the formal sector, a continuum of competitive firms transform aggregate capital and labor into output. We define the aggregate formal labor supply as

$$H_t = N_t h_t, \qquad h_t \equiv \sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \eta_i h_{t,i}, \tag{1a}$$

where N_t is the number of formal workers at time t, $h_{t,i}$ is time allocated to labor by household type i, and η_i is their labor productivity, normalized such that $\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \eta_i = 1$. Capital is owned by formal retirees and fully depreciates after a period. The economy-wide capital stock per formal worker, k_t, therefore corresponds to the economy-wide per capita savings of formal workers in the previous period, s_{t-1}, normalized by ν_t. We define the aggregate capital stock from

$$K_t = N_{t-1} s_{t-1}, \qquad s_{t-1} \equiv \sum_{i>0} \gamma_i s_{t-1,i}. \tag{1b}$$

The representative firm produces output using labor and capital and a conventional Cobb-Douglas technology

$$Y_t = K_t^{\alpha} H_t^{1-\alpha} \tag{2}$$

In equilibrium this implies the following factor prices:

$$R_t = \alpha \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t h_t} \right)^{\alpha - 1}, \qquad w_t = (1-\alpha) \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t h_t} \right)^{\alpha}. \tag{3}$$

Informal households produce with a linear technology, and we index its factor prices to the formal sector's: the informal wage w_t^0 is the formal wage that would prevail at the same capital per formal worker, s_{t-1}/ν_t, without the pension system, and the return on informal savings is proportional to the formal return, $R_t^0 = r_0 R_t$ (appendix A). At a given capital stock the informal wage therefore does not respond to taxes: a payroll tax that lowers formal hours raises the formal wage, but not informal earnings or the old-age endowment of the hand-to-mouth informal households of section 3.

2.3 Preferences and Household Choices

Households value consumption and leisure, and discount the future at factor $\beta \in (0,1)$. Representing utility by function $u(c,h)$ with $u'_c \geq 0, u'_h \leq 0, u''_{cc} \leq 0, u''_{hh} \leq 0$, the welfare of a young household of type i born in period t is defined by

$$u\left(c^i_{1,t}, h_{t,i}\right) + \beta u\left(c^i_{2,t+1}, 0\right). \tag{4}$$

The budget constraints for formal and informal workers are given by:

$$c^i_{1,t} = w_t \eta_i h_{t,i}(1-\tau_t) - s_{t,i}, \qquad i > 0, \tag{5a}$$
$$c^0_{1,t} = w^0_t \eta_0 h_{t,0} - s_{t,0}, \tag{5b}$$

where τ_t is the social security tax rate. As retirees, households receive a pension b^i_{t+1} that may depend on the individual household's contribution, and thus on their labor supply, $h_{t,i}$:

$$c^i_{2,t+1} = s_{t,i} R_{t+1} + b^i_{t+1}(h_{t,i}), \qquad i > 0, \tag{5c}$$
$$c^0_{2,t+1} = s_{t,0} R^0_{t+1} + b^0_{t+1}(h_{t,0}). \tag{5d}$$

Optimization yields the first order conditions that represent a leisure/consumption tradeoff and a conventional Euler condition for intertemporal consumption smoothing:[5]

$$-\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial h_{t,i}} = \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial c^i_{1,t}} \left(w_t(1-\tau_t)\eta_i + \frac{\partial b^i_{t+1}/\partial h_{t,i}}{R_{t+1}} \right), \qquad i > 0 \tag{6a}$$
$$-\frac{\partial u_0}{\partial h_{t,0}} = \frac{\partial u_0}{\partial c^0_{1,t}} \left(w^0_t \eta_0 + \frac{\partial b^0_{t+1}/\partial h_{t,0}}{R^0_{t+1}} \right), \tag{6b}$$
$$\frac{\partial u_i}{\partial c^i_{1,t}} = \beta R_{t+1} \frac{\partial u_i}{\partial c^i_{2,t+1}}, \qquad i > 0 \tag{6c}$$
$$\frac{\partial u_0}{\partial c^0_{1,t}} = \beta R^0_{t+1} \frac{\partial u_0}{\partial c^0_{2,t+1}}. \tag{6d}$$

Optimal savings and labor supply decisions can, in general, be written as

$$h_{t,i} = h_{t,i}\left(s_{t-1}, s_t, h_t, h_{t+1}, \tau_t, \tau_{t+1}\right) \tag{7a}$$
$$s_{t,i} = s_{t,i}\left(s_{t-1}, s_t, h_t, h_{t+1}, \tau_t, \tau_{t+1}\right), \tag{7b}$$

where the dependence on h_{t+1}, τ_{t+1} comes from the pension system.

2.4 Social Security System

The government runs a pay-as-you-go pension system with a balanced budget. Every period, the government taxes labor income in the formal sector and pays pensions to current retirees.

We consider systems that differ along two dimensions. First, in *contributive* systems workers have to meet a contribution requirement to receive full pension benefits. In contrast, in a *universal* system all workers are eligible to receive pensions upon retirement,

[5] We are using shorthand notation $u_i \equiv u(c_i, h_i)$ with timing implicit by the variable we take derivatives with respect to.

regardless of whether they contributed to it or not.

Second, pension schemes also differ according to the relationship between the level of contributions and benefits. *Bismarckian* systems provide earnings-related benefits; this gives workers an additional incentive to work as they perceive this increases their future pensions. In contrast, *Beveridgean* systems offer flat payments and lack this incentive. We model this by making benefits to consist of a common amount for all formal workers and a second component that is proportional to past labor income.[6]

Benefits are thus given by:

$$b_t^i = [\theta h_{t-1,i}\eta_i + (1-\theta)h_{t-1}]\,\bar{b}_t \tag{8a}$$

$$b_t^0 = \epsilon h_{t-1}\bar{b}_t \tag{8b}$$

where ϵ determines the level of universal pensions received by informal workers, θ measures how Bismarckian are the benefits of formal workers, and $\bar{b}_t$ is the pension rate per unit of past effective labor, so that the average formal pension is $h_{t-1}\bar{b}_t$. With $\epsilon = 0$ the system is purely contributive and there are no pensions for informal workers. With $\epsilon = 1-\theta$ they receive the basic common pension of formal workers, and with $\epsilon = 1-\theta+\theta\eta_1 h_{t-1,1}/h_{t-1}$ the system is purely universal in the sense that informal workers receive the same pensions as the type of formal working household with lowest productivity.

The balanced budget requirement implies that

$$\nu_t w_t \tau_t h_t = \sum_{j\geq 0} \gamma_j b_t^j$$

This implies that the pension rate $\bar{b}_t$ is:

$$\bar{b}_t = \frac{\nu_t w_t h_t \tau_t}{h_{t-1}(1+\gamma_0\epsilon)}. \tag{8c}$$

2.5 Elections

Elections take place at the beginning of each period. We assume that preferences are aggregated through probabilistic voting.[7] Thus, policy maximizes a convex combination of the objective functions of all groups of voters, where the weights reflect the groups' sizes and their responsiveness to policy changes. We allow for age related variation in responsiveness, reflected in a per capita political influence weight of unity for young voters and a per capita weight of $\omega \geq 0$ for retired voters.

[6] This formulation has been frequently used in the study of redistributive social security, see e.g. Casamatta et al. (2000).

[7] See Lindbeck and Weibull (1987).

2.6 Equilibrium

Competitive Equilibrium. In economic equilibrium, firms and households optimize given factor prices, policies, and a vector of aggregate states z_t, which includes exogenous demographics as well as the distribution of states $\{s_{t-1,j}, h_{t-1,j}\}_j$. In a rational expectations equilibrium, the path of policies $\{\tau_s\}_{t\leq s\leq T}$ fully determines an allocation and price system.

Conditional on some initial states z_0 and a policy sequence $\{\tau_t\}_{0\leq t\leq T}$, a competitive equilibrium is given by an allocation and price system such that

i. households optimize;

ii. aggregate states are defined according to (1), markets clear, and factor prices are determined according to (3) for all t; and

iii. the government budget constraints in (8) are satisfied for all t.

Politico-economic equilibrium. In politico-economic equilibrium political decision makers optimally choose tax rates, taking all implications of their actions into account and forming rational expectations about future policy choices. We assume that these choices are Markov, i.e. they are functions of the fundamental state variables. The decision maker at date t takes the distribution of states $\{s_{t-1,j}, h_{t-1,j}\}$ as well as the continuation policy $\tau_t^{+1}(z_t)$ as given. Furthermore, given the continuation tax function, the policymaker takes as given the following law of motion for the state variables as a function of current policy choices:

$$z_{t+1} = \zeta_t\left(z_t, \tau_t, \tau_t^{+1}\right). \tag{9}$$

Subject to (3), (8), (9), the policymaker chooses τ_t to maximize

$$\mathcal{W}_t\left(z_t, \tau_t; \tau_t^{+1}(z_{t+1})\right) \equiv \sum_j \gamma_j \mu_j \left[\omega \mathcal{O}_j(z_t, \tau_t) + \nu_t \mathcal{Y}_j\left(z_t, \tau_t; \tau_t^{+1}(z_{t+1})\right)\right],$$

where the objective function is the weighted sum of indirect utilities from retirees $\mathcal{O}_j$ and workers $\mathcal{Y}_j$, with weights reflecting relative population sizes through ν_t and γ_j, relative political weight of retirees ω, and propensity to vote μ_j.

Definition 1. *A* politico-economic equilibrium *as of period t conditional on z_t consists of a sequence of tax functions, $\{\tau_\iota(\cdot)\}_{\iota\geq t}$; a sequence of continuation tax functions, $\{\tau_\iota^{+1}(\cdot)\}_{\iota\geq t}$; a sequence of laws of motion for the state variables, $\{\zeta_\iota(\cdot)\}_{\iota\geq t}$; policy choices, $\{\tau_\iota^\star\}_{\iota\geq t}$; and a competitive equilibrium allocation such that*

i. tax functions are optimal subject to continuation tax functions:

$$\tau_\iota(z_\iota) \in \arg\max_{\tau_\iota} \mathcal{W}_\iota(z_\iota, \tau_\iota; \tau_\iota^{+1}(\cdot)) \text{ for all } z_\iota, \text{ s.t. } (3), (8), (9), \ \iota \geq t;$$

ii. continuation tax functions are consistent with tax functions:[8]

$$\tau_{\iota-1}^{+1}(z_\iota) = \tau_\iota\left(z_\iota, \tau_\iota^{+1}(z_{\iota+1}(\cdot))\right) \text{ for all } z_\iota, \iota \geq t;$$

iii. laws of motion are consistent with the policy and continuation policy functions according to (9);

iv. equilibrium tax choices are generated by the continuation tax function,

$$\{\tau_\iota^\star\}_{\iota \geq t} = \tau_{\iota-1}^{+1}(z_\iota),$$

and $\{\tau_\iota^\star\}_{\iota \geq t}$ implements a competitive equilibrium allocation.

For infinite horizon and a recursive time-autonomous structure, the policy and continuation policy functions are time-autonomous functions of the state as well, and conditions i. and ii. above are combined in a fixed point requirement.

3 Logarithmic-GHH Preferences

This section derives the model's analytical results. We follow Greenwood et al. (1988) and assume

$$u(c_{1,t}^i, h_{t,i}) = \ln\left(\tilde{c}_{1,t}^i\right), \qquad \tilde{c}_{1,t}^i \equiv c_{1,t}^i - \frac{X_i \xi}{1+\xi}\left(h_{t,i}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \tag{10}$$

where ξ is the Frisch elasticity of labor supply and X_i is a type-specific taste for leisure. Proposition 1 characterizes the economic equilibrium under these log-GHH preferences. If informal households are in addition hand-to-mouth, the politico-economic equilibrium carries no state (proposition 2) and the tax rate is a function of parameters and demographics alone. The quantitative sections keep log-GHH preferences as the benchmark and let informal households save for retirement. They also report results under CRRA-GHH preferences, $u(c_{1,t}^i, h_{t,i}) = \left((\tilde{c}_{1,t}^i)^{1-1/\rho} - 1\right)/(1-1/\rho)$, in which ρ is the intertemporal elasticity of substitution and $\rho = 1$ is the logarithmic case.

[8] With a finite horizon, $\tau^{T+1}(z_T) = \emptyset$.

3.1 Economic Equilibrium

With log-GHH preferences, formal households i supply labor and save according to

$$h_{t,i} = \left(\frac{\eta_i w_t (1-\tau_t) + \frac{\theta \bar{b}_{t+1} \eta_i}{R_{t+1}}}{X_i} \right)^{\xi} \tag{11a}$$

$$s_{t,i} = \frac{\beta}{1+\beta} \left[w_t (1-\tau_t) h_{t,i} \eta_i - \frac{X_i \xi}{1+\xi} (h_{t,i})^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \right] - \frac{b^i_{t+1}/R_{t+1}}{1+\beta}. \tag{11b}$$

Appendix A shows that in economic equilibrium every relevant variable x (savings, labor supply and consumption) is a power of capital per worker times a coefficient,

$$x_t = \Theta_{x,t} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t} \right)^{\sigma_x},$$

where the coefficient $\Theta_{x,t}$ depends on parameters and taxes and the exponent σ_x on parameters only.

Proposition 1. *In economic equilibrium we have the following:*

i. Aggregate labor is decreasing in τ_t, ϵ and γ_0 and increasing in τ_{t+1}, θ. Aggregate savings are decreasing in τ_t, τ_{t+1}, and θ and are increasing in ϵ and γ_0.

ii. Labor income inequality and relative labor supply are independent of pension policy and given by

$$\frac{\eta_i h_{t,i}}{h_t} = \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi} \Gamma_h}, \qquad \Gamma_h \equiv \sum_i \frac{\gamma_i \eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}. \tag{12}$$

iii. Savings of formal households relative to average savings are independent of τ_t and linear in τ_{t+1}:

$$\frac{s_{t,i}}{s_t} = \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}} \frac{1}{\Gamma_h} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0 \epsilon} \frac{1-\theta}{1+\beta} \left(\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi} \Gamma_h} - 1 \right). \tag{13}$$

iv. When $\tau_{t+1} = 0$ or with fully Bismarckian pensions ($\theta = 1$), the heterogeneity in savings exactly matches labor income inequality. An increase in τ_{t+1} or a decrease in θ amplifies the spread in private savings.

v. Informal savings increase in τ_t and θ and decrease in τ_{t+1} and ϵ; current taxes also raise their ratio to formal savings.

Part i of proposition 1 states that current taxes reduce labor supply and savings, while future taxes increase labor supply, since higher expected benefits make work more

attractive, and reduce the need to save. A higher θ increases labor supply for the same reason; with GHH preferences this raises the marginal utility of $\tilde{c}_{1,t}$ and so, through the Euler equation, lowers aggregate savings. A higher ϵ shifts future benefits toward informal households and lowers the benefit formal households expect, so that they save more and work less, and a larger share of informal households has the same effects.

Parts ii and iii reduce the state space of the politico-economic equilibrium, as the next subsection shows. Part iv implies that higher future taxes or a lower θ, when pensions are redistributive, widen the dispersion of savings and thus of private wealth. Part v works through the universal pension, since informal earnings do not respond to pension policy. The pension's present value to an informal household is proportional to formal savings, with a factor that rises with future taxes and ϵ: current taxes and a higher θ, which lower formal savings, therefore raise informal savings, while future taxes and a higher ϵ raise the present value of the pension and lower them.

3.2 Politico-Economic Equilibrium

In a Markov equilibrium the distributions of past savings and past labor supply are in principle state variables of the political choice of the tax rate. Part ii of proposition 1 removes the distribution of labor supply, since taxes do not move relative labor supply.[9] If informal households save, their past savings are a further state, and one that both current and future taxes move. For the analytical results we therefore take informal households to be hand-to-mouth: they do not save, so that their Euler condition (6d) does not apply, and when old they receive an endowment tied to the informal wage, which can be read as work in old age at a lower productivity.[10]

With log-GHH preferences and hand-to-mouth informal households, the policymaker maximizes

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{W}_t(z_t, \tau_t; \tau_t^{+1}(z_{t+1})) = \sum_i \gamma_i \mu_i \left[\omega \ln\left(c_{2,t}^i\right) + \nu_t \left(\ln\left(\tilde{c}_{1,t}^i\right) + \beta \ln\left(c_{2,t+1}^i\right)\right)\right] \\ + \gamma_0 \mu_0 \left[\omega \ln\left(\tilde{c}_{2,t}^0\right) + \nu_t \left(\ln\left(\tilde{c}_{1,t}^0\right) + \beta \ln\left(c_{2,t+1}^0\right)\right)\right] \qquad (14)\end{aligned}$$

Proposition 2. *In politico-economic equilibrium with hand-to-mouth informal households, all consumption functions are log-separable in the endogenous state variables, making policy only a function of parameters, including system characteristics and demographics. Politico-economic equilibrium taxes are increasing in ω and decreasing in ν_t, the latter whenever the aggregate marginal support of formal retirees for the tax is positive at the equilibrium, as it is without a universal pension. With equal propensities to vote,*

[9] This property of GHH preferences also holds under CRRA preferences (appendix A.1).

[10] We model old-age income as an endowment of goods to keep the model as symmetric with the general case as possible.

and with retirees' savings consistent with the tax and the design they anticipated, taxes are increasing in income inequality and, if no formal type borrows against its pension, decreasing in θ, given the continuation policy when there is a universal pension. The effect of an unanticipated change in ϵ is ambiguous and depends on the pension's share of consumption of informal and formal retirees.

The economic equilibrium is log-separable in the aggregate states (appendix A.2), and the one remaining vector of states, the distribution of formal households' savings $s_{t-1,i}/s_{t-1}$, is a function of parameters and the current tax alone; by the same token, the distribution carried into the next period does not depend on the current choice (appendix B.1). Despite two dimensions of pension design and heterogeneous households, the politico-economic equilibrium therefore shares the property of Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008), Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2012), Song (2011), and Uchida and Ono (2024), among others, that policy is a function of parameters and demographics only, although the equilibrium conditions are more complex and in most cases can be solved only numerically. Appendix B.1 shows that the equilibrium tax is unique for any Frisch elasticity up to $1/(1-2\alpha)$ (proposition 3), and that with a single type of formal household and no informal households it has a closed form, which with inelastic labor is the tax of Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008).

Notwithstanding the orthogonality of current policy with state variables, the trade-offs underlying the equilibrium tax rates are dynamic in nature as they relate contemporaneous policy decisions to capital accumulation and thus future wages and tax revenue. The tractability of the model comes from specifying functional forms that render the factor price elasticities and the derivatives of the indirect utility functions orthogonal to the capital stock and relative labor supply and relative savings decisions independent of current taxes.

The comparative statics in ω and ν_t mirror those in Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008) and Song (2011), and the latter also shows that the equilibrium tax rate increases with income inequality. A distinct contribution to the politico-economic literature on social security is the prediction that a more Bismarckian benefit formula weakens political support for taxation. The reason for this is that a higher θ shifts benefits from low-income to high-income retirees, and the former, with their higher marginal utility, weigh more in the political objective, so that retirees' support for taxes declines in the aggregate. The results for θ and for inequality both compare economies in which retirees saved for their own income and for the design in force, and both rest on the response of these savings. A retiree who anticipated a more Bismarckian design offset the fraction $1/(1+\beta)$ of the change in its pension through its savings, so that retirees' support for the tax weighs the transfer the design performs by relative income over squared consumption in retirement, a weight that, with equal propensities to vote, falls with income if no type borrows against its pension. With savings held at their inherited values, inequality would not move the tax

under flat benefits, and the weight would be the savings share over squared consumption, which need not fall with income, since poorer retirees save less relative to their income when part of the pension is flat; the sign of the effect of θ would then be open (appendix B.1).

A higher ϵ shifts benefits from formal to informal retirees. With log utility a retiree's support for the tax is the pension's share of their consumption, so the shift raises the support of informal retirees and lowers that of formal ones (appendix B.1 gives the exact condition for the sign). Taxes rise when informal retirees are poorer than formal ones, by more than the small elasticity of the tax base with respect to the tax rate, and the pension is a comparable share of their consumption, as in Argentina (section 5), because their smaller pension then rises in a larger proportion than formal pensions fall.

When informal households save or preferences are CRRA, the tax rate depends on the state and the equilibrium has to be solved numerically; section 4 describes how.

4 Numerical Methods

This section describes how the politico-economic equilibria of sections 5–7 are computed, with the algorithms and the code in the technical documentation (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026). The quantitative politico-economic literature computes a time-invariant policy function (Krusell and Ríos-Rull 1999; Forni 2005; Song 2011) or compares steady states across demographic scenarios (Galasso 1999). Along a demographic transition, however, the Markov policy function is date-specific, since the policymaker at t faces its own mix of cohorts, ν_t, and a continuation policy set further along the transition. The distinction is immaterial in the equilibrium of proposition 2, which carries no state, but not under CRRA preferences or with informal savers, where the continuation reaches the tax through the state, or in the design choice, where a design chosen at t is weighed against the electorate of $t+1$.[11] We therefore compute date-specific policy functions by backward induction from a date T (appendix D), the end of a finite horizon or the start of a steady state in an infinite one. For a large T the two agree away from T. We set $T = 2200$ (2190 for Argentina): a steady state from T on, or a T two periods earlier or three periods later, moves the tax rates of the calibration year and the period after by at most 0.03 p.p., and the chosen design by less than 0.001 (table 6). We report the finite-horizon solution, which approximates the Markov equilibrium in the limit of finite-horizon economies.

In the general case with CRRA preferences, the distribution of labor supply remains

[11] In our applications, the distinction has a modest effect on results: a time-invariant policy function, solved at each date's own ν_t and applied along the projected path, misses the tax rate by roughly 0.2 p.p., and by up to 0.3 p.p. in the Argentine calibration at the lowest intertemporal elasticity, and misplaces the design by up to 0.074 (online appendix).

independent of policy (part ii of proposition 1) and the distribution of past savings is pinned down by the current tax together with past aggregate savings (appendix A.1). The distribution of past savings matters for the political problem, but since it depends only on the current tax and past aggregate savings we can eliminate it from the state space, keeping only the level of past savings s_{t-1}: we work with the first order condition in τ_t derived with the distribution of past savings held fixed, and then replace it with the one consistent distribution for each candidate tax and for each state s_{t-1}. Informal savers add the ratio $s_{t-1,0}/s_{t-1}$ of informal to formal savings to the state space, which also depends on τ_{t-1} (appendix B.2).

When the policy function features one or more states, the current tax moves the states and affects future policy choices. We measure the marginal effect by numerical differentiation of the $t+1$ solution grid, which the backward induction has already computed. A first order condition can have several roots, some of them minima, and the optimum can lie at a corner where it has none, so we evaluate the condition on a grid of taxes and test the corners and all its roots. A candidate passes if it maximizes the political objective with its own consistent distribution held fixed. Along the equilibrium path, the largest gap between the computed tax rate and the root of the first order condition with its derivatives in the tax converged is 0.003 p.p. at $\rho = 0.5$ and 0.001 p.p. at $\rho = 2$ in the U.S. calibration, and 0.014 p.p. in the Argentine one (table 8 in appendix D).

Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008) establish uniqueness in the limit of finite-horizon economies, but their argument does not carry over: their model has a representative household in each cohort, and so no distribution of savings to make consistent with the tax, and neither informal savers nor a choice of design. Under log-GHH preferences, with no informal households, or with hand-to-mouth ones and $\xi(1-2\alpha) \leq 1$, which our calibration satisfies by far, exactly one candidate passes at every date (proposition 3 in appendix B). At the distribution of savings consistent with a higher tax, retirees below mean income have saved less, which strengthens their support for the tax, but the income from their savings falls by less than their pension rises, so that the first order condition evaluated at consistent distributions is strictly decreasing in the tax. Under CRRA preferences or with informal savers we check uniqueness numerically, and the solver records at every state and date how many candidates pass.[12]

Each reported path starts from the steady state under the first period's policy. Parameters whose targets are equilibrium outcomes, such as the discount factor and the political weight of the old, are calibrated by re-solving the equilibrium path at each trial value until the targets of sections 5 and 6 hold in the calibration year.

Under log preferences the choice of the design in section 7 adds no state either. The

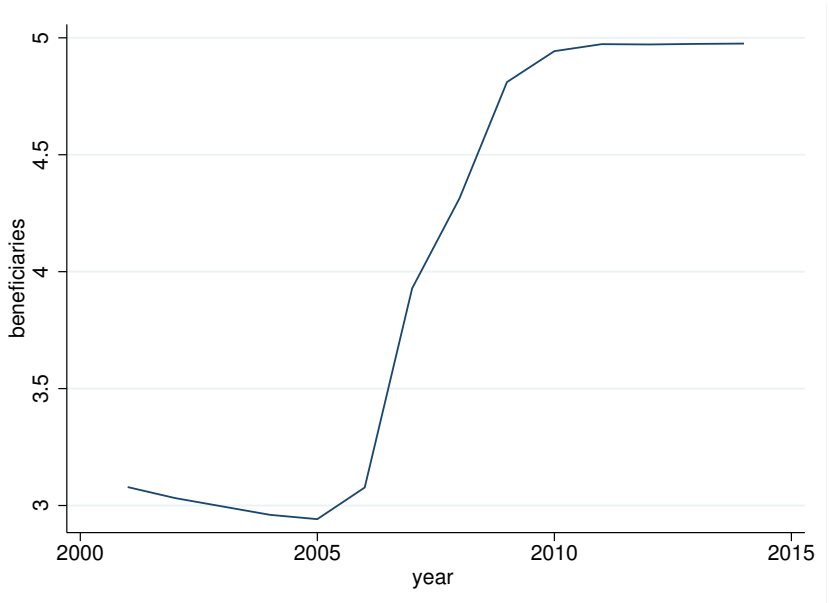
[12]Several passing candidates would be ranked by payoff, an assumption about equilibrium selection that none of our reported equilibria requires: exactly one passes at every state and date of every solve behind our results, except at one state and date in the choice of the design, where none does. Appendix D describes the exception and reports the counts by solve in table 7, the online appendix file by file.

design chosen at t applies from $t+1$ and depends neither on the design chosen in the previous period, which sets current benefits, nor on aggregate savings (proposition 5 in appendix C.4), and the tax at each candidate design is found as above, without a state. Each date's choice is therefore a search over a grid of designs. Under CRRA preferences neither property survives: the equilibrium is a backward recursion over policy functions of the state (s_{t-1}, θ_t).

5 Pension System Reform in Argentina

Argentina is a middle-income country with high labor informality. In 1994 the social security system was reformed tying full benefits to 30 years of contributions, which left about a third of the elderly without a pension by 2004.[13] From 2005 a series of tax amnesties let workers with shorter contribution records draw a pension. They added 2.7 million beneficiaries by 2011 (Rofman and Apella 2015), raising the number of pensioners from about 3 to 5 million (figure 5.1) and the coverage of the elderly from 68% to over 90% (Rofman and Oliveri 2012). Thus, in a few years, Argentina experienced a significant increase in non-contributive pensions: Between 2005 and 2010 social security spending increased by 1.9% of GDP with most of this increase, 1.8% of GDP, due to the tax amnesties (Cetrángolo and Grushka 2020).

Figure 5.1: Pension coverage in Argentina



Note: Beneficiaries of the national pension system (SIPA) and of non-contributive old-age pensions, annual averages in millions. Source: Cetrángolo and Grushka (2020, table 6), from the Boletín Estadístico de la Seguridad Social.

[13] The reform also let workers opt for a fully funded system, whose funds were nationalized in December 2008.

The following outlines the calibration procedure and presents the main results from the pension reform. The reform is the only change in the universal pension ϵ that the paper considers, and it is taken as given: when the electorate also chooses the design, in section 7, it chooses θ and not ϵ. Appendix E keeps calibration details and the online appendix provides supplementary evidence from the reform.[14]

Calibration. We calibrate the model with informal savers to Argentina before the reforms and read the tax amnesties as an increase in ϵ. Informal households work when young and save for retirement, facing the same rate of return on savings as formal households. A model period is thirty years, the calibration year is 2010, and every household has the same propensity to vote. Table 1 reports the result. The pre-reform $\epsilon = 0.21$ is the basic pension of retirees without a full contribution record, 70% of the benefit of the least productive formal workers, in units of the average formal benefit and discounted because it starts five to ten years after the formal retirement age, and $\gamma_0 = 0.47$, informal households per formal household, puts informal households at 32% of all, the share of the population over 65 without a pension before the reform (Rofman and Oliveri 2012). Since some of these households would never have drawn the basic pension, which required ten years of contributions, we also report the reform from a pre-reform $\epsilon = 0$ (appendix E). The design $\theta = 0.84$ matches the observed ratio of replacement rates at mean and half-mean income. The reform raises ϵ to the universal level $\epsilon^U = 1 - \theta + \theta\eta_1 h_{t-1,1}/h_{t-1}$ of section 2, at which informal retirees receive the benefit of the least productive formal ones. We impose a formal-sector capital share of $\alpha = 0.35$, between the values implied by the survey's informal earnings and by shadow-economy estimates of informal output, a Frisch elasticity of $\xi = 0.30$, and a ratio of workers to retirees ν_t from thirty-year gross growth of the total population in the estimates and medium-variant projections of the United Nations' World Population Prospects 2024, as in Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008).

The remaining parameters are identified jointly with the equilibrium path. The formal productivities η_i match the income distribution across the four formal quartiles of the survey, with a taste for leisure X common to them whose level is pinned by the observed formal workweek of 42.5 hours.[15] Relative hours across quartiles are then a prediction, which reproduces the survey's ranking and overstates the hours of the top quartile, 1.18 against 1.10 times the formal average. Four parameters are solved against four targets in 2010: β against a capital-output ratio of 3.23, ω against an equivalent social security tax

[14] Appendix E holds the data, the identifying formulas and the sources of the calibration. The online appendix has additional evidence including how the design (ϵ, θ) shapes equilibrium outcomes and how different calibrations affect results.

[15] Identifying one X_i per quartile instead takes the survey's relative hours as data and leaves the level of hours unidentified (appendix E.5). Since the productivity distribution reaches the aggregates only through a sum that both calibrations normalize to one, only η_i and X_i differ, and every result of this section is the same under both.

rate of 11.8%, which is pension spending of 7.1% of GDP before the 2001 crisis divided by formal labor income, 60% of GDP once GDP includes the output of informal households, and η_0 and X_0 against the informal households' income and hours relative to the formal average.

Table 1: Calibration, Argentina

Parameter	**Value**	**Target**
ϵ (*pre*-reform)	0.21	Basic pension, 70% of the minimum, discounted
θ	0.84	Replacement rate dispersion
α	0.35	Factor income shares
ν_t	$[1.65, 0.96]$	30-year gross population growth rates
ξ	0.30	Elasticity of labor supply
β	0.67	Capital–output ratio of 3.23
X	1.92	Average formal workweek of 42.5 hours
η_i	$[0.64, 0.90, 1.14, 1.87]$	Income distribution
γ_0	0.47	Elderly without a pension, 32% of households
ω	1.50	Social security tax of 11.8%
η_0	0.340	Informal relative income, eq. (E.1)
X_0	0.795	Informal relative working hours

Note: Our default specification relies on $\rho = 1$.

The reform. Table 2 reports the effect in 2010 of an unanticipated and permanent rise of ϵ to ϵ^U under log-GHH preferences, first with the tax rate held at its pre-reform path and then chosen politically. Since the rise is unanticipated, the retirees of 2010 enter it with the savings they made under the pre-reform system. We find that taxes increase, which drives down savings and labor supply. With taxes held fixed, the new pensions are paid for by cutting formal benefits by 12.7%, and formal households save more and work marginally less, since the reform lowers the benefit they expect (proposition 1); informal households, who now hold a claim on the pension system, save less.

In 2010 the model predicts that the social security tax rate rises by 2.0 p.p., enough to pay for the new pensions and to raise formal benefits by 1.5%, so that none of the expansion is financed by cuts. The reason for this is that the reform moves benefits toward informal retirees, who are poorer than formal ones and value benefits more at the margin.[16] The tax response builds over time, to 3.5 p.p. above the pre-reform path by 2040, because informal households, now covered, save less for retirement and as retirees

[16]The tax also rises when informal households are hand-to-mouth, consistent with condition (B.11) in appendix B.1.

demand more taxation. In 2010 the savings rate falls by 0.4 p.p. of GDP and the average workweek by a quarter of an hour.

Two moments of the episode can be set against the model, the rise in pension spending and the response of household savings. Pension spending rises by 1.2% of GDP, and spending on informal retirees, which corresponds to the cost of the amnesties, by 1.1% of GDP, in each case about three fifths of its observed counterpart: the 1.9% of GDP by which spending rose between 2005 and 2010 and the 1.8% of GDP that the amnesties added.[17] The comparison depends on how the pre-reform system is read. If no informal retiree drew a pension before the reform, so that the model is recalibrated at $\epsilon = 0$ and the reform raises ϵ from zero, the tax rises by 4.2 p.p., pension spending by 2.5% of GDP and spending on informal retirees by 2.0% of GDP, more than observed: the two readings bracket the data. Gonzalez-Rozada and Ruffo (2016) compare the national expenditure surveys of 2004/05 and 2012/13 by a difference-in-differences in which a household's treatment is its predicted probability of drawing a pension through the amnesties. Household savings, income less consumption, fall for households whose head is of retirement age and, in a specification by cohort, for households of every age: a probability of treatment higher by ten points lowers savings by about 2 to 4%. The model's counterpart of the effect on younger households is the difference between the shares of disposable labor income that informal and formal young households save, which falls by 5.4 p.p., 5.2 p.p. of it with the tax held fixed; retired households do not save in the model.

Table 2: Pension system reform, year 2010

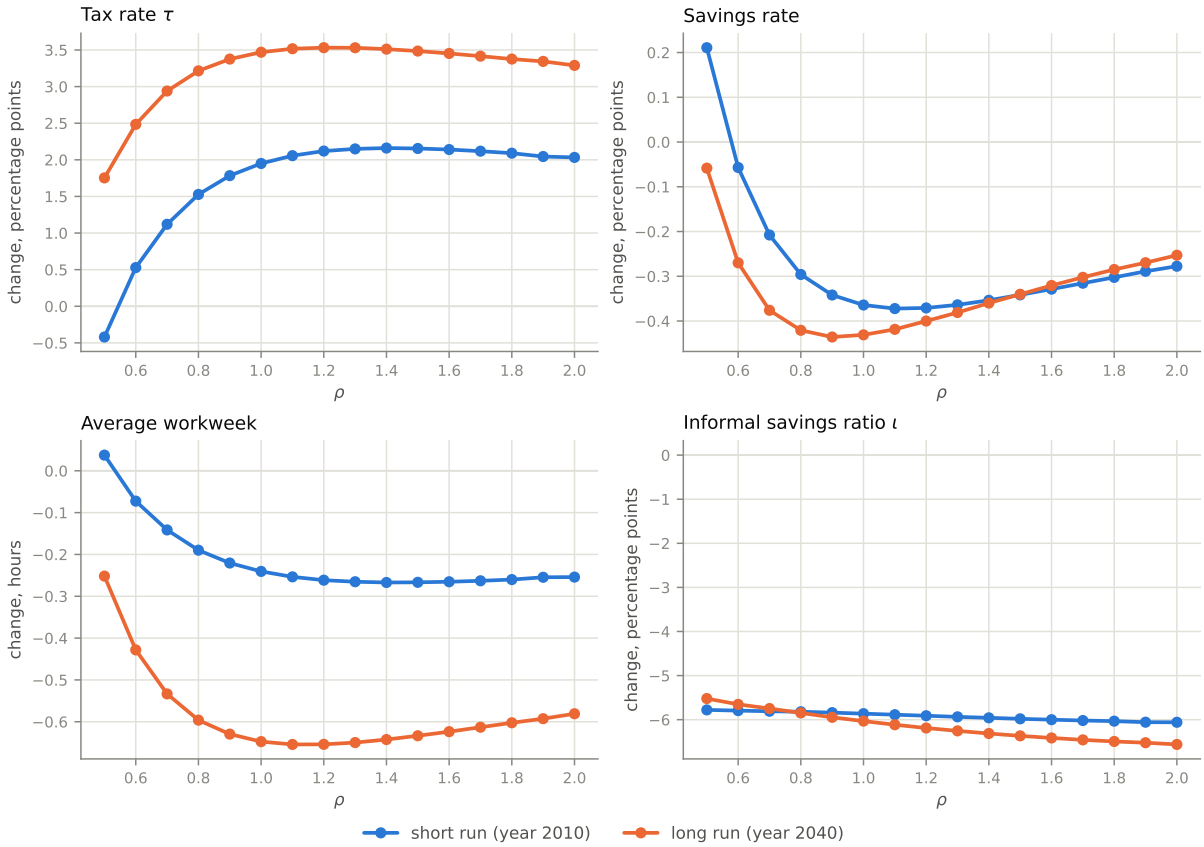
Scenario	**Tax rate**	**Savings rate**	**Avg. workweek (hours)**	**Formal benefits**
Baseline	11.81%	13.33%	42.54	–
Economic Equilibrium	11.81%	13.64%	42.46	−12.70%
Full effect	13.76%	12.96%	42.30	+1.46%

Note: The reform permanently raises ϵ to $1-\theta+\theta\eta_1 h_1/h$ in the calibration year, unanticipated. The "Economic Equilibrium" scenario solves for the new economic equilibrium path with taxes as in the Baseline scenario, but with the new permanent ϵ; the "Full effect" scenario lets taxes be determined by the politico-economic equilibrium. $\rho = 1$. The savings rate is savings relative to GDP, formal plus informal output. Formal benefits: the change in the benefit of every formal retiree against the Baseline.

[17] The observed rise starts from 2005, when spending had fallen to 5.2% of GDP because only minimum pensions were adjusted for inflation after the 2001 crisis, while the model's pre-reform economy is calibrated to the pre-crisis 7.1% (appendix E). The nationalization of the funded system in December 2008 moved its members and their contributions into the public system in the same window; it bears on the comparison only through spending, and the 1.8% of GDP counts the beneficiaries of the amnesties alone. Finally, a model period is thirty years, so the model's response in 2010 is a shift in spending that lasts a generation, which we compare with the shift reached within the five years of the amnesties.

The effect of the intertemporal elasticity of substitution. Since the environment has no uncertainty, we read the parameter ρ of CRRA preferences as the intertemporal elasticity of substitution (IES). The evidence on its size is inconclusive,[18] and we keep logarithmic utility as the benchmark. Figure 5.2 repeats the reform with the pre-reform economy calibrated at each ρ and traces the effects in 2010 and 2040 for taxes, savings rates, average workweek, and informal savings.

Figure 5.2: Short- and long-run effects of the pension reform as a function of ρ



Note: Each panel is the change against the pre-reform path of the same ρ. The savings rate is savings relative to GDP, formal plus informal output, and the informal savings ratio ι is the savings of an informal household relative to the average savings of formal households.

The effects of the pension reform are nonlinear in ρ. For an IES between 1 and 2 the results stay close to the log benchmark: the tax rises by 2.0 to 2.2 p.p. in 2010, the workweek shortens by roughly 0.25 hours, and the fall in the savings rate shrinks from 0.4 to 0.3 p.p. of GDP. Results are similar in 2040, albeit with tax and workweek effects amplified. Below log utility the responses of the tax rate, savings and hours shrink, and the tax response changes sign between $\rho = 0.6$ and $\rho = 0.5$, at about 0.54: at $\rho = 0.5$ the tax rate falls by 0.4 p.p. on impact, the savings rate rises by 0.2 p.p. of GDP and

[18] Estimates from aggregate consumption data are low, which Guvenen (2006) reconciles with higher values from output and wealth data through limited asset market participation, and asset-pricing models with Epstein–Zin preferences and long-run or disaster risk require an IES above one (Bansal and Yaron 2004; Barro 2009).

the workweek lengthens slightly, although by 2040 the tax is 1.8 p.p. above its pre-reform path. Only the fall in the informal savings ratio, 5.8 to 6.1 p.p., is about the same at every ρ. The reversal lies where the calibration is least reliable: it needs a thirty-year discount factor above one, 1.44 at $\rho = 0.5$ and 1.12 at $\rho = 0.6$ (online appendix), and it is less precise there than elsewhere on the grid.

A decomposition of the 2010 tax condition by group shows that the reversal does not come from the formal young, whose resistance to a higher tax is about the same at $\rho = 0.5$ as at log, but from informal households.[19] With a low IES the informal retirees' marginal utility falls faster as their pension rises, so they ask for a smaller rise in the tax. And the informal young, who will now draw a pension, withdraw more of their support for a higher tax than at log, since a higher tax lowers savings and with them the value of that pension. At $\rho = 0.5$ the second force offsets nearly all of the first, and the formal retirees, whose benefits fall at a given tax, tip the balance.

Since Gonzalez-Rozada and Ruffo (2016) compare households, their estimate does not discriminate between values of the IES: the share of disposable labor income that informal young households save falls against that of formal ones by 4.9 to 5.4 p.p. at $\rho = 0.5$, 1 and 2 alike. Read as a fall in the aggregate savings rate, their sign excludes only values of ρ near 0.5, below about 0.6.

6 Social Security in Rich OECD Countries

In order to study the determinants of pensions, we now calibrate the model to three rich OECD economies that differ markedly in pension spending, demography, income inequality, voting patterns and pension design: the U.S., France and the UK. In these economies nearly every worker qualifies for a contributive pension, so we set informality aside and the design reduces to one dimension, the extent to which benefits are earnings-related.[20] To explore what characteristics shape pensions, savings rates, and labor supply, we simulate counterfactual economies that are calibrated to the U.S. with one characteristic changed at a time.

As for the Argentina case, the following outlines the main results. Appendix F and the online appendix contain more details on the calibration and supplementary evidence.[21]

[19] Each group's contribution is the change that the reform makes to its term of the first order condition at the pre-reform tax, divided by the slope of the post-reform condition between the two taxes, so that the contributions sum to the tax response. At $\rho = 1$ and $\rho = 0.5$ the informal retirees raise the tax by 8.2 and 4.3 p.p., while the informal young lower it by 2.9 and 4.0 p.p., the formal retirees by 2.7 and 0.6 p.p. and the formal young by 0.6 and 0.2 p.p.; the retirees' terms through hours contribute less than 0.2 p.p. The formal young's share of the slope is 0.37 and 0.39, the informal retirees' 0.33 and 0.51.

[20] Whitman et al. (2011) estimate that about 4% of individuals aged 62–84 in the U.S. in 2010 would never collect Social Security, most of them for lack of the 40 quarters of covered earnings needed to qualify.

[21] The online appendix holds the calibrations across the intertemporal elasticity of substitution, under the alternative treatment of the taste for leisure and with Medicare among U.S. transfers to the old, and

Calibration. We calibrate the three economies to 2020 in the same way as Argentina in section 5, with a few exceptions. First, with informality set aside, the population is split into three formal income groups. The first two groups are cut, as for Argentina, to have mean incomes of half the mean and the mean, the incomes at which the OECD's replacement rates identify θ. France's system is fully Bismarckian, $\theta = 1$ at any cuts, so we group French households at the U.S. income percentiles instead, which puts the two countries' household types in one-to-one correspondence for the counterfactuals below. Second, the discount factor β matches the U.S. thirty-year interest rate rather than a capital–output ratio and is imposed on France and the UK. Third, where the Argentine calibration gives every household the same propensity to vote, the political objective here weights each income group by its observed propensity. In the U.S. the poor vote much less than the rich, while in France the propensity to vote is nearly flat across income groups. In all three countries the tax rate is calibrated to public cash spending on pensions, the measure of figure 1.1, so U.S. Medicare enters neither the tax rate nor θ, just as public health spending does not in France and the UK (appendix F).

Table 3 reports the parameters. Population growth is highest in the U.S. and lowest in France, $\nu_{2020} = 1.34$ against 1.04, and the ratio of high to low productivity is about a third higher in the U.S. than in France, 3.08 against 2.29. The average taste for leisure is 1.9 times the U.S. level in the UK and 1.6 times in France. The calibrated political weight of the old is highest in France, 1.45, against 1.23 in the U.S. and 1.10 in the UK.

Determinants of pensions, savings, and labor supply. Figure 6.1 summarizes the counterfactuals. Each row changes one characteristic of the U.S. calibration: its pension design, population growth, income distribution, leisure preferences or voting patterns. Each panel reports the effect on the equilibrium tax rate, the savings rate and the workweek in 2020, at the three values of the intertemporal elasticity ρ considered below. The counterfactuals are guided by France and the UK, particularly France, whose households can be grouped as in the U.S. Each is a separate equilibrium path on which the changed characteristic holds throughout, so a row describes an economy that has always had that characteristic rather than the U.S. surprised in 2020.

The tax panel identifies the pension design and ageing as the main determinants of pension spending. Going from a fully Bismarckian system to a fully Beveridgean one raises the equilibrium tax rate by 6.6 p.p. at $\rho = 1$ and lowers the savings rate by 1.9 p.p. of GDP. The reason for this is that of proposition 2: flatter benefits direct more of the revenue to poorer retirees, whose higher marginal utility gives them more weight in the political objective, so retirees support a larger system. Holding taxes fixed, an increase in θ would lower savings, but the endogenous fall in taxes more than offsets this and the

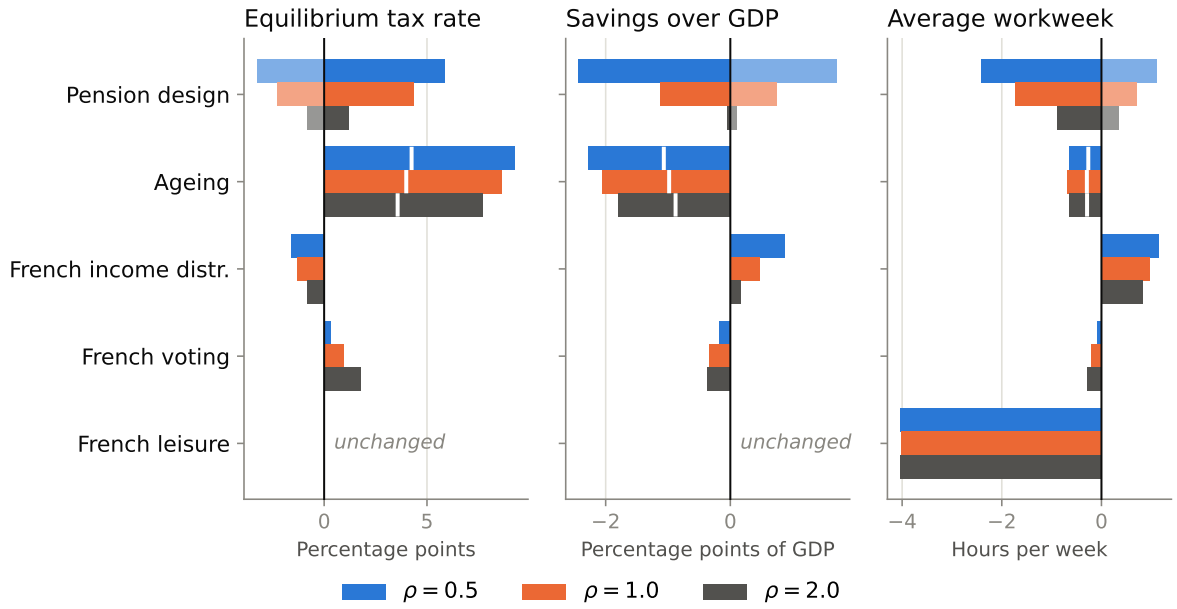
the counterfactuals of this section with the UK as the host economy and across the Frisch elasticity, each figure with the data behind it.

Table 3: Calibration, the U.S., the UK and France

Parameter	U.S.	UK	France	Identified by
θ	0.73	0.56	1.00	Replacement rate dispersion
ω	1.23	1.10	1.45	$\tau^{US} = 10.5\%$, $\tau^{UK} = 11.2\%$, $\tau^{FR} = 20.6\%$
X	4.16	7.93	6.64	Average workweek
ν_{2020}	1.34	1.17	1.04	30-year gross population growth
η_H/η_L	3.08	3.06	2.29	Relative productivity, high to low income
β		0.66		30-year interest rate (U.S.)
ρ		1		Log-GHH preferences
ξ		0.30		Frisch elasticity of labor supply
α		0.30		Capital income share

Note: X is the population-weighted mean of X_i; its level is the hours unit, pinned for France and the UK by targeting average hours relative to the U.S. rather than in levels. The lower panel is common to the three countries; β is calibrated for the U.S. and imposed on the other two.

Figure 6.1: The effect of various counterfactuals in the U.S.



Note: The online appendix repeats the figure with the UK as the host economy and gives the data behind both. In the pension-design row each bar shows both corners, measured from the baseline: $\theta = 0$ in full colour and $\theta = 1$ in the light tone. In the ageing row the bar is acute ageing and the white line across it mild ageing. The savings rate is savings relative to GDP.

net effect is positive. For labor supply, the economic-equilibrium and political effects of an increase in θ are aligned, and at $\rho = 1$ and below the tax response contributes more than the direct effect.

Population ageing is the determinant that previous studies of the politico-economic equilibrium of pension spending have highlighted: Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008) predict an increase in U.S. spending of around 3.6 p.p. towards the middle of this century because of the slowdown in population growth. In the data, including projections, ageing is more acute in France than in the UK, and much more than in the U.S. We consider two scenarios, which roughly correspond to the data for the two European countries. In the first, *mild ageing*, we halve current and projected U.S. population growth; in the second, *acute ageing*, the population is constant, $\nu_t = 1$ for all t. Acute ageing raises the tax rate by 8.7 p.p. and mild ageing by 4.0 p.p. The fall in population growth in the mild scenario is close to the one projected by Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008),[22] although their 3.6 p.p. is a change over time within one economy and our 4.0 p.p. a difference between two economies in 2020. When acute ageing drives up pension contributions significantly, this crowds out private savings by 2.0 p.p. of GDP at $\rho = 1$. Working hours fall by roughly 0.7 hours a week: the higher tax rate lowers the effective wage rate net of taxes, but this is partly offset by a capital deepening effect from ageing on wages. Thus, the net result is a modest drop in hours worked.

The characteristics that set France's households apart move the tax rate much less. At $\rho = 1$, France's flatter income distribution, imposed with θ held at its U.S. value, lowers it by 1.3 p.p.,[23] and its flatter voting profile, under which the poor vote about as often as the rich, raises it by 0.9 p.p. The voting profile moves the tax rate towards France's, but once the electorate chooses the design as well (section 7) it moves the design away from France's fully Bismarckian system, towards flat benefits. Rescaling the taste for leisure to France's level shortens the workweek by nearly the whole gap to France's and leaves every rate at the baseline, since a proportional change in X_i scales hours, output and savings together. With the UK as the host economy the effects are smaller still, and France's income distribution raises the UK's tax rate, since at the UK's income cuts France is the more unequal of the two countries (appendix F.4).

The workweek panel ranks the determinants differently. France's leisure preferences move hours most and leave every rate unchanged. Among the characteristics that move the tax rate, the pension design moves hours most, by about 1.7 hours a week at the Beveridgean corner at $\rho = 1$, while ageing, the largest effect on taxes, moves them less than France's income distribution does at every ρ. The determinants of pension spending are thus not the determinants of hours worked.

The effect of the intertemporal elasticity of substitution. In general, our results

[22] In Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008), $\nu_{2000} = 1.38$ and the projected $\nu_{2080} = 1.23$, a fall of about 0.15, similar to the fall of 0.17 in 2020 in the mild ageing scenario.

[23] We read θ off the ratio of replacement rates at mean and half-mean income, so under France's flatter income distribution the same observed ratio would imply a considerably less Bismarckian system. Re-estimating θ would bundle a change in the design into a counterfactual about inequality.

above are robust across different ρ and the overall conclusion about the determinants of pension spending, savings, and labor supply holds. The effects on the tax rate and the savings rate are amplified for lower values of ρ and dampened for higher values, modestly for ageing and much more for the income distribution; the one exception where this pattern is reversed is the French voting profile. The effect of ageing on the workweek is about the same at every ρ. The IES plays a key role in the effect of the pension design: going from $\theta = 1$ to $\theta = 0$ raises the tax rate by 9.1 p.p. at $\rho = 0.5$ and by only 2.0 p.p. at $\rho = 2$. The reason for this is that θ moves the tax rate through the difference in marginal utility between poor and rich retirees (proposition 2), and a higher IES makes marginal utility fall less steeply with consumption, so that this difference counts for less; the savings rate and the workweek follow.

The calibrated parameters absorb institutions that the model does not contain. The political weight of the old, ω, stands for the way legislation is introduced, debated and passed, and for constitutional arrangements such as whether the political system is presidential or parliamentary. The taste for leisure, X, stands for preferences and also for institutions that shape labor supply, such as unionization, collective bargaining, labor-market regulation and statutory holidays, so the large differences in X across the three countries include these institutional differences.

We now return to figure 1.1, in which pension spending and the Bismarckian index both rise as population growth falls, and neither is related to income inequality. With the design given, the model accounts for the pattern in pension spending: ageing is the main determinant of the equilibrium tax rate, and the income distribution moves it several times less.[24] The relation between the design and population growth suggests that countries respond to ageing by tying benefits more closely to earnings, which a model that holds θ fixed cannot address. Section 7 takes it up by letting the electorate choose θ as well as τ.

7 Endogenous Pension Design

Up to this point the electorate chooses the size of the pension system while its design is calibrated. In this section it chooses the design θ as well as the tax rate, with the same political objective $\mathcal{W}_t$, in the economy of section 6 without informal households. Appendix C holds the derivations, appendix G further results, appendix H the data of the cross-country test that closes the section, and the technical documentation the algorithms (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026).

[24] On the disposable-income Gini of figure 1.1, the U.S., at 0.42, is the third most unequal of the 29 countries, after Mexico and Turkey, and France, at 0.32, is the median.

7.1 The deadweight cost of redistribution

Left to choose the design in the model as it stands, the electorate chooses flat benefits. For a given revenue, flattening benefits shifts income from retirees who earned more than the average when young to those who earned less, and the political objective, which weighs retirees by their marginal utility, counts the gains of the poorer for more than the losses of the richer. Proposition 4 in appendix C.1 makes the argument exact: if the rich are no more likely to vote than the poor, an electorate that sets the design and the tax at the same time picks the Beveridgean corner, $\theta_t = 0$, whatever the tax rate, the demography and the income distribution. The same appendix extends the result to propensities to vote that rise with income by proportionally less than consumption in retirement. In the U.S. the rich do vote more often, which could in principle reverse the result, but at the U.S. calibration the electorate still picks the Beveridgean corner at every intertemporal elasticity we check, whether it sets the design together with the tax or one period ahead of the benefits it governs (appendix C.1). A design chosen once and for all, an exercise outside the Markov equilibria of section 2, is also a corner: the Beveridgean one under log preferences and the Bismarckian one at higher intertemporal elasticities.

The model does contain a cost of flat benefits. A flat benefit does not reward an extra hour of work, and at the Beveridgean corner the workweek is about 1.7 hours shorter than at the observed U.S. design (section 6). When the design is chosen ahead of the benefits it governs, the electorate weighs this cost, and at a given anticipated tax retirees, whose benefits are levied on current labor, favor an earnings-related design because of it. At U.S. inequality the cost is too weak to hold the electorate back. What the model misses is a mechanism through which flat benefits cost more than earnings-related ones on margins other than hours.

The empirical literature points to such margins. Disney (2004) splits public pension contributions in OECD countries into a part matched by benefit entitlements and a part that is not, and finds that the second lowers the labor force participation of women while the first raises it. Kumler et al. (2020) find that after Mexico's 1997 pension reform tied benefits more closely to the wages reported to the social security agency, the under-reporting of wages fell among the younger workers the reform affected. Benefits that are loosely tied to contributions thus erode the base on which contributions are levied, through participation in the formal labor market and through the reporting of earnings. The model contains neither margin; the cost we introduce below stands for the first (appendix C.2).

Summers (1989) explains why the link matters. The part of a payroll contribution that buys the contributor a benefit is closer to deferred pay than to a tax, while the part that buys nothing distorts like a tax. Specifically, with $y_i \equiv \eta_i h_{t-1,i}/h_{t-1}$ the earnings of type i relative to the mean, constant over time by part ii of proposition 1, a retiree of

type i receives $\nu_t w_t h_t \tau_t \left[\theta_t y_i + 1 - \theta_t\right]$ on past earnings $w_{t-1} y_i h_{t-1}$, that is

$$\Pi_t \, \tau_t \left[\theta_t + \frac{1-\theta_t}{y_i}\right] \text{ per unit of past earnings,} \qquad \Pi_t \equiv \frac{\nu_t w_t h_t}{w_{t-1} h_{t-1}},$$

where Π_t is the pay-as-you-go return factor: a purely earnings-related system paying the same revenue returns $\Pi_t \tau_t$ per unit of earnings to every type. The flat component moves type i away from that benchmark by

$$t_i \equiv \Pi_t \, \tau_t \, (1-\theta_t) \left(1 - \frac{1}{y_i}\right) \tag{15}$$

per unit of earnings.

We do not model participation and formality explicitly. Instead, we borrow a principle from the literature on the deadweight cost of taxation, that the excess burden of a tax rises with the square of its rate (Harberger 1964). Applied to the implicit tax of each type, it gives a loss that we take out of the revenue that reaches retirees, as a revenue-equivalent excess burden,[25] so that the budget becomes (see appendix C.2 for the derivation)

$$\nu_t w_t \tau_t h_t \, f(\theta_t, \tau_t) = \sum_i \gamma_i b_t^i, \tag{16}$$

$$f(\theta_t, \tau_t) = \exp\!\left(-\tfrac{1}{2} \, \lambda \, \tau_t \, \tilde{V} \, (1-\theta_t)^2\right), \qquad \tilde{V} \equiv \sum_i \gamma_i \frac{(y_i - 1)^2}{y_i},$$

where $\lambda \geq 0$ is a cost parameter to be calibrated, $1 - f$ the share of revenue lost and $\tilde{V}$ the dispersion of relative incomes.[26] We see this form as a reasonable place to start rather than as an exact account of participation and formality: it has the properties that the principles above suggest, and it leaves the size of the loss to the calibration. The loss vanishes when the system redistributes nothing, at $\theta_t = 1$ or when all incomes are equal, since flat and earnings-related benefits then pay everyone the same. Its share of revenue grows with the tax rate, so each unit of redistribution costs more in a larger system. And since the loss is quadratic in the flat share, the first unit of redistribution costs nothing at the margin: under log preferences the slope of the political objective at the Bismarckian corner, and the tax chosen there, are the same at every value of λ, so an electorate whose objective falls towards that corner without the cost does not choose it at any value of λ (appendix C.2).

The electorate chooses the design one period ahead: at t it sets θ_{t+1}, which governs

[25] The implicit taxes are a pure transfer in the aggregate, $\sum_i \gamma_i y_i t_i = 0$, so with a common elasticity the first-order responses of the contribution bases of taxed and subsidized types cancel in revenue. What remains is the excess burden, a welfare cost that subsidized types bear as well as taxed ones; charging it against the revenue that reaches retirees is a choice of reduced form rather than a consequence of the argument.

[26] The exponential keeps f between zero and one for any size of the system and gives back the model without the cost at $\lambda = 0$; to first order, $1 - f$ is the quadratic loss itself.

the benefits of the current young, and the loss that the design causes is taken out of those benefits.[27] A design chosen together with the tax would only re-split benefits that current retirees have already earned, and so would move no decision, while a design chosen once and for all would require a commitment that the Markov equilibria of section 2 rule out. Reforms of benefit formulas, moreover, usually apply to benefits not yet in payment. Formally, the cost only replaces θ_t and $1-\theta_t$ by $f\theta_t$ and $f(1-\theta_t)$ in the equilibrium of the previous sections (appendix C.3). Since it scales both components of the benefit alike, it cancels from the ratio of replacement rates that identifies the design in section 6, and the observed U.S. design is still $\theta^* = 0.728$. In the tax condition it adds one factor: a larger system loses a larger share of its revenue, so a retiree gains less from a higher tax than the revenue it raises. And at a given anticipated tax, a more earnings-related design now also enlarges the benefits the young will receive, because less of the revenue that pays them is lost; this gain is what can stop the electorate short of the Beveridgean corner.[28] Under log preferences, the design chosen at t depends neither on the design inherited nor on savings (proposition 5 in appendix C.4), so each date's choice is a search over designs without a state (section 4).

7.2 Calibration and the determinants of the design

Calibration. We calibrate the cost parameter so that the electorate re-elects the observed design. Concretely, the target is θ_{2020}, set by the electorate of 1990 on an equilibrium path along which every design from the first period on is chosen, and β and ω are recalibrated at every trial value of λ, so that the targets of section 6 still hold with the cost in place. Only the design of 2020 is targeted; every other design along the path is an outcome of the model.

Table 4 reports the calibration at each intertemporal elasticity. At the calibrated design the loss is a small share of revenue, at most 4.2% $(1-f(\theta^*))$, because it is quadratic in the flat share and the observed design is close to the Bismarckian corner. What the calibration pins down is the cost at the margin, and there it bites harder: at the tax rate of 2020, a design 0.1 flatter would lose 7.7% of revenue at $\rho = 0.5$, 3.5% at $\rho = 1$ and 0.8% at $\rho = 2$. Across the three elasticities the calibrated cost parameter λ varies by a factor of

[27] The participation and formality responses that the loss stands for occur earlier, when the young work, and erode the base that pays the retirees of that period. Booked there, the loss of a design would fall on current retirees rather than on the cohort whose benefits it governs, and each period's budget would depend on the design and the tax of the next period. We book it in the period of the benefits, where the implicit tax (15) falls, so that each budget depends on the policy of its own period. The choice bears on the weight the political objective gives the loss, since current retirees and the young enter it with different weights.

[28] The anticipated tax responds to the design as well, and the equilibrium accounts for the response (appendix C.3). At the U.S. choice under log preferences it adds to the gain: of what offsets the pull of the design towards flat benefits at a given loss share and tax, the saving on the loss supplies about 70% and the response of the anticipated tax about 30%.

about nine and a half, and the share of revenue that a completely flat benefit would lose $(1 - f(0))$ by a factor of about seven, since the share lost rises less than in proportion to λ. The cost parameter falls as the elasticity rises, because a higher elasticity strengthens the forward-looking stakes in an earnings-related design, and less cost is needed to keep the electorate at the observed level. At every elasticity λ lies more than an order of magnitude above what participation and taxable-income elasticities alone would imply, so the cost also stands in for administrative, evasion and political costs of redistribution that the model does not contain (appendix C.2). The parameter calibrated on the U.S. accounts for about a quarter of the distance from the U.S. design to the UK's and to France's, whose corner no value of the parameter reproduces (appendix G.1).

Table 4: The calibrated cost of redistribution for the U.S.

ρ	λ	ω	$1 - f(\theta^*)$	$1 - f(0)$
0.5	25.082	1.84	4.2%	43.7%
1.0	11.345	1.28	1.9%	22.9%
2.0	2.643	1.11	0.4%	5.9%

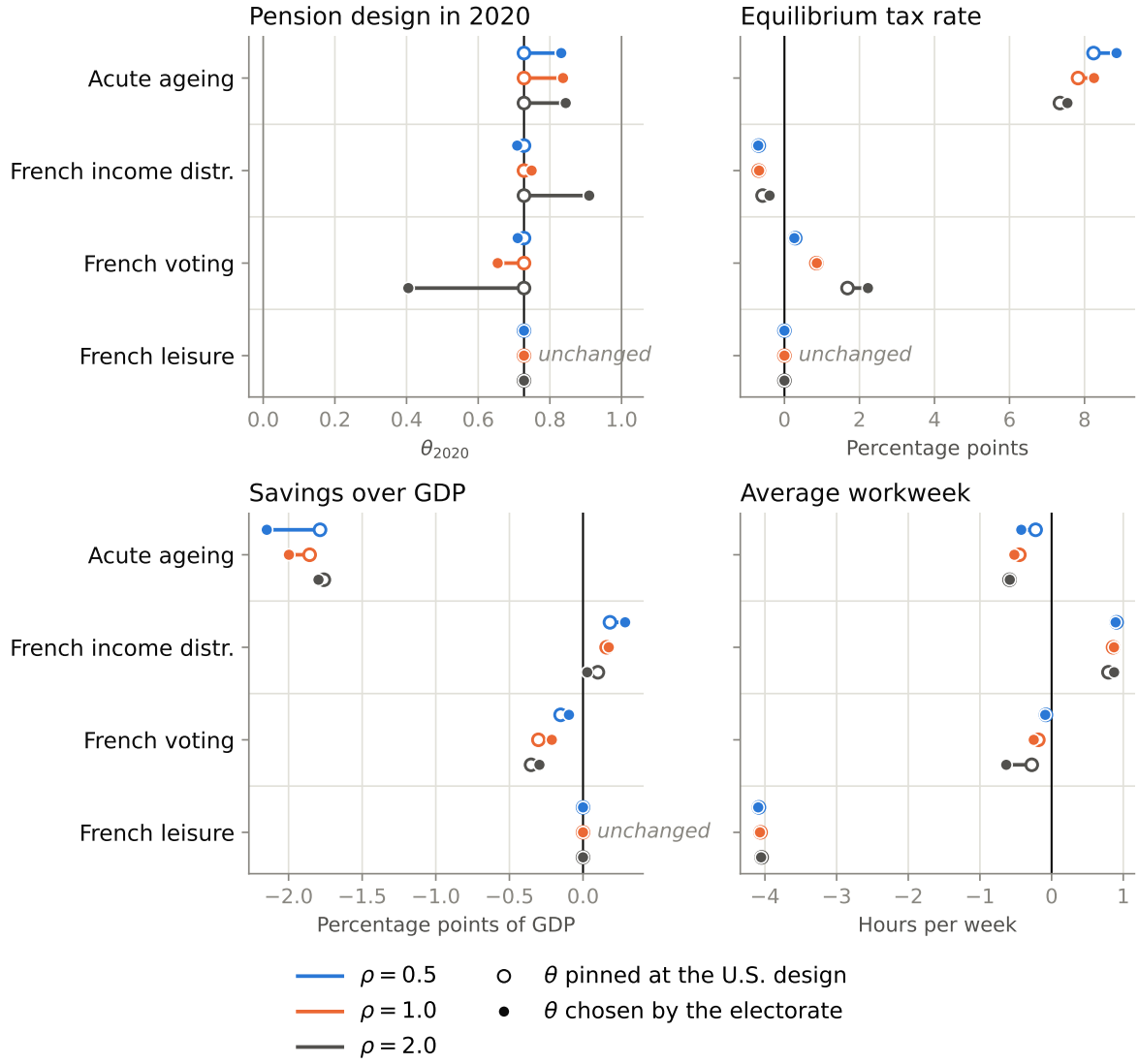
Note: The cost is that of equation (16), with $\theta^* = 0.728$ and $\tilde{V} = 0.436$ at every ρ. $1 - f(\theta^*)$ and $1 - f(0)$ are the shares of revenue lost in 2020 at the observed design and at a flat benefit, both at the 2020 tax rate. β and ω are recalibrated with λ.

Determinants of the pension design. Figure 7.1 takes the counterfactuals of section 6 to the economy with the endogenous pension design: acute ageing and France's income distribution, voting patterns and taste for leisure, each imposed on the U.S. calibration over the whole horizon and read in 2020. Every counterfactual is read twice, with the design pinned at θ^* and with the design chosen. Because the cost is present in both, the pinned reading departs from figure 6.1. Ageing still moves the tax rate several times more than any other characteristic,[29] but France's income distribution lowers it by only 0.7 p.p. at $\rho = 0.5$ and 1, about half as much as there, and at $\rho = 1$ by less than France's voting profile raises it.

First, the results from section 6 about the determinants of the size of the pension system, savings and labor supply remain mostly unchanged. Ageing, however, crowds out private savings more with the design chosen than with it pinned, in particular for low values of ρ. Second, the panel on the pension design shows that ageing consistently ties benefits more closely to earnings, that the French voting profile moves the design towards more flat benefits, and that a more equal income distribution moves the design little except at $\rho = 2$.

[29] With the design pinned at $\rho = 1$, acute ageing raises the tax rate by 7.8 p.p. rather than 8.7 p.p., since the cost makes a larger system worth less to retirees at the margin.

Figure 7.1: The effect of various counterfactuals with the design chosen



Note: The model is recalibrated for each ρ under the cost equation (16).

Ageing consistently ties benefits more closely to earnings through two forces. First, ageing gives retirees more weight in the political objective, and at a given anticipated tax retirees prefer a design that raises current labor supply, on which their benefits are levied, which is the more earnings-related one. Second, the higher tax rate associated with ageing raises the loss on every unit of redistribution, since the share of revenue lost grows with the size of the system. Thus, the higher tax increases the incentive to make pension benefits more earnings-related, consistent with the evidence from figure 1.1.

How much of the response the second force supplies depends on the form of the cost. The cost parameter absorbs the ratio of the pay-as-you-go return factor to the market return, Π_t/R_t, which falls as the population ages (appendix C.2). A cost that keeps this ratio grows less with ageing, and under it acute ageing raises the design by about 70% as much as under the cost (16), at each of the three elasticities. A cost attached to the

design itself (online appendix) does not grow with the size of the system at all. Under it acute ageing raises the design by 0.035 at $\rho = 1$, against 0.109, so the size of the system accounts for about two thirds of the response there, for more at $\rho = 0.5$ and for about a third at $\rho = 2$. Under all three costs, mild and acute ageing make the design more Bismarckian at every elasticity.

A more equal income distribution moves the design through three forces, whose balance depends on the intertemporal elasticity of substitution. First, compressing incomes shrinks the gain that poorer young voters expect from flat benefits in their own retirement, while the stake in an earnings-related design that works through labor supply does not depend on the dispersion of incomes, which pushes the design towards more Bismarckian benefits. Second, compressing incomes makes flat benefits cheaper, since the share of revenue lost scales with the dispersion of relative incomes, which France's distribution halves, from 0.436 to 0.218. Third, it lowers the tax rate, and with it the share of revenue that every unit of redistribution loses. The second and third forces push the design towards more Beveridgean benefits and are strongest at low elasticities, where the calibrated cost parameter is largest (table 4), and the first is strongest at high elasticities, where the stake through labor supply is strongest. A more equal distribution therefore lowers the design slightly at $\rho = 0.5$, where the first two forces nearly offset each other and the third supplies most of the fall, raises it slightly at $\rho = 1$, and raises it by much more at $\rho = 2$.[30]

7.3 The OECD cross-section

We return to figure 1.1, in which pension spending and the Bismarckian index both rise as population growth falls and neither is related to income inequality. With the design given, section 6 accounts for the pattern in spending. With the design chosen as well, the counterfactuals above point to one political process behind both: ageing raises the tax rate and ties benefits more closely to earnings at every intertemporal elasticity, while the income distribution moves the tax rate little and moves the design in a direction that depends on the elasticity. Whether this process reproduces the cross-section is a quantitative question. At a given demography a more Bismarckian design lowers the tax (proposition 2), so the rise of spending with the index has to come from demography moving both.

The index of figure 1.1 and the design are two scales for one object. A retiree's replacement rate at relative income y is $\Pi_t \tau_t \left[\theta_t + (1 - \theta_t)/y\right]$ (section 7.1), so the ratio of

[30] Imposing France's distribution in three steps separates the forces: first everywhere but in the cost, whose share of revenue lost at each design is held at its U.S. value, then on the dispersion of relative incomes in the cost, and last on the tax rate in the cost. The first step raises the design by 0.128, 0.149 and 0.216 at $\rho = 0.5$, 1 and 2. The second lowers it by 0.130, 0.113 and 0.031, and the third by 0.017, 0.015 and 0.003. The split depends on the order of the steps: imposed alone, France's dispersion in the cost lowers the U.S. design by 0.192 at $\rho = 1$.

the replacement rates at mean and at half mean earnings is $I = 1/(2 - \theta_t)$. It runs from 1/2 at the Beveridgean corner to 1 at the Bismarckian one, and neither the size of the system nor the cost enters it. The two scales agree only at the corners: a unit of θ is worth I^2 units of the index, about 0.6 at the U.S. design. On the index, acute ageing raises the U.S. design by 0.07 to 0.08 across the three elasticities, and the projected demography raises it by about 0.06 from 2020 to 2110 (appendix G.2), against a cross-section that spans 0.50 to 1.

We take the model to the 26 countries of the figure in which at most a quarter of employment is informal, which leaves out Mexico, Turkey and Korea. Each country enters with its own population growth, income distribution and observed design, measured in the same way for every country, the U.S. included; everything else, from the political weight of the old and the cost parameter to the propensities to vote, is held at its U.S. value, under log preferences (appendix H). For each country the model predicts the tax rate of 2020 at the observed design and the design in force in 2020, chosen by the electorate of 1990, which is the design that the calibration of λ targets.[31] Data and model are regressed on the variables of figure 1.1, with the model's design converted to the index.

Table 5 sets the slopes of the model beside those of the data. The model reproduces the sign of the three relations that are significant in the data. Spending falls with population growth, at a slope 1.3 times that of the data, and so does the index, less steeply, −0.28 against −0.45. Spending therefore rises with the index, as in the data, although at a given demography a more Bismarckian design lowers the tax: in the model the relation runs through demography, which moves the size of the system and its design together. Its slope is 2.4 times that of the data, since the model's designs vary much less than the observed ones. On the index they run from 0.672 to 0.928 (figure H.1), while in the data two countries sit at the Beveridgean corner and six at the Bismarckian one, a corner the cost cannot by itself deliver (section 7.1).

Inequality is where the model and the data part. In the data neither spending nor the index is related to the Gini. In the model spending is not related to it either, but the index falls with it, −0.73 against 0.89 in the data, and significantly: at the U.S. political weight and cost parameter and at an elasticity of one, a more unequal country chooses a less Bismarckian design, just as France's more equal distribution raises the U.S. design at $\rho = 1$ in figure 7.1. With each country's political weight calibrated to its pension spending instead, the second layer of table 5 (appendix H.3), the index still falls with population growth, while its relation with the Gini is no longer significant. The model thus accounts

[31] Under log preferences the design chosen depends neither on the inherited design nor on savings (proposition 5), so the observed design enters the test only through the tax rate. The design chosen in 2020, which binds from 2050, lies one period further along each country's path. It is more Bismarckian, 0.809 for the U.S. at the data of the test against 0.802 on its baseline path (appendix G.2), varies less across countries, and its index falls with population growth at less than a third of the slope in the data, −0.13 against −0.45.

Table 5: Figure 1.1's relations in the data and in the model

Relation	**Data**	**Layer 1**	**Layer 2**
Pension spending on population growth	−12.84 (3.67)	−16.49 (0.59)	*targeted*
Pension spending on the Gini	17.80 (23.90)	−10.25 (18.21)	*targeted*
Pension spending on the Bismarckian index	16.33 (3.67)	39.84 (6.25)	51.27 (7.36)
Bismarckian index on population growth	−0.45 (0.16)	−0.28 (0.04)	−0.19 (0.06)
Bismarckian index on the Gini	0.89 (0.98)	−0.73 (0.33)	−0.19 (0.38)

Note: Least-squares slopes with standard errors in parentheses, 26 countries. The regressors are those of figure 1.1 in data and model alike; the model's index is $1/(2-\theta)$ of the design in force in 2020 on the freely simulated path, chosen in 1990 (for the U.S. its observed design, the target of λ), and its spending is $\tau(1-\alpha)$ at the observed design. Layer 1: every country at the U.S. $\beta = 0.655$, $\omega = 1.294$ and $\lambda = 11.109$; layer 2: ω calibrated to each country's spending, which it then matches.

for the joint rise of spending and the earnings link as populations age, though with less dispersion in the design than the data show. On inequality its prediction depends on the elasticity, and at an elasticity of one it relates the design to inequality where the data do not.

8 Conclusions

This paper studies how two features of a pension system, whether benefits require a contribution record and how closely they follow past earnings, shape its political support and through it taxes, savings and labor supply. The setting is an overlapping generations model with capital, heterogeneous households, an informal sector and probabilistic voting, first over the size of the system and then over its design as well.

With log-GHH preferences and hand-to-mouth informal households the equilibrium tax is a function of parameters and demographics alone. It rises with the political weight of the old, with ageing and with income inequality, and it falls when benefits are more closely tied to earnings, since earnings-related benefits move revenue from poor retirees to rich ones; universal pensions raise the tax when informal retirees are poorer than formal ones and the pension is a comparable share of their consumption. Calibrated to Argentina, the model accounts for about three fifths of the rise in pension spending that accompanied the expansion of coverage of 2005 to 2010, with the savings rate lower by 0.4 p.p. of GDP and the workweek by a quarter of an hour. In the calibrations to the U.S., France and the UK, acute ageing, which holds the population constant, is

the main determinant of the U.S. tax rate and the earnings link the second, ahead of income inequality and voting patterns, at every intertemporal elasticity of substitution we consider. A higher elasticity shrinks the effects of ageing, the earnings link and the income distribution and enlarges that of the voting profile, so that at an elasticity of two the earnings link, at 2.0 p.p., is barely ahead of the voting profile, at 1.8 p.p.

When the electorate chooses the earnings link as well, costless redistribution puts the choice at a corner: with propensities to vote that do not rise with income the design chosen with the tax is fully Beveridgean, and at U.S. inequality each of the three timings we examine gives a corner at every intertemporal elasticity of substitution we check, the Beveridgean one in the Markov equilibria we study. An interior design needs flat benefits to be costlier than earnings-related ones, and we read the flat component as an implicit tax whose deadweight loss rises with the square of its rate, so that the share of revenue lost grows with the size of the system. With this cost calibrated on the U.S. design alone, ageing makes the chosen design more Bismarckian at every intertemporal elasticity of substitution, France's flatter voting profile makes it less so, away from France's own fully Bismarckian system, and a more equal income distribution moves it in a direction that depends on that elasticity. The U.S. cost parameter accounts for about a quarter of the distance of the UK and of France from the U.S. design, and the UK's own parameter is a third below the U.S. value at elasticities of one or below and a sixth above it at two. In the OECD cross-section, spending and the earnings link rise together as population growth falls, and neither follows inequality. Taken to 26 OECD countries with the U.S. parameters at an elasticity of one, the model reproduces the first pattern in sign, though the earnings link responds less to population growth than in the data, and it leaves spending unrelated to inequality. Unlike the data, however, it ties more Beveridgean designs to higher inequality.

Three limitations point to future work. The model has no risk; in Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras (2023) we study a related environment in which health risk may prevent households from qualifying for a contributive pension, and find that households work and save more in response. Every quantitative result rests on GHH preferences, which rule out income effects on labor supply; the hours responses and the retirees' stake in an earnings-related design both work through labor supply and may change once such effects are allowed. And the cost specification cannot by itself deliver France's fully Bismarckian system, because under a cost quadratic in the redistribution performed the first unit of redistribution is free at the margin; a linear term in the cost, or a formality margin, toward which the informal sector of our Argentine model is a first step, would allow it. The same margin bears on the rise of platform work and other arrangements outside contributive coverage in rich economies, which the model can address.

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Appendices

A Economic Equilibrium

The appendix derives results for the economic equilibrium with CRRA-GHH and log-GHH preferences and where informal workers' endowment is tied to wages in the formal sector absent taxes.

A.1 With CRRA-GHH preferences

Household solutions. With CRRA-GHH preferences, the first order conditions in (6) can be written as

$$h_{t,i} = \left(\frac{\eta_i w_t (1-\tau_t) + \frac{\theta \bar{b}_{t+1} \eta_i}{R_{t+1}}}{X_i} \right)^{\xi}$$
$$c^i_{2,t+1} = \tilde{c}^i_{1,t} \left(\beta R_{t+1}\right)^{\rho}.$$

Using the budget constraints and rearranging slightly, we can write individual savings as

$$s_{t,i} = \frac{B_{t+1}}{1+B_{t+1}} \left[w_t \left(1-\tau_t\right) h_{t,i} \eta_i - \frac{X_i \xi}{1+\xi} \left(h_{t,i}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \right] - \frac{b^i_{t+1}/R_{t+1}}{1+B_{t+1}},$$

where we have used the shorthand notation $B_{t+1} \equiv (\beta)^{\rho} \left(R_{t+1}\right)^{\rho-1}$.

When informal households save using informal technology, similar conditions apply:[32]

$$h_{t,0} = \left(\frac{\eta_0 w^0_t}{X_0} \right)^{\xi} \tag{A.1}$$
$$c^0_{2,t+1} = \tilde{c}^0_{1,t} \left(\beta R^0_{t+1}\right)^{\rho}. \tag{A.2}$$

As for formal households, we can derive the following for informal savings:

$$s_{t,0} = \frac{B^0_{t+1}}{1+B^0_{t+1}} \left[w^0_t h_{t,0} \eta_0 - \frac{X_0 \xi}{1+\xi} \left(h_{t,0}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \right] - \frac{b^0_{t+1}/R^0_{t+1}}{1+B^0_{t+1}},$$

where we have used $B^0_{t+1} \equiv (\beta)^{\rho} \left(R^0_{t+1}\right)^{\rho-1}$. When informal households are hand-to-mouth and receive an endowment when old, the solution for labor supply is given by (A.1).

Savings and labor supply in equilibrium. Next, in economic equilibrium, we impose conditions for factor prices in equations (3) and the specification of pension benefits

[32] Note that given our assumption on universal pensions, informal workers do not perceive a link between their work effort and the benefits they might receive.

including the balanced budget condition in equations (8). We can then rewrite type i's labor supply decision as

$$h_{t,i} = \left(\frac{\eta_i}{X_i}\right)^{\xi} \left(\frac{1}{h_t}\right)^{\xi} \left((1-\alpha)(1-\tau_t)\left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\alpha} h_t^{1-\alpha} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} s_t \tau_{t+1}\right)^{\xi}.$$

The only type-specific term is $(\eta_i/X_i)^{\xi}$; this shows that the ratio $h_{t,i}/h_t$ is only a function of parameters, namely that

$$\frac{h_{t,i}}{h_t} = \frac{(\eta_i/X_i)^{\xi}}{\Gamma_h}, \qquad \Gamma_h \equiv \sum_{i>0} \frac{\gamma_i \eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}. \tag{A.3}$$

Next, we can use the individual labor decision and wage rates to write

$$(1-\alpha)(1-\tau_t) h_t^{1-\alpha} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\alpha} = \frac{h_t^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}}}{\Gamma_h^{1/\xi}} - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} s_t \tau_{t+1},$$

Using this and the discounted pension benefits in equilibrium, we have that

$$\begin{aligned} s_{t,i} =& \frac{1}{1+B_{t+1}} \left[B_{t+1} \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}} \left(\frac{h_t}{\Gamma_h}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \frac{1}{1+\xi} - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{1-\theta}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} s_t \tau_{t+1} \right] \\ & - \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}\Gamma_h} \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} s_t \tau_{t+1} \end{aligned} \tag{A.4}$$

Using the definition of the aggregate state (1) and rearranging, we then have:

$$s_t = \left(\frac{h_t}{\Gamma_h}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \Gamma_{s,t}, \qquad \Gamma_{s,t} \equiv \frac{1}{1+\xi} \frac{\Gamma_h B_{t+1}}{1 + B_{t+1} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}(1+\theta B_{t+1})} \tag{A.5}$$

Furthermore, note that we can combine equations for s_t, h_t to yield closed-form expressions *given* values of B_{t+1}. From the definition of h_t we use that s_t is proportional to $h_t^{(1+\xi)/\xi}$ to derive:

$$h_t = \Theta_{h,t} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\frac{\alpha\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}, \qquad \Theta_{h,t} \equiv (\Gamma_h)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \left(\frac{(1-\alpha)(1-\tau_t)}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_{s,t}}\right)^{\frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \tag{A.6}$$

Using this, an alternative expression for s_t is:

$$s_t = \Theta_{s,t} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}}, \qquad \Theta_{s,t} \equiv \left(\frac{\Theta_{h,t}}{\Gamma_h}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \Gamma_{s,t}. \tag{A.7}$$

Using the relation between s_t and $h_t^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}}$ in (A.5), the ratio of individual (A.4) to aggregate

savings satisfies:

$$\frac{s_{t,i}}{s_t} = \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}} \frac{1}{\Gamma_h} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} \frac{1-\theta}{1+B_{t+1}} \left(\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}\Gamma_h} - 1 \right). \tag{A.8}$$

For informal households, we assume that informal wages are proportional to formal wages absent taxes and scaled appropriately by informal productivity η_0. Furthermore, we assume that the return to informal savings is proportional to the formal return on savings $R_t^0 = r_0 R_t$.

Specifically, we assume that informal wages are given by:

$$w_t^0 = \left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}} \right)^{\frac{1}{1+\alpha\xi}} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t} \right)^{\frac{\alpha}{1+\alpha\xi}}$$

Informal labor supply then follows directly from the derivations above for formal workers; in the case with informal savings, the ratio of informal to aggregate savings is similarly given by

$$\frac{s_{t,0}}{s_t} = \frac{B_{t+1}^0}{1+B_{t+1}^0} \frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}(1+\xi)} \left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}} \right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \frac{1}{\Theta_{s,t}} - \frac{1}{1+B_{t+1}^0} \frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha} \frac{\epsilon\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} \tag{A.9}$$

Consumption functions. It is straightforward to derive relevant equilibrium consumption functions $(c_{1,t}^j, \tilde{c}_{1,t}^j, c_{2,t}^j)$ given the results above. Imposing household budget constraints (5), factor prices (3), pension benefits and balanced budget condition (8), and labor and savings decisions from above, we have for formal households i:

$$c_{1,t}^i = \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}} \frac{s_t}{\Gamma_{s,t}} \left(1 - \frac{B_{t+1}}{(1+B_{t+1})(1+\xi)} \right) + \frac{s_t}{1+B_{t+1}} \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{\tau_{t+1}(1-\theta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} \tag{A.10}$$

$$c_{2,t}^i = \alpha\nu_t h_t^{1-\alpha} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t} \right)^{\alpha} \left(\frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} \left(1 + \theta \left[\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}} \frac{1}{\Gamma_h} - 1 \right] \right) \right) \tag{A.11}$$

$$\tilde{c}_{1,t}^i = \frac{s_t}{1+B_{t+1}} \left(\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}} \frac{1}{(1+\xi)\Gamma_{s,t}} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{\tau_{t+1}(1-\theta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} \right) \tag{A.12}$$

When informal households save using informal technology, equilibrium consumption functions are given by

$$\tilde{c}_{1,t}^0 = \frac{1}{1+\xi} \frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}} \left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}} \right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t} \right)^{\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}} + \frac{1}{1+B_{t+1}^0} \frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha} \frac{\epsilon\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} s_t \tag{A.13}$$

$$c_{2,t}^0 = r_0\alpha\nu_t \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t} \right)^{\alpha} h_t^{1-\alpha} \left(\frac{s_{t-1,0}}{s_{t-1}} + \frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha} \frac{\epsilon\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon} \right). \tag{A.14}$$

When informal households are hand-to-mouth, relevant equilibrium consumption func-

tions are given by[33]

$$\tilde{c}^0_{1,t} = \frac{1}{1+\xi}\frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}\left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}} \tag{A.15}$$

$$\tilde{c}^0_{2,t} = \frac{1}{1+\xi}\frac{(\chi\eta_0)^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}\left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}} + \frac{(1-\alpha)\nu_t\epsilon\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\alpha} h_t^{1-\alpha}. \tag{A.16}$$

A.2 With log-GHH preferences

With log-preferences, the economic equilibrium is identical to the CRRA equations outlined in appendix A.1, except for the discount function $B_t = B_t^0 = \beta$. All relevant variables $x_t \in \{s_t, h_t, s_{t,i}, h_{t,j}, \tilde{c}^j_{1,t}, c^i_{2,t}, \tilde{c}^0_{2,t}, c^i_{2,t+1}, \tilde{c}^0_{2,t+1}\}$ can be written on the form $x_t = \Theta_{x,t}\left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\sigma_x}$ where σ_x are parameter functions

$$\begin{aligned}
\sigma_h = \sigma_h^j &= \frac{\alpha\xi}{1+\alpha\xi} \\
\sigma^j_{\tilde{c}_1,t} = \sigma^i_{c_2,t} = \sigma^0_{\tilde{c}_2,t} = \sigma_{s,t} &= \sigma^i_{s,t} = \frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi} \\
\sigma^i_{c_2,t+1} = \sigma^0_{\tilde{c}_2,t+1} &= \left(\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}\right)^2,
\end{aligned}$$

and where the functions $\Theta_{x,t}$ depend only on parameters and policy.

Proof of proposition 1. Part *i.* outlines the marginal effect on s_t, h_t from policy and pension characteristics. Given the solution structure, the effect on s_t, h_t can be found by differentiating equations (A.5) and (A.6) with respect to the relevant variable. For τ_t the effect is straightforward:

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \tau_t} &= -\frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{1}{1-\tau_t} \leq 0 \\
\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \tau_t} &= -\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{1}{1-\tau_t} \leq 0.
\end{aligned}$$

We can also show that h_t is unambiguously decreasing in ϵ:

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \epsilon} &= \frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_{s,t}}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_{s,t}}\frac{1}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left((1+\gamma_0\epsilon)\frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \epsilon} - \gamma_0\right) \leq 0 \\
\frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \epsilon} &= \frac{\gamma_0}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}(1+\theta\beta)}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}(1+\theta\beta)}.
\end{aligned}$$

[33] Recall informal workers are assumed to receive an endowment proportional to wages of formal workers when they retire. For tractability we define this as if they were making a labor supply decision. The relevant parameter determining the size of the endowment is χ.

However, the effect on s_t is harder to sign.

$$\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \epsilon} = \frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \epsilon} + \frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \epsilon}.$$

Replacing from the expressions above, and neglecting common factors, the sign of the derivative is given by the sign of

$$-\frac{1}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{\theta\beta(1+\beta)}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}(1+\theta\beta\frac{\xi}{1+\xi})} + 1 + \theta\beta.$$

This can be seen to be positive for all $\theta \in [0,1]$. Note that the effect from γ_0 is equivalent to that of ϵ. We now consider the effect of future taxes on labor supply and savings.

$$\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} = \frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\Gamma_{s,t}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_{s,t}}\left(1+\tau_{t+1}\frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \tau_{t+1}}\right) \geq 0$$

$$\tau_{t+1}\frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} = -\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}(1+\theta\beta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}(1+\theta\beta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}} \in (-1,0].$$

This shows that labor supply is increasing in τ_{t+1}. For savings the effect is:

$$\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} = \frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} + \frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \tau_{t+1}}.$$

As before the sign of this derivative can be shown to be the same as the sign of the following term:

$$\frac{1}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{\theta\beta(1+\beta)}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}(1+\theta\beta\frac{\xi}{1+\xi})} - (1+\theta\beta).$$

This is basically the same term (with different sign) as before. Thus, for all values of θ and τ_{t+1} we have that an increase in τ_{t+1} reduces savings.

Taking the derivative with respect to θ, we see a similar condition as with the effect of τ_{t+1}, namely:

$$\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \theta} = \frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}\Gamma_{s,t}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_{s,t}}\left(1+\theta\frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \theta}\right) \geq 0,$$

$$\theta\frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \theta} = -\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}\theta\beta}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}(1+\theta\beta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}} \in (-1,0].$$

This shows that labor supply is increasing in θ. For the savings rate, we have:

$$\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \theta} = \frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\frac{\partial \ln(h_t)}{\partial \theta} + \frac{\partial \ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{\partial \theta}.$$

Proceeding as before we find that this is unambiguously negative.[34]

Part *ii.* follows from earlier derivations, specifically equation (A.3). Part *iii.* similarly follows from equation (A.8) with $B_{t+1} = \beta$ in the log case. Finally, part *iv.* follows straightforwardly, comparing (A.8) and (A.3): An average type i household has $\eta_i^{1+\xi}/X_i^{\xi} = \Gamma_h$. Thus, for $\tau_{t+1} = 0$ or $\theta = 1$, we simply have $s_{t,i}/s_t = \eta_i h_{t,i}/h_t$. The spread in savings increases in τ_{t+1} and decreases in θ in the sense that these parameter changes increase $s_{t,i}/s_t$ for $s_{t,i}/s_t > 1$ and decrease for $s_{t,i}/s_t < 1$.

Part *v.* The effects on $s_{t,0}$ and $s_{t,0}/s_t$ from various parameters come from differentiation of (A.9) with $B_{t+1}^0 = \beta$. Note that $s_{t,0}$ depends on τ_t only through the effect of taxes on s_t. Thus, it is straightforward to show that both $s_{t,0}$ and $s_{t,0}/s_t$ are increasing in τ_t.

The effects from τ_{t+1} and ϵ are given by:

$$\frac{\partial s_{t,0}}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} = -\frac{1}{1+\beta}\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{s_t\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(1+\tau_{t+1}\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \tau_{t+1}}\right) \leq 0,$$
$$\frac{\partial s_{t,0}}{\partial \epsilon} = -\frac{1}{1+\beta}\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{s_t\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(\frac{1}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}+\epsilon\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \epsilon}\right) \leq 0.$$

The first derivative can be signed since $\tau_{t+1}\frac{\partial \ln(s_t)}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} \geq -1$. It is straightforward to show that an increase in θ increases $s_{t,0}$.

To see the effect of τ_{t+1} on the ratio $s_{t,0}/s_t$ we have that:

$$\frac{\partial(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} = -\frac{\beta}{1+\beta}\frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}(1+\xi)}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}\frac{1}{\Theta_{s,t}}\frac{\partial \ln(\Theta_{s,t})}{\partial \tau_{t+1}} - \frac{1}{1+\beta}\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon},$$

where the derivative $\partial \ln(\Theta_{s,t})/\partial \tau_{t+1} = \partial \ln(s_t)/\partial \tau_{t+1}$ is defined above. We note that this may be negative or positive. For instance, if $\epsilon \approx 0$ an increase in future taxes increases this ratio. Conversely if $r_0 \approx 0$ then we would expect the opposite effect.

B Politico-economic equilibrium

B.1 Proof of proposition 2

By appendix A.2, all consumption functions are log-separable in the aggregate state s_{t-1}, and in all the Θ-coefficient functions the only *predetermined* variable that may enter the political problem as an endogenous state is the distribution of savings $s_{t-1,i}/s_{t-1}$. The current tax moves the aggregate state carried into the next period, s_t, but by the same

[34] The term whose sign determines this is slightly different

$$\frac{1}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}(1+\theta\beta\frac{\xi}{1+\xi})} - 1.$$

log-separability its level drops out of the first order condition at $t+1$. The distribution chosen at t, $s_{t,i}/s_t$, depends on parameters and on the tax and the design anticipated for $t+1$ (part iii of proposition 1), but not on τ_t, so that the part of the law of motion (9) that carries the distribution does not respond to the current tax,

$$\frac{\partial\left(s_{t,i}/s_t\right)}{\partial\tau_t}=0, \qquad i>0.$$

The distribution is therefore not an *endogenous* state: changing τ_t has no strategic effect on future policy.

The tax at t maximizes (14) given the inherited distribution of savings and the continuation policy, and it satisfies the first order condition

$$\begin{aligned}
&\omega\left[\gamma_0\mu_0\overbrace{\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta^0_{\tilde{c}2,t}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}}^{=\mathcal{E}^0_{2,t}}+\sum_{i>0}\gamma_i\mu_i\overbrace{\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta^i_{c2,t}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}}^{=\mathcal{E}^i_{2,t}}\right]\\
&+\nu_t\Bigg\{\gamma_0\mu_0\underbrace{\left(\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta^0_{\tilde{c}1,t}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}+\beta\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta^0_{\tilde{c}2,t+1}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}\right)}_{=\mathcal{E}^0_{1,t}}\\
&\qquad+\sum_{i>0}\gamma_i\mu_i\underbrace{\left(\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta^i_{\tilde{c}1,t}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}+\beta\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta^i_{c2,t+1}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}\right)}_{=\mathcal{E}^i_{1,t}}\Bigg\}\leq 0,
\end{aligned}$$

with equality for an interior solution, where $\mathcal{E}^j_{x,t}$ denotes the marginal effect of the tax on the indirect utility of a household of type j in generation x and μ_j the propensity to vote of type j. Using the equilibrium consumption functions of appendix A.1,

$$\mathcal{E}^0_{2,t}=\frac{\frac{(1-\alpha)\nu_t\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Theta_{h,t}^{1-\alpha}\left(1+(1-\alpha)\tau_t\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta_{h,t}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}\right)}{\frac{(\chi\eta_0)^{1+\xi}}{(1+\xi)X_0^{\xi}}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}+\frac{(1-\alpha)\nu_t\epsilon\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Theta_{h,t}^{1-\alpha}} \tag{B.1}$$

$$\mathcal{E}^i_{2,t}=(1-\alpha)\frac{\partial\ln\left(\Theta_{h,t}\right)}{\partial\tau_t}+\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{1}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(1+\theta_t\left[\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}\frac{1}{\Gamma_h}-1\right]\right)}{\frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}}+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(1+\theta_t\left[\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}\frac{1}{\Gamma_h}-1\right]\right)} \tag{B.2}$$

$$\mathcal{E}^0_{1,t}=-\frac{\beta}{1-\tau_t}\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)^2}{(1+\alpha\xi)^2} \tag{B.3}$$

$$\mathcal{E}^i_{1,t}=-\frac{1}{1-\tau_t}\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\left(1+\beta\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}\right). \tag{B.4}$$

The tax lowers the net income of the young and with it their savings, $\partial\ln(s_t)/\partial\tau_t=-\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{1}{1-\tau_t}$ (appendix A.2). An informal young household earns the informal wage, which

does not depend on τ_t, and in old age receives an endowment and a universal pension that both scale with $s_t^{\alpha(1+\xi)/(1+\alpha\xi)}$, which gives (B.3). For a formal young household the Euler equation writes indirect utility as $(1+\beta)\ln(\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}) + \beta\ln(R_{t+1}) + \beta\ln(\beta)$. Here $\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}$ is proportional to s_t with a factor that does not depend on τ_t (appendix A.1), and $R_{t+1} = \alpha\Theta_{h,t+1}^{1-\alpha}(s_t/\nu_{t+1})^{-(1-\alpha)/(1+\alpha\xi)}$ by (3) and (A.6), with $\Theta_{h,t+1}$ set by policy at $t+1$ and $t+2$, which does not respond to τ_t. The fall in savings lowers the consumption of the young and raises the return on their savings, which partly compensates them: $(1+\beta) - \beta\frac{1-\alpha}{1+\alpha\xi} = 1 + \beta\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}$ gives (B.4). For retirees the tax has opposing effects in (B.2). The first term is negative, since the tax lowers hours and with them both the base of the pension and the return on savings, and the second is positive, the direct effect of the tax on the pension.

Write $y_i \equiv \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}\Gamma_h} = \frac{\eta_i h_{t-1,i}}{h_{t-1}}$ for the labor income of type i relative to the mean, with $\sum_{i>0}\gamma_i y_i = 1$ by (A.3), $x_i \equiv s_{t-1,i}/s_{t-1}$ for its savings share, $p_i \equiv 1 + \theta_t(y_i - 1)$ for its pension relative to the average formal pension, and $a \equiv \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{1}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}$. By appendix A.1 and $R_t s_{t-1} = \alpha\nu_t h_t^{1-\alpha}(s_{t-1}/\nu_t)^{\alpha}$, a formal retiree of type i consumes $c^i_{2,t} = R_t s_{t-1} D_i$ with $D_i \equiv x_i + a\tau_t p_i$. Since $\nu_t w_t h_t = \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} R_t s_{t-1}$, the pension is $b^i_t = R_t s_{t-1} a\tau_t p_i$ by (8), so the pension's share of consumption is $\sigma^i_t \equiv b^i_t/c^i_{2,t} = a\tau_t p_i/D_i$. For an informal retiree it is $\sigma^0_t \equiv b^0_t/\tilde{c}^0_{2,t}$. Let

$$\phi_t \equiv 1 + (1-\alpha)\tau_t\frac{\partial\ln(\Theta_{h,t})}{\partial\tau_t} = 1 - \frac{(1-\alpha)\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\frac{\tau_t}{1-\tau_t}$$

be the elasticity of revenue with respect to the tax rate, so that $1-\phi_t$ is the elasticity of the tax base in absolute value. Then (B.1) and (B.2) read

$$\mathcal{E}^0_{2,t} = \frac{\phi_t\sigma^0_t}{\tau_t}, \qquad \mathcal{E}^i_{2,t} = \frac{\phi_t\sigma^i_t - (1-\phi_t)(1-\sigma^i_t)}{\tau_t} = \frac{\phi_t - 1 + \sigma^i_t}{\tau_t}: \tag{B.5}$$

a unit of tax raises every pension by ϕ_t/τ_t in proportion, and with log utility a retiree's support is that proportion times the pension's share of consumption, less, for formal retirees, the fall in the return on their savings.

Savings consistent with the tax. The generation that is old at t saved at $t-1$ for the tax and the design that pay its benefits, which in equilibrium are those in force at t. By part iii of proposition 1, one period back, its savings shares and consumption are

$$x_i(\tau_t) = y_i + \frac{a\tau_t(1-\theta_t)}{1+\beta}(y_i - 1), \qquad D_i = y_i + a\tau_t q_i, \qquad q_i \equiv \theta_t y_i + (1-\theta_t)\frac{\beta + y_i}{1+\beta}. \tag{B.6}$$

Types below mean income save less than their income share, by the fraction $1/(1+\beta)$ of the present value of what the flat component of the pension transfers to them, and

since $q_i > 0$, retirement consumption is positive and rises with relative income. Write $\mathcal{F}_t(\tau_t; x)$ for the left-hand side of the first order condition at savings shares $x = (x_i)_{i>0}$, and $G_t(\tau_t) \equiv \mathcal{F}_t(\tau_t; x(\tau_t))$ for the condition at the shares consistent with τ_t. A tax is a politico-economic equilibrium at t if and only if it maximizes the political objective at the shares consistent with it, which is the test of section 4.

Proposition 3. *Assume log-GHH preferences and hand-to-mouth informal households, with $\xi(1-2\alpha) \leq 1$ if $\gamma_0 > 0$. Given the design and the continuation policy, G_t is strictly decreasing on $[0,1)$, and the politico-economic equilibrium tax at t is its zero, or $\tau_t = 0$ if $G_t(0) \leq 0$. It is the only candidate that passes the equilibrium test, and for every horizon T the politico-economic equilibrium is unique. Without informal households G_t involves neither the continuation policy nor T, and the tax at each date before T is the same for every horizon.*

Proof of proposition 3. By (B.6), at consistent shares the second term of (B.2) is $ap_i/(y_i + a\tau_t q_i)$, positive, finite and strictly decreasing in τ_t on $[0,1)$. A higher anticipated tax lowers the savings of a retiree below mean income, but its pension rises by more than its savings income falls, so the pension's share of its consumption rises less than in proportion to the tax. The first term of (B.2) and the young's terms (B.3) and (B.4) are non-positive multiples of $1/(1-\tau_t)$, and (B.4) is a negative multiple, strictly decreasing and unbounded below as $\tau_t \to 1$. The informal retirees' term (B.1) is the derivative of $\ln(e_t + b_t^0)$, where the endowment e_t does not depend on τ_t and, by (A.6), the pension b_t^0 is proportional to $\tau_t(1-\tau_t)^m$ with $m \equiv (1-\alpha)\xi/(1+\alpha\xi)$. Its derivative in τ_t has the sign of $(e_t + b_t^0)\,\partial^2 b_t^0/\partial\tau_t^2 - (\partial b_t^0/\partial\tau_t)^2$, which is negative where b_t^0 is concave in τ_t, on all of $[0,1)$ when $m \leq 1$, that is $\xi(1-2\alpha) \leq 1$. Every term enters G_t with a positive weight, so G_t is continuous and strictly decreasing on $[0,1)$, finite at zero and unbounded below as $\tau_t \to 1$.

At fixed shares x the second term of (B.2), $ap_i/(x_i + a\tau_t p_i)$, is strictly decreasing in τ_t wherever the retiree's consumption is positive, so $\mathcal{F}_t(\cdot\,; x)$ is strictly decreasing and the political objective strictly concave in τ_t there. A tax τ^* therefore maximizes the objective at the shares $x(\tau^*)$ if and only if $\mathcal{F}_t(\tau^*; x(\tau^*)) = G_t(\tau^*) = 0$, or $\tau^* = 0$ and $G_t(0) \leq 0$. Exactly one tax does so, the zero of G_t if $G_t(0) > 0$ and $\tau_t = 0$ otherwise. Every other candidate of the test is a corner at which $G_t \neq 0$, so the objective at its own shares rises as the tax moves away from it, and it fails.

At T the young have no second period and their terms are (B.3)–(B.4) with $\beta = 0$ (appendix D), so G_T involves no state and neither does the tax at T. Given a continuation that does not respond to the state, the young's terms at t take the form (B.3)–(B.4), and G_t again involves no state, so by induction this holds at every date. The continuation enters G_t only through the level of $\Theta_{h,t}$ in b_t^0, by (A.6). Backward induction from T

therefore gives a unique equilibrium for every horizon, and without informal households G_t involves only τ_t, θ_t, ν_t and the parameters. □

The argument carries over to the tax condition with the cost of section 7 at the inherited design (appendix C.3, where $\gamma_0 = 0$). With $u(\tau_t) \equiv \tau_t f(\theta_t, \tau_t)$, by (C.8) and (C.7c) the benefit term at consistent shares becomes $ap_i u'(\tau_t)/(y_i + aq_i u(\tau_t))$, with $u' = f(1 + \ln f)$. Since $\ln f$ is linear in τ_t, $u'' \leq 0$ where $u' \geq 0$, so the term is strictly decreasing there and negative elsewhere, and G_t is strictly decreasing where it can vanish and negative beyond. At fixed shares the condition likewise changes sign at most once, from positive to negative, so the tax function $\mathcal{T}_t(\theta_t)$ of appendix C.3 is single-valued. The proposition does not extend to informal savers or to CRRA preferences. With either, the condition carries the response of the continuation policy to the state, which has no fixed sign, and under CRRA preferences every term carries a marginal-utility weight that moves with the tax. For these cases the solver records at every state and date how many candidates pass the test (appendix D).

Comparative statics. By the proof of proposition 3, G_t, and $\mathcal{F}_t$ at fixed shares, have strictly negative derivatives in τ_t, since that of (B.4) is strictly negative and those of the other terms are not positive. At an interior equilibrium a parameter therefore moves the tax in the direction in which it moves G_t, or $\mathcal{F}_t$ when the shares are held at their inherited values, by the implicit function theorem, and at the corner $\tau_t = 0$ a small change has no effect. The comparative statics are those of the tax at t given the continuation policy, which enters only through σ_t^0. Without a universal pension it does not enter, and they hold at every date of the equilibrium path.

ω and ν_t. The retirees' terms sum to a positive number at an interior equilibrium, since the young's are negative, so taxes rise with ω. The ratio ν_t weights the young's terms and also enters the universal pension. The pension b_t^0 is proportional to ν_t, more contributors per informal retiree, while the endowment is not, and both scale with the same power of s_{t-1}/ν_t (appendix A.1). Hence $\partial\sigma_t^0/\partial\nu_t = \sigma_t^0(1-\sigma_t^0)/\nu_t$ and $\partial\mathcal{E}_{2,t}^0/\partial\nu_t = \mathcal{E}_{2,t}^0(1-\sigma_t^0)/\nu_t$, while σ_t^i does not move, since formal pensions and capital income both scale with ν_t. Using $G_t = 0$ to substitute for the young's terms,

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial G_t}{\partial \nu_t} &= \frac{\omega}{\nu_t}\gamma_0\mu_0\mathcal{E}_{2,t}^0\left(1-\sigma_t^0\right) + \gamma_0\mu_0\mathcal{E}_{1,t}^0 + \sum_{i>0}\gamma_i\mu_i\mathcal{E}_{1,t}^i \\ &= -\frac{\omega}{\nu_t}\left[\gamma_0\mu_0\mathcal{E}_{2,t}^0\sigma_t^0 + \sum_{i>0}\gamma_i\mu_i\mathcal{E}_{2,t}^i\right]. \end{aligned} \tag{B.7}$$

Since $0 \leq \sigma_t^0 \leq 1$, the bracket is at least the smaller of the formal retirees' term $\sum_{i>0}\gamma_i\mu_i\mathcal{E}_{2,t}^i$ and the retirees' total, which is positive. Taxes therefore fall with ν_t whenever the aggregate marginal support of formal retirees is positive at the equilibrium,

which by (B.5) is

$$\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \mu_i \mathcal{E}^i_{2,t} > 0 \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad \frac{\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \mu_i \sigma^i_t}{\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \mu_i} > 1 - \phi_t : \tag{B.8}$$

the average share of the pension in the consumption of formal retirees, weighted by their propensities to vote, exceeds the elasticity of the tax base. Without a universal pension the formal retirees' term is the retirees' total and the condition always holds. With one it fails only if the tax is sustained by informal retirees against formal ones.

Income inequality. For any two types with $y_H > y_L$, raise η_H and lower η_L such that

$$\frac{\partial \eta_L}{\partial \eta_H} = -\frac{\gamma_H \left(\frac{\eta_H}{X_H}\right)^\xi}{\gamma_L \left(\frac{\eta_L}{X_L}\right)^\xi},$$

which keeps Γ_h, and so aggregate labor supply and savings, constant for given policies. Since $\partial y_m / \partial \eta_m = (1+\xi)(\eta_m / X_m)^\xi / \Gamma_h$, the change leaves every other y_j unchanged and satisfies $\gamma_H \, dy_H + \gamma_L \, dy_L = 0$: it transfers relative income from a poorer to a richer type at a constant mean. It reaches G_t only through the pension shares of formal retirees, since the young's terms and ϕ_t do not involve the y_i and σ^0_t involves them only through Γ_h. At consistent shares, by (B.6), a formal retiree's pension share is a function of its relative income alone,

$$\sigma(y) = \frac{a\tau_t \left[\theta_t y + 1 - \theta_t\right]}{D(y)}, \qquad \sigma'(y) = -\frac{\kappa_t (1-\theta_t)}{D(y)^2}, \qquad \kappa_t \equiv a\tau_t \left(1 + \frac{a\tau_t}{1+\beta}\right), \tag{B.9}$$

where $D(y) = y + a\tau_t q(y)$, with $q(y)$ defined as q_i in (B.6), is proportional to the consumption of a retiree with relative income y and rises with it. The share falls with relative income, and by less at higher incomes. Using $\gamma_L \, dy_L = -\gamma_H \, dy_H$, the transfer changes the retirees' terms by

$$\frac{\omega}{\tau_t} \gamma_H \, dy_H \left[\mu_H \sigma'(y_H) - \mu_L \sigma'(y_L)\right] = \frac{\omega}{\tau_t} \gamma_H \, dy_H \, \kappa_t \left(1 - \theta_t\right) \left[\frac{\mu_L}{D_L^2} - \frac{\mu_H}{D_H^2}\right],$$

which is positive with equal propensities to vote, since $D_H > D_L$, and in general whenever $\mu_H / \mu_L < (c^H_{2,t} / c^L_{2,t})^2$. Every spread of relative incomes built from such transfers therefore raises the tax. The result rests on the response of savings: with the shares held at their inherited values the transfer would move σ^i_t only through the earnings-related part of the pension, $\partial \sigma^i_t / \partial y_i = a\tau_t \theta_t x_i / D_i^2$, and would leave the tax unchanged at $\theta_t = 0$.

The design. The design θ_t pays current retirees, who anticipated it when they saved. At consistent shares $\partial D_i / \partial \theta_t = \frac{\beta}{1+\beta} a\tau_t (y_i - 1)$ by (B.6): consumption moves by the fraction $\beta/(1+\beta)$ of the change in the pension, savings having absorbed the rest. Since

$D_i - \frac{\beta}{1+\beta} a\tau_t p_i = y_i \left(1 + \frac{a\tau_t}{1+\beta}\right)$, also by (B.6),

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial \sigma_t^i}{\partial \theta_t} &= \frac{a\tau_t(y_i - 1)}{D_i^2} \left(D_i - \frac{\beta}{1+\beta} a\tau_t p_i \right) = \kappa_t \frac{y_i}{D_i^2} (y_i - 1) , \\ \frac{\partial G_t}{\partial \theta_t} &= \frac{\omega \kappa_t}{\tau_t} \sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \frac{\mu_i y_i}{D_i^2} (y_i - 1) . \end{aligned} \tag{B.10}$$

Since $\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i (y_i - 1) = 0$, the sum equals $\frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j} \gamma_i \gamma_j \left(\frac{\mu_i y_i}{D_i^2} - \frac{\mu_j y_j}{D_j^2} \right)(y_i - y_j)$, as in the proof of proposition 4, and is negative when $\mu_i y_i / D_i^2$ falls with relative income and incomes are not all equal. Taxes therefore fall with θ_t whenever $\mu_i y_i / (c_{2,t}^i)^2$ is decreasing in relative income across formal types. With equal propensities, D is affine in y by (B.6), and

$$\frac{d \ln \left(y / D(y)^2 \right)}{dy} = \frac{1}{y} - \frac{2D'(y)}{D(y)} = \frac{1}{yD(y)} \left(\frac{2\beta}{1+\beta} a\tau_t (1 - \theta_t) - D(y) \right)$$

is negative wherever $D(y) > \frac{2\beta}{1+\beta} a\tau_t (1 - \theta_t)$. Since D rises with y, the condition holds across formal types if every formal retiree consumes more than $2\beta/(1+\beta)$ times the flat component of its pension, $(1 - \theta_t) h_{t-1} \bar{b}_t = R_t s_{t-1} a\tau_t (1 - \theta_t)$. This is the case whenever no formal type borrows against its pension: with $x_i \geq 0$, $D_i \geq a\tau_t p_i \geq a\tau_t (1 - \theta_t)$, which exceeds $\frac{2\beta}{1+\beta} a\tau_t (1 - \theta_t)$ for $\beta < 1$ and $\theta_t < 1$, and the bound is zero at $\theta_t = 1$. With the shares held at their inherited values, as for a design that retirees did not anticipate, $\partial \sigma_t^i / \partial \theta_t = a\tau_t (y_i - 1) x_i / D_i^2$, and the weight $x_i / (c_{2,t}^i)^2$ need not fall with income, since x_i rises with income faster than y_i when $\theta_t < 1$; the sign is then open. A permanent change in the design also moves the continuation, which enters G_t only through σ_t^0 and so not at all without a universal pension.

The universal pension. The effect of ϵ works through retirees alone, since the young's terms do not depend on it. We sign it for a change that current retirees did not anticipate, with their savings shares at their inherited values, as at the reform date of section 5, and with $\Theta_{h,t}$, which moves with the universal pension the young anticipate for themselves, held fixed. Benefits are shares of revenue $\nu_t w_t h_t \tau_t$, $\epsilon / (1 + \gamma_0 \epsilon)$ per informal retiree and $p_i / (1 + \gamma_0 \epsilon)$ per formal retiree of type i, so a higher ϵ raises b_t^0 by $1/(\epsilon(1 + \gamma_0 \epsilon))$ in proportion and lowers every b_t^i by $\gamma_0 / (1 + \gamma_0 \epsilon)$ in proportion, a pure transfer since there are γ_0 informal retirees per formal one. A pension share responds to a proportional change in the benefit by $\partial \sigma_t^j / \partial \ln b_t^j = \sigma_t^j (1 - \sigma_t^j)$, since the rest of consumption does not move, and by (B.5) $\partial \mathcal{E}_{2,t}^0 / \partial \sigma_t^0 = \phi_t / \tau_t$ and $\partial \mathcal{E}_{2,t}^i / \partial \sigma_t^i = 1 / \tau_t$. Hence

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{F}_t}{\partial \epsilon} = \frac{\omega \, \gamma_0}{\tau_t (1 + \gamma_0 \epsilon)} \left[\frac{\phi_t}{\epsilon} \mu_0 \sigma_t^0 \left(1 - \sigma_t^0 \right) - \sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \mu_i \sigma_t^i \left(1 - \sigma_t^i \right) \right] ,$$

and taxes rise with ϵ if and only if the bracket is positive,

$$\frac{\phi_t}{\epsilon}\,\mu_0\sigma_t^0\left(1-\sigma_t^0\right) > \sum_{i>0}\gamma_i\mu_i\sigma_t^i\left(1-\sigma_t^i\right). \tag{B.11}$$

The share γ_0 multiplies the whole expression, because the loss of formal retirees is the gain of informal retirees times their number, and enters the bracket only through the consumption levels, so it does not determine the sign. The factor $\sigma(1-\sigma)$ is zero for a retiree without a pension and for one who lives on the pension alone, whose consumption and marginal benefit a higher ϵ raises in the same proportion, and is largest at one half. The factor $1/\epsilon$ is the asymmetry of the transfer: a unit of ϵ is a large proportional change of a small universal pension and a small one of the formal pensions. With equal pension shares and equal propensities to vote the condition is $\epsilon < \phi_t$, and since informal retirees then consume ϵ times the average consumption of formal retirees, it requires them to be poorer by more than $1-\phi_t$, the elasticity of the tax base. The condition therefore holds when informal retirees are poorer than formal ones by more than this elasticity and the pension is a comparable share of their consumption, since a comparable share of a smaller consumption is a smaller pension, and fails when they live on the pension alone or are much richer than formal retirees. A permanent reform also lowers the hours of the young (part i of proposition 1), and with them the universal pension relative to the informal endowment, and a change that retirees anticipated would also move their savings shares; (B.11) leaves out both.

At the Argentine calibration of section 5, in 2010 before the reform, $\epsilon = 0.21$, $\phi_t = 0.976$, and the pension is 12.2% of the consumption of informal retirees and between 19.5% and 15.5% of that of formal retirees, falling with income. The left-hand side of (B.11) is then 0.498, three and a half times the right-hand side, 0.143. After the reform, at $\epsilon^U = 0.546$ and the post-reform tax of 13.8%, at which $\phi_t = 0.971$, the pension is 26.9% of the consumption of informal retirees and the two sides are 0.350 and 0.145. The calibration has informal savers, whose savings income falls with hours as that of formal retirees does, so their term carries a factor of one in place of ϕ_t, which raises the left-hand side before the reform to 0.511.

The representative-agent tax. With one type of formal household and no informal households, $J = 1$ and $\gamma_0 = 0$, relative income, the savings share and the relative pension are one, $y_1 = x_1 = p_1 = 1$, so the design drops out of (B.2): both components of the benefit pay the same household. The propensity to vote multiplies both generations' terms and cancels, and with $a = (1-\alpha)/\alpha$ the second term of (B.2) is $a/(1+a\tau_t)$, so the first order condition is

$$\omega\left[\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha+(1-\alpha)\tau_t} - \frac{(1-\alpha)\xi}{(1+\alpha\xi)(1-\tau_t)}\right] = \frac{\nu_t}{1-\tau_t}\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\left(1+\beta\frac{\alpha(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}\right).$$

Multiplying by $(1-\tau_t)(1+\alpha\xi)/(1-\alpha)$ and writing $\Psi \equiv (1+\xi)\left(1+\frac{\alpha\beta(1+\xi)}{1+\alpha\xi}\right)$ gives $(1+\alpha\xi)(1-\tau_t)/(\alpha+(1-\alpha)\tau_t) = \xi + \nu_t\Psi/(\omega(1-\alpha))$, which is linear in τ_t once cross-multiplied, and the unique solution is

$$\tau_t = \max\left\{0,\ \frac{\omega(1-\alpha)-\alpha\nu_t\Psi}{\omega(1-\alpha)(1+\xi)+(1-\alpha)\nu_t\Psi}\right\}. \tag{B.12}$$

Where it is positive, the tax rises with ω and falls with ν_t, α, β and ξ. With inelastic labor, $\xi = 0$, $\Psi = 1+\alpha\beta$ and (B.12) is the equilibrium tax of Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008), their ratio of young to old households being ν_t and their per capita political weight of retirees ω. The Frisch elasticity lowers the tax because GHH preferences carry no income effect: the tax lowers hours, which erodes the base that pays retirees and deepens the loss of the young, whereas under the separable logarithmic preferences of their section 3 a social security tax that is the only tax leaves hours unchanged. The same expression is the tax at the Bismarckian corner for any income distribution and any propensities to vote, as long as there are no informal households. At $\theta_t = 1$ benefits and, by part iv of proposition 1, savings are proportional to relative income, so every type has $\sigma_t^i = a\tau_t/(1+a\tau_t)$ and the same marginal effects, and the propensities cancel. At the U.S. calibration of section 6 it gives a tax of 8.3% in 2020, against the calibrated 10.5%.

B.2 With log-GHH preferences and informal savings

The introduction of $s_{t-1,0}/s_{t-1}$ as an endogenous state variable complicates the model because this state variable not only depends on past choices (through the effect of τ_{t-1} on $\Theta_{s,t-1}$), but is also forward looking ($s_{t-1,0}/s_{t-1}$ depends explicitly on τ_t). To deal with this, let $dx_t/d\tau_t$ denote the effect in politico-economic equilibrium of changing the tax rate τ_t on the variable x_t accounting for the fact that a change in τ_t also changes the state $s_{t,0}/s_t$ which through the continuation policy affects the choice of τ_{t+1} as well. Specifically, for the state variable $s_{t,0}/s_t$ we have:

$$\frac{d(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{d\tau_t} = \frac{\partial(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{\partial\tau_t} + \frac{\partial(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{\partial\tau_{t+1}}\frac{d\tau_t^{+1}}{d(s_{t,0}/s_t)}\frac{d(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{d\tau_t},$$

where the partial derivatives of $s_{t,0}/s_t$ capture how the state reacts to policy in economic equilibrium and $\tau_t^{+1}(s_{t,0}/s_t)$ is the continuation policy that details how policy in $t+1$ adjusts when the endogenous state changes. When considering a marginal change in τ_t, the policymaker takes into account how this propagates via economic equilibrium and continuation policy functions into future periods in order to summarize the total impact on current relevant variables. The technical documentation derives a recursive structure for all the relevant derivatives required to evaluate the marginal effect of τ_t on the indirect utility of households (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026, section *Informal Savings Model*).

With the endogenous state $s_{t-1,0}/s_{t-1}$, the politico-economic equilibrium is now characterized by the first order condition:

$$\omega\left[\sum_{i\geq 0}\gamma_i\overbrace{\frac{d\ln\left(c^i_{2,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}}^{=\mathcal{E}^i_{2,t}}\right]+\nu_t\left\{\sum_{i\geq 0}\gamma_i\underbrace{\left(\frac{d\ln\left(\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}+\beta\frac{d\ln\left(c^i_{2,t+1}\right)}{d\tau_t}\right)}_{=\mathcal{E}^i_{1,t}}\right\}\leq 0,$$

Using equilibrium consumption functions from appendix A.1, we have the derivatives of indirect utility for retired households:

$$\mathcal{E}^0_{2,t}=(1-\alpha)\frac{d\ln\left(h_t\right)}{d\tau_t}+\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}{\frac{s_{t-1,0}}{s_{t-1}}+\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\epsilon\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}} \tag{B.13}$$

$$\mathcal{E}^i_{2,t}=(1-\alpha)\frac{d\ln\left(h_t\right)}{d\tau_t}+\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{1}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(1+\theta_t\left[\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}\frac{1}{\Gamma_h}-1\right]\right)}{\frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}}+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_t}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(1+\theta\left[\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}\frac{1}{\Gamma_h}-1\right]\right)}. \tag{B.14}$$

We note that the marginal effect for formal retirees is the same as when continuation policies were independent of state variables. The only difference is that the change in the aggregate labor supply, $\frac{d\ln(h_t)}{d\tau_t}$, now includes strategic effects through future policies.

For the formal, working households, we can use the Euler equation to write the indirect utility as $\ln\left(\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}\right)(1+\beta)+\beta\ln\left(\beta R_{t+1}\right)$. The marginal effect on indirect utility then consists of the two terms:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{E}^i_{1,t}=&(1+\beta)\frac{d\ln\left(\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}+\beta\frac{d\ln\left(R_{t+1}\right)}{d\tau_t}\\
\frac{d\ln\left(\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}=&\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\frac{d\ln\left(h_t\right)}{d\tau_t}+\frac{\Gamma_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{1-\theta_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(\frac{d\tau_{t+1}}{d\tau_t}+\tau_{t+1}\frac{d\ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{d\tau_t}\right)}{\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^{\xi}}\frac{1}{1+\xi}+\Gamma_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}(1-\theta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}\\
\frac{d\ln\left(R_{t+1}\right)}{d\tau_t}=&(1-\alpha)\left(\frac{d\ln\left(h_{t+1}\right)}{d\ln\left(s_t\right)}-1\right)\frac{d\ln\left(s_t\right)}{d\tau_t}.
\end{aligned}$$

where we use the shorthand $d\tau_{t+1}/d\tau_t=\frac{d\tau_t^{+1}}{d(s_{t,0}/s_t)}\frac{d(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{d\tau_t}$ to define the total effect of a change in the tax rate on future taxes. The technical documentation gives the computation of these derivatives in the numerical application (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026, section *Informal Savings Model*).

For the informal, working households, a similar Euler condition applies such that we can write indirect utility as $\ln\left(\tilde{c}^0_{1,t}\right)(1+\beta)+\beta\ln\left(\beta R^0_{t+1}\right)$ The marginal effect on indirect

utility is then characterized by

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{E}^0_{1,t} =&(1+\beta)\frac{d\ln\left(\tilde{c}^0_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}+\beta\frac{d\ln\left(R^0_{t+1}\right)}{d\tau_t}\\
\frac{d\ln\left(\tilde{c}^0_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t} =&\frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Theta_{s,t}\left(\frac{d\tau_{t+1}}{d\tau_t}+\tau_{t+1}\frac{d\ln(s_t)}{d\tau_t}\right)}{\frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}}\frac{1}{1+\xi}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^{\alpha}}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}+\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\epsilon\tau_{t+1}}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Theta_{s,t}}\\
\frac{d\ln\left(R^0_{t+1}\right)}{d\tau_t} =&(1-\alpha)\left(\frac{d\ln\left(h_{t+1}\right)}{d\ln\left(s_t\right)}-1\right)\frac{d\ln\left(s_t\right)}{d\tau_t}
\end{aligned}$$

B.3 With CRRA-GHH preferences and informal savings

With CRRA preferences it is no longer the case that future policy is independent of the capital stock. But conditional on this state variable, with GHH preferences it is still the case that the distribution of savings for formal workers, $\{s_{t-1,i}/s_{t-1}\}_{i>0}$, remains a function of s_{t-1} and τ_t and is thus not an independent state variable. Thus, the policy function can be written as a function of two endogenous states: s_{t-1} and $s_{t-1,0}/s_{t-1}$.

Compared to the log-GHH case, we adjust the definition of the politico-economic equilibria derivative $dx_t/d\tau_t$ to include the effect through both states such that

$$\frac{dx_t}{d\tau_t}=\frac{\partial x_t}{\partial\tau_t}+\frac{\partial x_t}{\partial\tau_{t+1}}\left(\frac{\partial\tau_t^{+1}}{\partial s_t}\frac{ds_t}{d\tau_t}+\frac{\partial\tau_t^{+1}}{\partial(s_{t,0}/s_t)}\frac{d(s_{t,0}/s_t)}{d\tau_t}\right).$$

The first order condition identifying the politico-economic choice τ_t is now given by

$$\begin{aligned}
&\omega\sum_{j\geq 0}\gamma_j\underbrace{\left(c^j_{2,t}\right)^{\frac{\rho-1}{\rho}}\frac{d\ln\left(c^j_{2,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}}_{\equiv\mathcal{E}^j_{2,t}}\\
&+\nu_t\sum_{j\geq 0}\gamma_j\underbrace{\left(\left(\tilde{c}^j_{1,t}\right)^{\frac{\rho-1}{\rho}}\frac{d\ln\left(\tilde{c}^j_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t}+\beta\left(c^j_{2,t+1}\right)^{\frac{\rho-1}{\rho}}\frac{d\ln\left(c^j_{2,t+1}\right)}{d\tau_t}\right)}_{\equiv\mathcal{E}^j_{1,t}}\leq 0,
\end{aligned}$$

The log-derivatives $d\ln\left(c^j_{2,t}\right)/d\tau_t$ follow from the formulas for the log-GHH case and consumption levels $c^j_{2,t}$ depend on the state s_{t-1} and are given in appendix A.1.

For formal working households, we use the Euler equation to write indirect utility as

$$\begin{aligned}
v^i_{1,t} =&(1+B_{t+1})\frac{\left(\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}\right)^{1-1/\rho}}{1-1/\rho}=\frac{\left(\hat{c}^i_{1,t}\right)^{1-1/\rho}}{1-1/\rho}\\
\hat{c}^i_{1,t} =&\left(\frac{h_t}{\Gamma_h}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}}(1+B_{t+1})^{\frac{1}{\rho-1}}\mathcal{C}^i_{1,t}
\end{aligned}$$

$$\mathcal{C}^i_{1,t} = \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^\xi}\frac{1}{1+\xi} + \Gamma_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}(1-\theta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}$$

The marginal effect of taxes can then be summed up by

$$\frac{dv^i_{1,t}}{d\tau_t} = \left(\hat{c}^i_{1,t}\right)^{1-1/\rho}\frac{d\ln\left(\hat{c}^i_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t} \tag{B.15}$$

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{d\ln\left(\hat{c}^i_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t} =& \frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\frac{d\ln(h_t)}{d\tau_t} + \frac{B_{t+1}}{1+B_{t+1}}(1-\alpha)\left(\frac{d\ln(h_{t+1})}{d\ln(s_t)} - 1\right)\frac{d\ln(s_t)}{d\tau_t} \\ &+ \frac{\Gamma_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{1-\theta}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(\frac{d\tau_{t+1}}{d\tau_t} + \tau_{t+1}\frac{d\ln(\Gamma_{s,t})}{d\tau_t}\right)}{\frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^\xi}\frac{1}{1+\xi} + \Gamma_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}(1-\theta)}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}\end{aligned} \tag{B.16}$$

For the young informal households, we can employ the Euler equation in a similar way and write:

$$\begin{aligned}v^0_{1,t} =& \frac{\left(\tilde{c}^0_{1,t}(1+B^0_{t+1})^{\frac{\rho}{\rho-1}}\right)^{1-1/\rho}}{1-1/\rho} = \frac{\left(\hat{c}^0_{1,t}\right)^{1-1/\rho}}{1-1/\rho} \\ \hat{c}^0_{1,t} =& \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\sigma_s}(1+B^0_{t+1})^{\frac{1}{\rho-1}}\mathcal{C}^0_{1,t} \\ \mathcal{C}^0_{1,t} =& \frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^\xi}\frac{1}{1+\xi}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^\alpha}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} + \Theta_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\end{aligned}$$

We then have that:

$$\frac{dv^0_{1,t}}{d\tau_t} = \left(\hat{c}^0_{1,t}\right)^{1-1/\rho}\frac{d\ln\left(\hat{c}^0_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t} \tag{B.17}$$

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{d\ln\left(\hat{c}^0_{1,t}\right)}{d\tau_t} =& \frac{B^0_{t+1}}{1+B^0_{t+1}}(1-\alpha)\left(\frac{d\ln(h_{t+1})}{d\ln(s_t)} - 1\right)\frac{d\ln(s_t)}{d\tau_t} \\ &+ \frac{\Theta_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(\frac{d\tau_{t+1}}{d\tau_t} + \tau_{t+1}\frac{d\ln(\Theta_{s,t})}{d\tau_t}\right)}{\frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^\xi}\frac{1}{1+\xi}\left(\frac{1-\alpha}{\Gamma_h^\alpha}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} + \Theta_{s,t}\frac{1-\alpha}{r_0\alpha}\frac{\tau_{t+1}\epsilon}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}}\end{aligned} \tag{B.18}$$

C Endogenous pension design

This appendix collects the derivations behind section 7: the corner that costless redistribution produces, the deadweight cost of redistribution, what the cost changes in the equilibrium of appendices A and B, and the state independence of the design choice under log preferences. Throughout there are no informal households, $\gamma_0 = 0$, so the budget (8) gives $\bar{b}_t = \nu_t w_t h_t \tau_t / h_{t-1}$ and a retiree of type i the benefit $\nu_t w_t h_t \tau_t \left(1 + \theta_t \left[y_i - 1\right]\right)$, where $y_i \equiv \eta_i^{1+\xi}/(X_i^\xi \Gamma_h) = \eta_i h_{t-1,i}/h_{t-1}$ is the labor income of type i relative to the mean by

(A.3), and $\sum_i \gamma_i y_i = 1$.

C.1 Costless redistribution

We consider three timings of the choice. If θ_t is chosen at t together with τ_t, it re-splits benefits that current retirees have already earned. Current labor supply and savings depend on the design that will apply to the benefits they earn, θ_{t+1}, so the choice moves no economic decision, and its marginal effect on the political objective (14) runs entirely through current retirees,

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{W}_t}{\partial \theta_t} = \omega \sum_i \gamma_i \mu_i \frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_t \left(y_i - 1\right)}{\frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_t \left(1 + \theta_t \left[y_i - 1\right]\right)}. \tag{C.1}$$

The numerator is the change in the benefit of type i and averages to zero across types: a more Bismarckian split moves a given total from retirees below mean income to retirees above it. The denominator is proportional to the consumption of a retiree of type i and rises with income. With equal propensities to vote the sum therefore weights the gains of the rich by a lower marginal utility than the losses of the poor. The following proposition makes the argument exact.

Proposition 4. *Assume log-GHH preferences, no informal households and no deadweight cost of redistribution (section 7.1), and let the design θ_t that applies to the benefits paid at t be chosen at t together with τ_t. Let the propensities to vote be positive and not rise with relative income, $\mu_i \leq \mu_j$ whenever $y_i > y_j$, equal propensities included, and let relative incomes not all be equal. Then, for every $\omega > 0$ and $\tau_t > 0$, the derivative (C.1) is negative at every $\theta_t \in [0, 1]$ at which every retiree's consumption is positive, and the design chosen together with a positive tax is the Beveridgean corner, $\theta_t = 0$. This holds for all values of α, β, ξ, ν_t, γ_i, η_i and X_i, and whatever tax and design current retirees expected when they saved.*

Proof of proposition 4. By (11) the labor supply and the savings of the young at t depend on the design that will apply to their own benefits, θ_{t+1}, and not on θ_t, so θ_t enters no state at $t+1$ and no later decision. It enters $\mathcal{W}_t$ only through the consumption of current retirees (appendix A.1, with $\gamma_0 = 0$),

$$c^i_{2,t} = \alpha \nu_t h_t^{1-\alpha} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\alpha} D_i, \qquad D_i \equiv \frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_t \left(1 + \theta_t \left[y_i - 1\right]\right), \tag{C.2}$$

where the first factor is common to all types and independent of θ_t. From (14),

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{W}_t}{\partial \theta_t} = \omega \sum_i \gamma_i \mu_i \frac{\partial \ln c^i_{2,t}}{\partial \theta_t} = \omega \, \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \, \tau_t \sum_i \gamma_i \left(y_i - 1\right) \frac{\mu_i}{D_i},$$

which is (C.1). We sign the sum in three steps.

First, relative incomes average to one. By the definition of Γ_h in (A.3), $\sum_i \gamma_i y_i = 1$, and since $\sum_i \gamma_i = 1$ (section 2.1), $\sum_i \gamma_i (y_i - 1) = 0$: the design moves a given total between retirees below and above mean income.

Second, D_i rises with y_i. The savings of current retirees were chosen at $t-1$. By part iii of proposition 1, that is (A.8) with $B_{t+1} = \beta$, in which the tax and the design are those that apply to the benefits of the generation that saves,

$$\frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}} = y_i + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{\tau_t^e (1-\theta_t^e)}{1+\beta} (y_i - 1),$$

where τ_t^e and θ_t^e are the tax and the design that generation $t-1$ expected for period t. Whatever these were, the slope in y_i is at least one, since $\tau_t^e \geq 0$ and $\theta_t^e \leq 1$. The second term of D_i has slope $\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_t\theta_t \geq 0$, so D_i rises with y_i with a slope of at least one, and by (C.2) it is positive wherever every retiree's consumption is.

Third, Chebyshev's sum inequality: for weights $\gamma_i \geq 0$ that sum to one,

$$\sum_i \gamma_i a_i b_i - \sum_i \gamma_i a_i \sum_j \gamma_j b_j = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{i,j} \gamma_i \gamma_j (a_i - a_j)(b_i - b_j),$$

which is non-positive when a_i and b_i are ordered in opposite directions. Let $a_i = y_i - 1$ and $b_i = \mu_i / D_i$. If $y_i > y_j$, then $\mu_i \leq \mu_j$ and $D_i > D_j > 0$, so $b_i < b_j$, and every term with $y_i \neq y_j$ is negative. Since $\sum_i \gamma_i a_i = 0$ by the first step and relative incomes are not all equal, $\sum_i \gamma_i (y_i - 1) \mu_i / D_i < 0$, and so is the derivative.

Finally, D_i falls with θ_t only for types below mean income, and $D_i \geq 1$ for the others. The designs at which every retiree's consumption is positive therefore form an interval that starts at $\theta_t = 0$ whenever there are any, $\mathcal{W}_t$ is strictly decreasing on it, and the design chosen with any positive tax is $\theta_t = 0$.

The proof uses the propensities to vote only through the ratios μ_i / D_i, which order the types as $\mu_i / c_{2,t}^i$ does. The derivative is therefore negative at every design at which propensities to vote rise with relative income, if at all, by proportionally less than consumption in retirement, $\mu_i / \mu_j < c_{2,t}^i / c_{2,t}^j$ whenever $y_i > y_j$, and a design other than the Beveridgean corner requires propensities to vote that, for some pair of types and at some design, rise at least as fast as consumption. In the political objective μ_i is the weight of type i relative to its share of the population, of which turnout is the observable part. A responsiveness to policy that differed across types, the density of swing voters in probabilistic voting (Lindbeck and Weibull 1987), would multiply μ_i and enter the threshold in the same place, so the threshold bounds the product of turnout and responsiveness, and the calibration measures only the first. The argument also holds under CRRA-GHH preferences at every intertemporal elasticity: the design still enters only the consumption of current retirees, whose marginal utility is $D_i^{-1/\rho}$ times a factor common to all types,

and relative savings keep the form of (A.8) with a discount term B_t common to all types, so $\mu_i D_i^{-1/\rho}$ takes the place of μ_i/D_i and the threshold becomes $\mu_i/\mu_j < (c^i_{2,t}/c^j_{2,t})^{1/\rho}$. It is stricter than under log preferences when $\rho > 1$ and looser when $\rho < 1$: at $\rho = 2$ the ratio of propensities to vote must stay below the square root of the ratio of consumption in retirement, at $\rho = 0.5$ below its square.

Propensities to vote that rise with income can overturn the corner, and they do rise in the U.S. calibration of section 6, so there the sign is a quantitative matter: evaluated at the calibrated 2020 equilibrium, (C.1) is negative over the whole interval, at every date of the projection and at $\rho = 0.5$, 1 and 2, and the choice is the corner $\theta_t = 0$. With the middle income group at the mean, the sign of (C.1) is set by the threshold for the high- and the low-income group, which binds at $\theta_t = 0$, where the ratio of their consumption in retirement is lowest, 3.39 in 2020. The corner therefore survives until the weight of the high-income group is 3.4 times that of the low-income one at $\rho = 1$, twice the observed turnout ratio of 1.61. This critical ratio is 11.5 at $\rho = 0.5$ and 1.84 at $\rho = 2$. Along the projection a larger system compresses consumption in retirement, and at $\rho = 2$ the critical ratio falls to 1.76 from 2080 on.

If instead θ_{t+1} is chosen at t, the design no longer touches the benefits of current retirees but moves current labor supply and savings, directly and through the anticipated response of τ_{t+1}. With the political objective (14) the marginal effect is

$$\frac{\partial \mathcal{W}_t}{\partial \theta_{t+1}} = \sum_i \gamma_i \mu_i \left[\omega \, (1-\alpha) \frac{d \ln \Theta_{h,t}}{d\theta_{t+1}} + \nu_t \left((1+\beta) \frac{d \ln \tilde{c}^i_{1,t}}{d\theta_{t+1}} + \beta \frac{d \ln R_{t+1}}{d\theta_{t+1}} \right) \right], \tag{C.3}$$

where $\Theta_{h,t}$ is the labor supply function (A.6) and each total derivative includes the response of τ_{t+1}, and of θ_{t+2}, to the design chosen. Retirees are unanimous, since their term does not depend on i, and at a given anticipated tax they favour a more earnings-related system: a higher θ_{t+1} raises the return to an hour worked at t and with it the labor supply on which their benefits are levied. The young are divided between this forward-looking stake and the redistribution of their own future benefits, the force of (C.1) one period ahead. The equilibrium is a sequence of policy functions over the inherited design, identified by backward induction as in section 4, and at observed U.S. inequality and under log preferences the redistributive force dominates: the choice is again the corner $\theta = 0$. Section 7 adopts this timing. Of the three, it is the one that keeps the Markov structure and lets the design move labor supply and savings before it binds: a design chosen with the tax moves no decision, and a design chosen once and for all requires a commitment that the Markov equilibria of the paper do not have. It also mirrors how reforms of benefit formulas are legislated, applying to future benefits and leaving benefits in payment untouched.

A design chosen once and for all enters every channel at once. The joint choice of τ_{t_0} and θ is nevertheless one-dimensional, since at any candidate design the first order

condition for the tax is the tax condition of appendix B.1 at that design, and the predetermined distribution of savings is held at the value the chosen design implies, which makes the equilibrium a fixed point. The outcome is again a corner: $\theta = 0$ under log preferences, and under CRRA preferences the Bismarckian corner $\theta = 1$ at high intertemporal elasticities, where the forward-looking channels are strong. Near the elasticity at which the corner switches the electorate is close to indifferent between the two, so the switch is not sharply located. The online appendix reports the three timings at the intertemporal elasticities we check (online appendix); the technical documentation gives the algorithms (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026).

C.2 The deadweight cost of redistribution

This subsection spells out the argument behind the form of the cost in section 7.1. It motivates the form rather than deriving it from a model of participation and formality, and it leaves the size of the loss to the calibration.

The implicit tax. A purely earnings-related system that pays out the same revenue returns $\Pi_t \tau_t$ per unit of past earnings to every type, with Π_t the pay-as-you-go return factor of section 7.1. Against that benchmark the flat component levies the implicit tax t_i of (15) on type i: a tax on types above mean income, a subsidy to types below it, and a pure transfer in the aggregate, since $\sum_i \gamma_i y_i t_i = 0$. It is the redistributive part of the tax component of the contribution in the sense of Summers (1989), the part of the payroll charge that buys the contributor no benefit.

Which margin. The wedge (15) is an average implicit tax: it compares what type i receives per unit of its earnings with the benchmark. The marginal wedge is a different object. The flat component depends on aggregate hours and not on own hours, so an extra hour raises the benefit of every type by $\Pi_t \tau_t \theta_t$ per unit of earnings, and the marginal wedge of the flat component, $\Pi_t \tau_t (1 - \theta_t)$, is common to all types. That wedge is already in the model: it is the group $\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \theta \tau_{t+1} \Gamma_{s,t}$ in the labor supply function (A.6), through which hours respond to the design with the Frisch elasticity ξ, and GHH preferences carry no income effect through which the transfers between types could move hours. A cost built on the hours margin would count that response twice and could not depend on the spread of incomes. The cost therefore stands for margins the model does not contain and on which the average wedge is the relevant one, participation and formality: a worker who decides whether to bring earnings into the system, or into the formal sector, compares the earnings at stake with what they buy, so the wedge that matters is the average tax on those earnings (Saez 2002; Kleven and Kreiner 2006). Participation is the margin on which Disney (2004) finds the tax component to matter. The reporting of earnings, on which Kumler et al. (2020) find it, is a different margin: how much of a given wage to

report responds to the marginal wedge $\Pi_t\tau_t(1-\theta_t)$, which does not vanish when incomes are equal, so a loss on that margin would not depend on the dispersion of relative incomes. The cost does not contain it, and we read the evidence on reporting as evidence that the tax component matters rather than as a margin the cost prices.

The Harberger loss. A set of proportional wedges t_i on bases e_i, each responding to its net-of-tax rate with a common elasticity ε, costs $\frac{1}{2}\varepsilon\sum_i \gamma_i t_i^2 e_i$ to second order in the wedges (Harberger 1964). The wedge (15) changes the benefit paid at t per unit of earnings made at $t-1$, when the elasticity applies, and a worker values a unit of benefit at t at $1/R_t$ units of goods at $t-1$, as the labor supply condition (6) does, so the rate that enters is t_i/R_t. Per unit of mean past earnings the bases are $e_i = y_i$, so the loss in goods of $t-1$ is $\frac{1}{2}\varepsilon\,(\Pi_t/R_t)^2\tau_t^2(1-\theta_t)^2\tilde{V}$ with

$$\tilde{V} \equiv \sum_i \gamma_i \frac{(y_i-1)^2}{y_i}, \tag{C.4}$$

while revenue per unit of mean past earnings is $\Pi_t\tau_t/R_t$ in the same goods. As a share of revenue the loss is therefore $\frac{1}{2}\varepsilon\,(\Pi_t/R_t)\,\tau_t\,(1-\theta_t)^2\,\tilde{V}$: quadratic in the flat share of the system, linear in its size and proportional to a dispersion of relative incomes that is zero when all incomes are equal. The quadratic counts the subsidy to types below mean income as a loss, as it does the tax on types above it; where participation is already taxed, lowering the participation tax of low-income workers can reduce the total loss (Saez 2002), so the symmetry is a property of the reduced form rather than of the argument.

Specification. The exponential form $f(\theta_t,\tau_t)$ of (16) scales both components of the benefit alike,

$$A(\theta_t,\tau_t) = f(\theta_t,\tau_t)\,\theta_t, \qquad B(\theta_t,\tau_t) = f(\theta_t,\tau_t)\,(1-\theta_t), \tag{C.5}$$

so that the surviving share of revenue is $A+B=f\in(0,1]$ and $1-f$ is, to first order, the Harberger share with λ in the place of $\varepsilon\Pi_t/R_t$.[35] The exponential keeps f positive for every λ and every size of system, and nests the model without the cost at $\lambda=0$. Three properties follow. Nothing is lost when nothing is redistributed, $f=1$ at $\theta_t=1$ and for every design when $\tilde{V}=0$. The loss per unit of redistribution rises with the size of the system, through τ_t. And the marginal cost of the first unit of redistribution is zero: $\partial\ln f/\partial\theta_t = \lambda\tau_t\tilde{V}(1-\theta_t)$ vanishes at $\theta_t=1$, as does $\partial\ln f/\partial\tau_t$, so that A, B and the tax, through which alone the design enters the equilibrium of appendix C.3, have there the values and slopes they have without the cost. Under log preferences, where the design

[35] The factor Π_t/R_t multiplies every implicit tax alike and so scales the loss once. It falls as the population ages, from 0.55 in 2020 to 0.46 in 2110 along the U.S. path of section 6 at $\rho=1$, and would make a structural cost parameter drift with demographics; we absorb it into λ, which is calibrated rather than derived.

chosen does not move the designs chosen later (proposition 5), the slope of the political objective at the Bismarckian corner, and the tax chosen there, therefore do not depend on λ. The cost can never by itself make the corner a local maximum of the political objective: an electorate whose objective falls towards the corner without the cost does not choose it at any value of λ. France's electorate is such a case, which is why no value of λ makes it re-elect its design (appendix G.1). Scaling both components alike is a choice. A cost on the flat component alone delivers the same endpoints and differs in the interior, but it loses the separate identification of θ and λ (appendix C.3). A cost on the design itself rather than on the transfer it performs, $f(\theta) = \phi + (1-\phi)\theta^p$, stays in place when a compressed income distribution removes the redistributive stakes; the online appendix reports it.

Magnitude. The shape of f follows from the tax component; its size does not. In the U.S. calibration for 2020 the return factor is $\Pi_t = 1.35$, close to ν_t (table 3), and the thirty-year return to which β is calibrated is $R_t = 2.44$ (appendix F), so that Π_t/R_t is about 0.55. Participation and taxable-income elasticities of 0.1 to 0.4 (Chetty et al. 2011; Saez et al. 2012) then correspond to λ between about 0.06 and 0.22. The calibrated values of section 7 are more than an order of magnitude above that range at every intertemporal elasticity, 51 to 205 times at $\rho = 1$ and 12 to 48 times at $\rho = 2$, where λ is smallest, so λ also stands in for administrative, evasion and political costs of redistribution that the model does not contain.

C.3 The equilibrium with the cost

With the cost, the benefit formula of (8) becomes

$$b_t^i = \left[A(\theta_t, \tau_t)\, h_{t-1,i}\eta_i + B(\theta_t, \tau_t)\, h_{t-1}\right] \bar{b}_t, \tag{C.6}$$

with $\bar{b}_t = \nu_t w_t h_t \tau_t / h_{t-1}$ the gross revenue per unit of past labor, of which a share $1-f$ does not reach retirees. The model without the cost is $(A, B) = (\theta_t, 1-\theta_t)$.

Economic equilibrium. In appendix A the design enters only through the groups $\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_{t+1}\theta_{t+1}$ and $\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_{t+1}(1-\theta_{t+1})$, in $\Gamma_{s,t}$, $\Theta_{h,t}$ and $s_{t,i}/s_t$, and through θ_t and $1-\theta_t$ in the benefits of current retirees. The cost is therefore exactly the substitution $\theta_{t+1} \mapsto A(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})$ and $1-\theta_{t+1} \mapsto B(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})$ in those groups, and $\theta_t \mapsto A(\theta_t, \tau_t)$, $1-\theta_t \mapsto B(\theta_t, \tau_t)$ in the benefit formula, and it changes nothing else. Under log preferences, (A.5), (A.6) and (A.8) read

$$\Gamma_{s,t} = \frac{1}{1+\xi}\,\frac{\Gamma_h \beta}{1+\beta+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_{t+1}\left[A(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})(1+\beta) + B(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})\right]}, \tag{C.7a}$$

$$\Theta_{h,t} = (\Gamma_h)^{\frac{1+\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \left(\frac{(1-\alpha)(1-\tau_t)}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} A(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})\, \tau_{t+1} \Gamma_{s,t}} \right)^{\frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}}, \tag{C.7b}$$

$$\frac{s_{t,i}}{s_t} = y_i + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \frac{B(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})\, \tau_{t+1}}{1+\beta} (y_i - 1), \tag{C.7c}$$

and the consumption of a retiree of type i carries $A(\theta_t, \tau_t)\, y_i + B(\theta_t, \tau_t)$ in place of $1 + \theta_t [y_i - 1]$ in (C.2). The two coincide when $A + B = 1$, so the model without the cost is nested exactly. Here τ_{t+1} is the tax the young anticipate for the period in which their benefits are paid, $\tau_{t+1} = \mathcal{T}_{t+1}(\theta_{t+1})$ with $\mathcal{T}_{t+1}$ the equilibrium tax function below, so the young anticipate both the design and the size of the system that will pay them.

The tax condition. The first order condition for the tax of appendix B.1 picks up one factor. The benefit term of the retirees' marginal effect $\mathcal{E}^i_{2,t}$ is multiplied by τ_t, and f now moves with τ_t, so

$$\mathcal{E}^i_{2,t} = (1-\alpha) \frac{\partial \ln(\Theta_{h,t})}{\partial \tau_t} + \frac{\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} [A(\theta_t, \tau_t)\, y_i + B(\theta_t, \tau_t)] \left(1 + \tau_t \frac{\partial \ln f(\theta_t, \tau_t)}{\partial \tau_t}\right)}{\frac{s_{t-1,i}}{s_{t-1}} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha} \tau_t [A(\theta_t, \tau_t)\, y_i + B(\theta_t, \tau_t)]}, \tag{C.8}$$

where $\partial \ln f / \partial \tau_t = -\frac{1}{2} \lambda \tilde{V} (1-\theta_t)^2$ and hence $1 + \tau_t\, \partial \ln f / \partial \tau_t = 1 + \ln f(\theta_t, \tau_t)$, since $\ln f$ is linear in τ_t: a larger system is worth less to a retiree at the margin than the revenue it collects, by the share of the marginal contribution that the flat component dissipates. Nothing else in the condition sees f. The term of the young, $\mathcal{E}^i_{1,t}$, contains no policy but τ_t, and $\partial \ln(\Theta_{h,t}) / \partial \tau_t = -\frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi} \frac{1}{1-\tau_t}$ is free of the groups, so the condition involves θ_{t+1} nowhere and the equilibrium tax at t is a function $\mathcal{T}_t(\theta_t)$ of the inherited design and of parameters and demographics alone, as in proposition 2.

Identification of θ. The replacement rate of type j, its benefit over its past earnings, is $\Pi_t \tau_t [A + B/y_j]$. The ratio of the replacement rates of two types, the datum that identifies θ in section 6, therefore depends on (A, B) only through $B/A = (1-\theta_t)/\theta_t$, from which f cancels: the design is identified separately from the cost, and $\theta^* = 0.728$ for the U.S. whatever λ. This is a property of the proportional specification. A cost on the flat component alone, $(A, B) = (\theta_t, f(1-\theta_t))$, leaves $B/A = f(1-\theta_t)/\theta_t$, so that the same datum implies a different θ for every value of the cost parameter and the two are identified jointly.

The design condition. With the design chosen one period in advance, θ_{t+1} enters the objective through $A(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})$ and $B(\theta_{t+1}, \tau_{t+1})$ in (C.7), with τ_{t+1} the anticipated equilibrium tax. At a given tax, $\partial A / \partial \theta_{t+1} = f + \theta_{t+1}\, \partial f / \partial \theta_{t+1}$ and $\partial B / \partial \theta_{t+1} = (1 - \theta_{t+1})\, \partial f / \partial \theta_{t+1} - f$ with $\partial f / \partial \theta_{t+1} = f \lambda \tau_{t+1} \tilde{V} (1 - \theta_{t+1})$, so

$$\frac{\partial A}{\partial \theta_{t+1}} + \frac{\partial B}{\partial \theta_{t+1}} = \frac{\partial f}{\partial \theta_{t+1}} = f\, \lambda\, \tau_{t+1}\, \tilde{V}\, (1 - \theta_{t+1}) \geq 0, \tag{C.9}$$

zero at $\theta_{t+1} = 1$. Since $\ln f = -\frac{1}{2}\lambda\tau_{t+1}\tilde{V}(1-\theta_{t+1})^2$, the derivative rises with the size of the system the young anticipate and with the dispersion of relative incomes if and only if $\ln f > -1$, and with the flat share $1-\theta_{t+1}$ if and only if $\ln f > -\frac{1}{2}$, that is $(1-\theta_{t+1})^2\lambda\tau_{t+1}\tilde{V} < 1$. The first condition holds wherever the anticipated tax is interior, since the benefit term of (C.8) carries the factor $1+\ln f$ and every other term of the tax condition is negative. The second holds near the calibrated design at every intertemporal elasticity but not near flat designs at $\rho = 0.5$, where a flat benefit at the 2020 tax rate loses 43.7% of revenue (table 4), more than the 39% at which $\ln f = -\frac{1}{2}$. At that tax it fails for designs below 0.067, where the loss is already so large that a further unit of flatness dissipates less at the margin. Without the cost a more Bismarckian design shifts next period's benefits one for one from the flat to the earnings-related component, $\partial A/\partial\theta_{t+1} = -\partial B/\partial\theta_{t+1} = 1$, and the redistributive stake of the young dominates as in appendix C.1. With it, and at a given anticipated tax, a more Bismarckian design also raises the total the young will receive, since it dissipates less, which is what lets the design condition cross zero in the interior.

C.4 The design choice under log preferences

Proposition 5. *Assume log-GHH preferences and no informal households, and let the design be chosen one period in advance under the cost* (C.5)*. Then the political objective at t is additively separable,*

$$\mathcal{W}_t = \mathcal{A}_t(\tau_t, \theta_t) + \mathcal{B}_t(\theta_{t+1}) + \mathcal{C}_t(s_{t-1}), \tag{C.10}$$

where $\mathcal{C}_t$ depends on no policy. The tax chosen at t depends on the inherited design, θ_t, and on neither θ_{t+1} nor s_{t-1}; the design chosen at t maximizes $\mathcal{B}_t$ alone and depends on neither θ_t nor s_{t-1}.

Proof of proposition 5. By (C.7b), $\Theta_{h,t}$ is the product of a factor in τ_t and a factor in $(\tau_{t+1}, \theta_{t+1})$, and $\tau_{t+1} = \mathcal{T}_{t+1}(\theta_{t+1})$ by the tax condition above, so by (A.6) $\ln h_t$ is the sum of a term in τ_t, a term in θ_{t+1} and $\frac{\alpha\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}\ln(s_{t-1}/\nu_t)$. The same holds for $\ln s_t = \frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\ln(h_t/\Gamma_h) + \ln\Gamma_{s,t}$ by (A.5), whose last term is a function of θ_{t+1} alone, and for $\ln\tilde{c}^i_{1,t}$, which by appendix A.1 is $\ln s_t$ plus the logarithm of a bracket in $\Gamma_{s,t}$, θ_{t+1} and τ_{t+1}. The return $\ln R_{t+1}$ is affine in $\ln(s_t/\nu_{t+1})$ and $\ln h_{t+1}$, and $\ln h_{t+1}$ is $\ln\Theta_{h,t+1}$ plus a multiple of $\ln(s_t/\nu_{t+1})$, where $\Theta_{h,t+1}$ depends on τ_{t+1} and on the continuation $(\theta_{t+2}, \tau_{t+2})$; by backward induction from the terminal period, in which no design is chosen, the design chosen at $t+1$ depends on no state, so the continuation is a function of θ_{t+1} alone and every term of the young's utility is a sum of terms in τ_t, in θ_{t+1} and in s_{t-1}. Finally, $\ln c^i_{2,t} = (1-\alpha)\ln h_t + \ln\left[s_{t-1,i}/s_{t-1} + \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\tau_t\left(A(\theta_t,\tau_t)\,y_i + B(\theta_t,\tau_t)\right)\right] + \alpha\ln(s_{t-1}/\nu_t) + \text{const}$, and $s_{t-1,i}/s_{t-1}$ is a function of (τ_t, θ_t) by (C.7c) at $t-1$. Every dependence of (14) on θ_{t+1}

therefore arrives additively, apart from the terms in (τ_t, θ_t) and in s_{t-1}, which is (C.10). The tax condition of appendix C.3, taken at the inherited savings shares and evaluated at the shares consistent with the tax, involves $\mathcal{A}_t$ alone, and the design chosen at t is the maximizer of $\mathcal{B}_t$.

The design chosen at t is thus the same whatever system the electorate inherits and whatever the capital stock, which is what section 4 uses: each date's choice is a search over a grid of designs with no state, the tax at each candidate design is found as in proposition 2, and the condition $\theta_{2020} = \theta^*$ that calibrates λ in section 7.2 is a function of λ alone. The property is specific to log preferences. Under CRRA preferences the powers do not separate, both s_{t-1} and θ_t re-enter the design choice, and the equilibrium is a backward recursion over policy functions of the state (s_{t-1}, θ_t) (Berg and Gonzalez-Eiras 2026).

D Terminal states and numerical checks

We consider two terminal states of the model: a finite-horizon version, in which the economy ends after $t = T$, and a steady-state version. The paper reports the finite-horizon solution, in periods of thirty years from 1960 to $T = 2200$ for the rich economies and from 1920 to $T = 2190$ for Argentina, with population growth held at its last projected rate after 2080 (2070 for Argentina). The appendix then reports three checks on the computed equilibria: how much they depend on the horizon and the terminal state, how many candidates and equilibria the solver finds, and how closely the policy functions solve their first order conditions between the nodes of their grids.

Finite horizon. In the finite horizon, consumption functions and indirect utility in economic equilibrium are those of the general case in every period $t < T$. For the young generations at time T, we simply say that

$$u_{T,j} = u_j\left(c^j_{1,T}, h_{T,j}\right).$$

In this case, the economic equilibrium at $t = T$ is the general formulation with $\beta = \tau_{t+1} = s_t = s_{t,j} = 0$. Specifically:

$$h_t = (\Gamma_h)^{\frac{1}{1+\alpha\xi}} \left((1-\alpha)(1-\tau_t)\right)^{\frac{\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \left(\frac{s_{t-1}}{\nu_t}\right)^{\frac{\alpha\xi}{1+\alpha\xi}} \tag{D.1}$$

$$h_{t,i} = h_t \frac{(\eta_i/X_i)^\xi}{\Gamma_h} \tag{D.2}$$

$$\tilde{c}^i_{1,t} = \frac{1}{1+\xi} \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}}{X_i^\xi} \left(\frac{h_t}{\Gamma_h}\right)^{\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}} \tag{D.3}$$

$$\tilde{c}_{1,t}^{0} = \frac{1}{1+\xi}\frac{\eta_0^{1+\xi}}{X_0^{\xi}}\left(w_t^0\right)^{1+\xi}. \tag{D.4}$$

For the retired generation, the relevant consumption functions are unchanged.

For the politico-economic equilibrium, the marginal effect of τ_t on retirees is the same as for $t < T$. For working households, the effects are much simpler, namely:

$$\mathcal{E}_{1,t}^{i} = \left(\tilde{c}_{1,t}^{i}\right)^{1-1/\rho}\frac{1+\xi}{\xi}\frac{\partial \ln\left(h_t\right)}{\partial \tau_t} \tag{D.5}$$

$$\mathcal{E}_{1,t}^{0} = 0 \tag{D.6}$$

Steady state, infinite horizon. In the steady-state version, population growth stays at its last projected rate forever, and the equilibrium is the limit of finite-horizon equilibria as the horizon grows. We compute it as the finite horizon extended by 40 periods: the policy at the paper's T then no longer changes from one period to the next (table 6), so that T is the start of a steady state. In a steady state, where the tax and the design are constant, the equations for aggregate labor supply and savings combine into:

$$s^* = \Gamma_h^{1+\xi}\left[\left(\frac{(1-\alpha)(1-\tau)}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_s}\right)^{1+\xi}\frac{\Gamma_s^{1+\alpha\xi}}{\nu^{\alpha(1+\xi)}}\right]^{\frac{1}{1-\alpha}} \tag{D.7}$$

$$\Gamma_s = \frac{1}{1+\xi}\frac{\Gamma_h B}{1+B+\frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\tau}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\left(1+\theta B\right)} \tag{D.8}$$

$$B = (\beta)^{\rho}\left(R^*\right)^{\rho-1}, \qquad R^* = \alpha\left(\frac{s^*}{\nu h^*}\right)^{\alpha-1}$$

$$\frac{s^*}{\nu h^*} = \frac{(s^*)^{\frac{1}{1+\xi}}\Gamma_s^{\frac{\xi}{1+\xi}}}{\nu\Gamma_h} = \left(\frac{(1-\alpha)(1-\tau)}{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_s}\frac{\Gamma_s}{\nu}\right)^{\frac{1}{1-\alpha}} \tag{D.9}$$

We can use this to write the discount function as

$$B = (\beta)^{\rho}\left(\alpha\frac{\Gamma_h - \frac{1-\alpha}{\alpha}\frac{\theta\tau}{1+\gamma_0\epsilon}\Gamma_s}{(1-\alpha)(1-\tau)}\frac{\nu}{\Gamma_s}\right)^{\rho-1} \tag{D.10}$$

The horizon and the terminal state. Table 6 reports the paper's equilibria solved again with the backward induction started two periods earlier, three periods later and from the steady state: the U.S. with the design given and with the design chosen, and Argentina in its baseline and with the universal pension. Under log preferences the U.S. tax at a date before T cannot depend on the horizon, since without informal households the condition at each date does not involve the continuation (proposition 3). Under CRRA preferences and with informal savers the policy functions carry a state through which the horizon could reach the calibration year, but it matters little there. No tax

rate in the calibration year changes by more than 0.03 p.p., no savings rate by more than 0.013 p.p. of GDP, and the design chosen in 2020 does not change at the third decimal. The largest change, 0.030 p.p., is in Argentina's response to the universal pension at $\rho = 0.5$ when the horizon is two periods shorter; in the U.S. it is 0.027 p.p., at $\rho = 0.5$ under the steady state. One period later the changes are of the same size, at most 0.028 p.p. in a tax rate.

Equilibrium counts. The candidates for the tax at a state are the two corners and every crossing of the first order condition. At every state and date the solver records their number and the number that pass the equilibrium test of section 4; the exact recursion with the design chosen under CRRA preferences records the same for the design. Table 7 reports the largest of these counts for each solve behind the paper's exhibits, and the online appendix lists them for every file of results. Every solve that records the counts has one equilibrium at every state and date, with one exception in the choice of the design. At one state and date, in the U.S. with its taste for leisure rescaled to France's level at $\rho = 0.5$ and under the cost on the design itself (appendix C.2), no design passes the test, and the solver ranks the designs there by the political objective, each at its own consistent distribution of savings. Since the corners are always candidates, the count of candidates for the tax is at least two, and it never exceeds three, the corners and one crossing. Under log-GHH preferences with no informal households, or with hand-to-mouth ones and $\xi(1 - 2\alpha) \leq 1$, one equilibrium follows from proposition 3, and a larger count there would be a numerical failure rather than a selection. Under CRRA preferences and with informal savers the count is the evidence that the proposition does not provide.

Accuracy off the grid. The policy functions are computed at the nodes of a grid of states, and the equilibrium path enters each period between them. Table 8 compares the policy function at such states with the root of the period's first order condition there. On the path the two differ by less than 0.001 p.p. of the tax rate in the U.S. and 0.01 p.p. in Argentina. Over the states the path visits, the difference stays below 0.003 p.p. in the U.S. and below 0.02 p.p. in Argentina, except at $\rho = 0.5$ in the periods before 2010, where it reaches 0.22 p.p. There the policy, which the solver smooths across states, departs from the root at the nodes as much as between them. Larger differences arise only at states the path never visits. The condition carries derivatives in the tax that are computed numerically, and with derivatives converged on a finer tax grid the difference on the path is at most 0.003 p.p. in the U.S. and 0.014 p.p. in Argentina. The U.S. results use a grid of 150 states; on one of 50 the difference on the path rises to 0.050 p.p. at $\rho = 0.5$.

Table 6: The horizon and the terminal condition

Outcome	ρ	**Paper's T**		**Shorter**		**Longer**		**Steady state**	
United States		2020	2050	2020	2050	2020	2050	2020	2050
Tax rate (%), design given	0.5	10.52	16.03	+0.003	+0.006	+0.011	+0.010	+0.027	+0.028
	1.0	10.52	15.75	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	10.52	15.19	−0.005	+0.005	−0.001	+0.005	0.000	+0.007
Savings rate (% of GDP), design given	0.5	15.83	14.60	−0.002	−0.005	−0.005	−0.004	−0.013	−0.014
	1.0	15.30	14.15	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	14.81	13.82	0.000	−0.001	−0.001	−0.002	−0.001	−0.002
Design θ, chosen	0.5	0.728	0.799	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	1.0	0.728	0.802	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	0.728	0.802	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Tax rate (%), design chosen	0.5	10.53	15.75	0.000	+0.002	+0.002	0.000	+0.005	−0.001
	1.0	10.52	15.46	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	10.56	15.13	−0.001	−0.002	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Savings rate (% of GDP), design chosen	0.5	15.95	14.79	−0.001	−0.006	−0.001	0.000	−0.001	0.000
	1.0	15.37	14.26	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	14.81	13.82	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Argentina		2010	2040	2010	2040	2010	2040	2010	2040
Tax rate (%)	0.5	11.81	20.11	−0.005	+0.028	0.000	−0.001	−0.003	−0.005
	1.0	11.81	19.75	0.000	−0.003	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	11.81	18.80	+0.001	−0.002	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Savings rate (% of GDP)	0.5	13.83	12.33	−0.003	−0.011	0.000	0.000	+0.001	+0.001
	1.0	13.33	11.56	0.000	−0.001	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	12.78	10.93	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
Universal pension: change in the tax rate (p.p.)	0.5	−0.42	+1.75	+0.030	−0.016	+0.001	−0.004	+0.004	−0.001
	1.0	+1.95	+3.47	−0.008	+0.021	0.000	0.000	0.000	0.000
	2.0	+2.03	+3.29	−0.006	−0.008	0.000	−0.001	0.000	−0.001

Note: Every parameter at its calibrated value at the paper's horizon, $T = 2200$ in the United States and 2190 in Argentina; the first two columns are the levels there. The other columns are the change against them at the same date: shorter, with the backward induction started two periods earlier ($T = 2140$ and 2130); longer, three periods later ($T = 2290$ and 2280); and under the steady-state terminal condition of appendix D, population growth held at its last projected rate from the last projection date on and the policy functions stationary from there, computed as the finite horizon extended by 40 periods (at the paper's T its tax policy differs from that of the period after by at most 7.9×10^{-7} over the states the path visits). Tax and savings rates in percent and their changes in percentage points, the design in units of θ. Under log preferences ($\rho = 1$) the U.S. tax at every date and the design chosen at every date but $T - 1$ do not depend on the horizon. The design is chosen one period ahead under the paper's cost, at its calibrated λ; in Argentina the universal pension is that of section 5, its change against the baseline of the same horizon.

Table 7: Equilibrium counts in the results the exhibits read

		Rows		Largest number of		
Solves	**Files**	all	counted	equilibria	candidates	**Fallbacks**
Tax rule: Argentina						
Calibrations	2	32	32	1	3	0
Experiments	64	448	224	1	3	0
Equilibria over designs	2	756	756	1	3	0
Numerical checks	2	114	114	1	3	0
Tax rule: the U.S., the UK and France						
Calibrations	6	96	96	1	3	0
Experiments	4	216	120	1	3	0
Endogenous design	14	350	188	1	3	0
Numerical checks	5	240	174	1	3	0
Design layer of the exact CRRA recursion						
Endogenous design	5	208	80	1	1	1
Numerical checks	2	75	66	1	1	0

Note: The files of results that the exhibits read, grouped by the solves that wrote them: per group the files, their rows, the rows that record the counts, and over these the largest number of equilibria at any state and period, the largest number of candidates, and the number of states at which no candidate passed the equilibrium test and the solver fell back. The other rows select nothing at that layer (the economic-equilibrium rows, with taxes held at the baseline path; the tax of the exact recursion, selected inside its design layer; the cost calibrations that failed; the rows with the design pinned) or were written before the counts existed; the online appendix lists every file. The tax rule's candidates are the two corners and the crossings of the first order condition; the design layer's are the brackets of its consistency residual. Every counted row has one equilibrium at every state and period, except where no candidate passed: the solver fell back at one state of the design layer in escShocksCRRA.csv ($\rho = 0.5$, the cost on the design, frLeisure, design chosen, exact recursion).

Table 8: First order condition residuals off the grid

ρ	Grid	As solved				Converged derivatives			
		Path	Visited, max	Visited, 99%	All, max	Path	Visited, max	Visited, 99%	All, max
United States, CRRA preferences									
0.5	150	5.3×10^{-4}	0.0024	0.0020	0.46	0.0028	0.0045	0.0043	0.45
2.0	150	8.8×10^{-4}	0.0023	0.0022	0.41	0.0013	0.0015	0.0014	0.41
0.5	50	0.050	0.091	0.090	1.7	0.050	0.094	0.093	1.8
2.0	50	0.0065	0.018	0.017	1.8	0.0069	0.019	0.018	1.7
Argentina									
0.5	45×45	0.0064	0.22	0.14	0.35	0.0098	0.23	0.14	0.34
1.0	45	0.0012	0.0023	0.0021	0.0028	0.0024	0.0046	0.0039	0.0046
2.0	45×45	0.0082	0.014	0.011	0.014	0.014	0.029	0.025	0.029

Note: Each cell is the largest (or 99th percentile) absolute difference, in percentage points of the tax rate, between the root of the first order condition at a state and the policy function there, over the periods of the paper's horizon: at the state the equilibrium path enters each period with, at the centres of the state grid's cells within the range the path visits (padded by a fifth), and at the centres of all its cells. The grid column gives the nodes of the state grid. The root is located by the selection of every period, without the smoothing of the policy, against the solved continuation. The first four columns evaluate the condition as the solver does; the last four with its derivatives in the tax converged, on a tax grid of 801 nodes in the U.S. and 401 in Argentina. Both solvers differentiate along $\ln(1-\tau)$: the U.S. one with a least-squares cubic spline whose knots are 0.04 apart in the tax, Argentina's with an interpolating spline. Solved at every period with converged derivatives and the calibrated parameters, the U.S. tax in 2020 is 10.52% and 10.52% at $\rho = 0.5$ and 2.0 (the calibration's 10.52%), and the difference between $\theta = 0$ and $\theta = 1$ is 9.11 and 1.99 p.p. against 9.13 and 1.99 p.p. Log preferences in the U.S. have no state.

E Calibration – Argentina

This appendix holds the data, the identifying formulas and the sources behind table 1, which section 5 summarizes.

E.1 The household survey

The Encuesta Permanente de Hogares (EPH) of the Instituto Nacional de Estadística y Censos (INDEC) is Argentina's main household survey of employment, hours and income, and the basis of its official labor market statistics. It is a continuous quarterly survey of the urban agglomerates, 31 metropolitan areas at present, in which households are drawn by a stratified multi-stage design. We use the last two quarters of 2006, a phase of sustained expansion after the recovery from the 2001–2002 crisis, at the start of the expansion of coverage under the amnesties (figure 5.1) and before the Great Recession. The survey asks respondents whether they contribute to social security, which separates formal from informal workers, and we keep those aged 25 to 60.

E.2 The pension system before and after the reform

Before the tax amnesties, retirees over the age of 70 who had made contributions for a minimum of 10 years were eligible for basic pension coverage. This coverage consisted of 70% of the minimum pension and a proportional amount from other contributions.[36] We calculate the pre-reform ϵ as

$$\epsilon = 0.7\left(1-\theta+\theta\frac{\eta_1 h_{t-1,1}}{h_{t-1}}\right)\frac{\beta^{5/30\,\frac{\mathrm{LE}_{\mathrm{men}}-5}{\mathrm{LE}_{\mathrm{men}}}}+\beta^{10/30\,\frac{\mathrm{LE}_{\mathrm{women}}-10}{\mathrm{LE}_{\mathrm{women}}}}}{2},$$

where $\mathrm{LE}_{\mathrm{men}} = 14.45$ and $\mathrm{LE}_{\mathrm{women}} = 22.55$ are the expected life expectancy for men and women, respectively, from their retirement ages (women retire at age 60, men at 65), such that the formula above corrects for the basic pension being received 5 or 10 years after the formal retirement age.[37] We set γ_0 so that informal households are 32% of all households, the share of the population over 65 without a pension before the reform, in 2004 (Rofman and Oliveri 2012); since the formal shares sum to one, $\gamma_0 = 0.32/0.68 = 0.47$. These households include those aged 65 to 69 with at least ten years of contributions, who

[36] The basic pension was set by Law 24,347 of 1994 at 70% of the first pillar, denoted "prestación básica universal", plus the corresponding fully-funded or pay-as-you-go benefit. For simplicity we assume the latter on average was also 70% of the benefits received by workers that had at least 30 years of contributions. Thus, basic pensions were 70% of the benefits received by the least productive formal workers.

[37] To estimate life expectancy at retirement age for Argentina we conduct a regression analysis using data for men and women's life expectancies at birth and at age 65 for 40 OECD countries for the year 2000. We then use the fitted regression and data from the World Bank on male and female life expectancy at birth in Argentina in 2000.

would draw the basic pension at 70, the delay for which ϵ is discounted, and those with fewer than ten years, who would never draw it. Section 5 also reports the reform when every informal household is of the second kind, with $\epsilon = 0$ before the reform and the model recalibrated to the same targets. To identify the Bismarckian incentives, we use OECD data on the ratio of replacement rates, RR, at half mean and mean wages for males and females.[38] Specifically, we adjust θ to ensure that

$$RR \equiv \frac{\theta + (1-\theta)\frac{h_t}{\eta_3 h_{t,3}}}{\theta + (1-\theta)\frac{h_t}{\eta_1 h_{t,1}}} = \frac{0.678}{0.803},$$

where types 1 and 3, the first and the third quartiles, are those whose mean incomes are closest to half the formal average and to the average, at 0.46 and 0.97 times that average.

E.3 Technology, demographics, and the aggregate targets

The capital income share is that of the formal sector. In the model, informal households produce outside Y_t and K_t, and national accounts book the output of unincorporated household enterprises, where most informal work sits, as mixed income, which a share computed as one minus the wage bill over GDP counts entirely as capital (Gollin 2002). The economy-wide share for Argentina is 0.43 (Frankema 2010). If a share y of GDP is informal mixed income, the formal-sector share is $(0.43-y)/(1-y)$. Informal earnings of about 5% of GDP, as in the household survey, give 0.40, while shadow-economy estimates of 20–25% of GDP give 0.24 to 0.29. We take $\alpha = 0.35$, which also puts Argentina on the same footing as the Gollin-adjusted shares we use for the rich economies in section 6. We set the Frisch elasticity of labor supply to $\xi = 0.30$. To calibrate β, we target the capital-output ratio. A model period is thirty years and capital depreciates fully between periods, so the capital stock per worker in place at t is the previous generation's savings, $k_t = s_{t-1}/\nu_t$, and with Cobb–Douglas production $K_t/Y_t = \alpha/R_t$ — a stock relative to one period, i.e. thirty years, of output. Thirty times that ratio is the capital-output ratio as the national accounts report it. Targeting it is therefore essentially equivalent to targeting the thirty-year interest rate, which for Argentina is not credibly measured. We target $K/Y = 3.23$, Argentina's ratio in 2010.[39] The model matches it with capital over

[38] In a pure Bismarckian system the replacement rate would be the same at all wage levels, such that $RR = 1$, while in a pure Beveridgean it would double if we halve wages, implying $RR = 0.5$. Note that we combine men and women since we do not have data separately on the increase in coverage or government spending by gender.

[39] Capital stock and GDP at constant national prices (`rnna`, `rgdpna`) from the Penn World Table 11.0 (Feenstra et al. 2015), retrieved through FRED. We read it at the calibration year, where the tax rate, the replacement-rate ratio, the coverage share and the household survey are all measured, rather than averaging. Correcting for the shadow economy would raise the capital-output target, since the Penn World Table stock is economy-wide and the informal sector is labor-intensive. We keep the measured ratio, because no source measures an informal capital share and the stock also includes housing, which cuts the other way.

formal output, K_t/Y_t, the ratio that fixes R_t; over GDP, formal plus informal output, its ratio is 2.99. We calibrate β and ϵ numerically, since β depends on the politico-economic equilibrium path for savings and labor supply and ϵ depends on β.

To construct the time series for ν_t we follow Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008) and use thirty-year gross growth of the total population in the estimates and medium-variant projections of the United Nations' World Population Prospects 2024. Finally, we use social security spending before the 2001 crisis of 7.1% of GDP,[40] to calibrate ω. Since the payroll tax falls on formal labor income, which is a share $1-\alpha$ of formal output, and formal output is a share $1-y$ of GDP when informal output is a share y, spending of 7.1% of GDP corresponds to an equivalent social security tax rate of $\tau_{2010} = 0.071/[(1-\alpha)(1-y)]$. Informal output is the income of informal households, which the informal income condition in (E.1) fixes relative to formal income, so that $y = 0.075$, between the survey's 5% and the shadow-economy estimates above, and $\tau_{2010} = 0.118$. This is the tax of the pre-reform economy in 2010, which we target at pre-crisis spending since contributive spending returned to that level after 2010. Savings and spending are reported over the same GDP.

E.4 Productivity and hours

We use η_j and X_j to match the income distribution across formal households and the income and working hours of informal households. Specifically, let z_j^η and z_j^x denote income and hours worked of group j relative to the population-weighted average over the formal households, so that $\sum_{i>0}\gamma_i z_i^\eta = \sum_{i>0}\gamma_i z_i^x = 1$; informal households are measured against the same formal average. With labor supply $h_{t,i}/h_t = (\eta_i/X_i)^\xi/\sum_{j>0}\gamma_j\eta_j^{1+\xi}/X_j^\xi$ for formal households (cf. proposition 1) and $h_{t,0} = (\eta_0 w_t^0/X_0)^\xi$ for informal households, where w_t^0 is the informal wage, we solve the system

$$
\begin{aligned}
z_i^\eta &= \frac{w_t(1-\tau_t)h_{t,i}\eta_i}{w_t(1-\tau_t)h_t} = \frac{\eta_i^{1+\xi}/X_i^\xi}{\sum_{j>0}\gamma_j\eta_j^{1+\xi}/X_j^\xi}, \qquad i>0, \\
z_i^x &= \frac{h_{t,i}}{\sum_{j>0}\gamma_j h_{t,j}} = \frac{(\eta_i/X_i)^\xi}{\sum_{j>0}\gamma_j(\eta_j/X_j)^\xi}, \qquad i>0, \\
z_0^\eta &= \frac{w_t^0 h_{t,0}\eta_0}{w_t(1-\tau_t)h_t}, \qquad z_0^x = \frac{h_{t,0}}{\sum_{j>0}\gamma_j h_{t,j}}.
\end{aligned}
\tag{E.1}
$$

Because only relative income and hours are observed, both the level of efficiency units and the unit in which hours are measured are free. We spend the first on the normalization

[40] Total public pension spending, national and provincial schemes, 7.0% and 7.2% of GDP in 2000 and 2001 (Cetrángolo and Grushka 2020, table 13). We use pre-crisis spending as it was relatively stable during that time, and after 2010 contributive pensions returned to their pre-crisis levels. Following the 2001 crisis, pension spending was reduced, to 5.2% of GDP in 2005, by only allowing minimum pensions to adjust for inflation.

$\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \eta_i^{1+\xi} / X_i^{\xi} = 1$, and take the taste for leisure to be common across the formal groups, $X_i = X$ for $i > 0$. The formal income conditions then invert in closed form, $\eta_i = (z_i^{\eta})^{1/(1+\xi)} X^{\xi/(1+\xi)}$, and they satisfy the normalization at any X, so the level of X is what fixes the unit in which hours are counted. We pin it down by requiring average formal hours in the baseline year, $\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i h_{t,i}$, to equal the average workweek of formal workers in the survey, 42.5 hours expressed as a share of discretionary time. Relative hours across the formal quartiles are then a prediction rather than a target, rising with relative income at elasticity $\xi/(1+\xi)$, and section 5 compares the prediction with the survey. The aggregate h_t weights hours by productivity and is not average formal hours; the two differ by the factor $\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i (\eta_i / X_i)^{\xi}$, which the informal hours condition in (E.1) carries. That condition and the informal income condition pin down η_0 and X_0 given the equilibrium h_t in the baseline year, and we solve for them jointly with β and ω at $X = 1$. The level of X then follows in one step from the solved hours, and η_0 and X_0 are re-derived at it. That last step leaves the equilibrium untouched, since the informal household reaches every aggregate through $\eta_0^{1+\xi} / X_0^{\xi}$, which the unit of hours does not move.

E.5 The vector-X_i calibration

The alternative to a common taste for leisure treats the survey's relative hours as data at every point of the formal distribution: with both z_i^{η} and z_i^{x} imposed, (E.1) identifies one X_i per quartile, and the level of hours is then not identified. Since the productivity distribution reaches every aggregate only through $\sum_{i>0} \gamma_i \eta_i^{1+\xi} / X_i^{\xi}$, which both calibrations normalize to one, β, ω and every equilibrium outcome of section 5, the reform at every ρ and its dependence on ϵ and θ included, are identical under the two; only the productivity and leisure parameters and the reading of relative hours differ. The online appendix reports that calibration against the one used here.

F Calibration – the U.S., France, and the UK

This appendix documents the data and the household heterogeneity behind the calibrations of section 6, whose parameters are in table 3. Each country has three income groups of men aged 25 to 60. The tables report, group by group, the population share γ_i, the taste for leisure X_i and the productivity η_i that the calibration assigns, and the propensity to vote μ_i taken from the data. Under the calibration of section 6 the taste for leisure is common across groups, so the X_i row repeats one number, fixed by the country's average workweek, and the income distribution is carried by η_i alone; the online appendix describes the alternative, with one X_i per group identified from relative hours.

The parameters in the lower panel of table 3 are common to the three countries. The

discount factor β matches the U.S. thirty-year gross interest factor $R_{2020} = 2.443$, the gross interest rate net of average multifactor productivity growth estimated by Gonzalez-Eiras and Niepelt (2008), and is imposed on France and the UK. The Frisch elasticity is $\xi = 0.30$, as for Argentina, and the capital share $\alpha = 0.30$.[41] Pension spending is public cash spending on old-age and survivors pensions in 2020 from the OECD Social Expenditure Database, the measure of figure 1.1. The number of workers per retiree ν_t is thirty-year gross growth of the total population in the estimates and medium-variant projections of the United Nations' World Population Prospects 2024, corrected for France as described below. The online appendix reports the calibration at every intertemporal elasticity of the model's grid.

F.1 The U.S.

For the U.S. we use the CPS March Supplement 2019. The low and medium income groups are cut so that their mean incomes are half the mean and the mean, which is what identifies θ from the replacement rates at those two income levels reported in OECD (2021); the remaining households form the high income group. The propensity to vote is from the U.S. Census, Voting and Registration in the Election of November 2020. Medicare is left out of spending and of θ, as is public health spending in France and the UK, where it is not confined to retirees, so that spending and θ measure pensions alike in the three countries. The online appendix reports the U.S. under the alternative reading, in which Medicare, 2.9% of GDP in the 2020 Data Book of the Medicare Payment Advisory Commission, counts among the transfers to the old as a benefit unrelated to income.[42] The tax rate is then 14.7%, and θ falls to 0.522, below the UK's 0.560.

Table 9 shows the two features that set the U.S. apart. Productivity rises steeply across the groups, from 0.82 in the low group to 2.54 in the high one, and the propensity to vote rises with income, from 0.47 to 0.77, so the political objective weighs high-income households well above their population share. The low group holds 58% of households.

[41] Averaging adjustments 2 and 3 of Gollin (2002) gives capital income shares close to 0.3 for France and the U.S. and slightly lower for the UK.

[42] Bethencourt and Galasso (2008) treat public health care and pensions as political complements, which supports that reading.

Table 9: Household heterogeneity – the U.S.

	Income group			
Parameter	**Low**	**Medium**	**High**	**Target**
γ_i	0.58	0.18	0.24	Income percentiles.
X_i	4.16	4.16	4.16	Average hours worked.
η_i	0.82	1.39	2.54	Income distribution.
μ_i	0.47	0.63	0.77	Voting propensity.

F.2 France

For France we use the 2018 wave of the Luxembourg Income Study. France's system is fully Bismarckian, so $\theta = 1$ whatever the income cuts, and the groups need not be cut at half-mean and mean income. We cut them at the U.S. percentiles instead, which puts the two countries' household types in one-to-one correspondence and makes the counterfactuals of section 6 a type-by-type replacement. The propensity to vote is from the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems.[43] Since the normal retirement age of men retiring in 2020 was 64.5 years in France, against 66 in the U.S. (OECD 2021, figure 3.7), we take France's population growth in 2020 to be

$$\frac{\text{Population 2020} \times (30 - 1.5)/30}{\text{Population 1990} + \text{Population 2020} \times 1.5/30},$$

and the other dates in the same way, with a gap of 1.5 years in 1990 and 2020 and of 1 year from 2050 on, the gap between the normal retirement ages of men entering the labor market in 2020, 66 against 67.

At the same percentiles France's productivity profile is flatter than the U.S. one (table 10): it runs from 1.09 to 2.51, a ratio of the high to the low group of 2.29 against 3.08 in the U.S. (table 3). The propensity to vote is nearly flat, between 0.81 and 0.86. The common taste for leisure is 6.64 against 4.16 in the U.S., which is how the calibration accounts for France's shorter workweek.

[43] https://cses.org/.

Table 10: Household heterogeneity – France

Parameter	Income group			Target
	Low	Medium	High	
γ_i	0.58	0.18	0.24	Income percentiles.
X_i	6.64	6.64	6.64	Average hours worked.
η_i	1.09	1.55	2.51	Income distribution.
μ_i	0.81	0.86	0.85	Voting propensity.

F.3 The UK

For the UK we use the Harmonised British Household Panel Survey, wave 17, which refers to 2006–07 and is distributed by the UK Data Service.[44] Income groups are cut as for the U.S., at half-mean and mean income. The propensity to vote is from the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems.

The UK's cuts put fewer households in the low group than the U.S. cuts do, 29% against 58%, and most of them in the medium group (table 11). The ratio of high to low productivity is close to the U.S. one, 3.06 against 3.08, and the propensity to vote lies between the other two countries, rising from 0.61 to 0.74. Table 14 also reports the UK with its households regrouped at the U.S. income percentiles, by a linear fit of the UK's group means rather than a recount of the survey, which understates the UK's dispersion of relative incomes (appendix G.1); the online appendix documents that grouping.

Table 11: Household heterogeneity – UK

Parameter	Income group			Target
	Low	Medium	High	
γ_i	0.29	0.58	0.13	Income percentiles.
X_i	7.93	7.93	7.93	Average hours worked.
η_i	0.95	1.61	2.90	Income distribution.
μ_i	0.61	0.70	0.74	Voting propensity.

F.4 France at the UK's income groups

Since France's system is fully Bismarckian, its income groups can also be cut at the UK's own income percentiles without disturbing the identification of θ, which puts France's and the UK's household types in one-to-one correspondence exactly as the U.S. percentiles

[44] Later waves were collected at least in part during the Great Recession.

do above. Table 12 reports France's household heterogeneity on those groups; the online appendix imposes them on the UK.[45] At the UK's cuts France is the more unequal of the two: the productivity of its top group relative to its bottom group is about 3.3 against the UK's 3.06, whereas at the U.S. cuts France is well below the U.S. (table 3). The regrouping moves none of France's aggregates: its political weight of the old and its tax rate are those of table 3.

Table 12: Household heterogeneity – France, UK income groups

	Income group			
Parameter	**Low**	**Medium**	**High**	**Target**
γ_i	0.29	0.58	0.13	Income percentiles.
X_i	6.58	6.58	6.58	Average hours worked.
η_i	0.92	1.47	3.03	Income distribution.
μ_i	0.81	0.83	0.85	Voting propensity.

G Further results on the endogenous design

This appendix collects results on the endogenous design of section 7 that the main text only points to: the calibration of the cost for the UK and the test of the U.S. calibration on the UK and France, and the path of the design along the projected U.S. demography.

G.1 Calibration

Table 13 calibrates the cost on the UK as table 4 does on the U.S.: λ is the value at which the UK electorate re-elects its observed design, $\theta^* = 0.560$, with households grouped at the UK's own income cuts as in section 6. The UK's parameter lies below the U.S. one at low elasticities, by 33% at $\rho = 0.5$ and 32% at $\rho = 1$, and above it at $\rho = 2$, by 17%. The cost weighs less in the UK. At $\rho = 1$ its observed design loses 1.9% of revenue, as the U.S. one does, but a flat benefit of the same size would lose 9.2%, against 22.9% in the U.S., because the UK's dispersion of relative incomes is about half the U.S. one, 0.223 against 0.436, and its cost parameter a third lower, although its system is slightly larger, with a tax rate of 11.2% against 10.5%. As in the U.S., the cost raises the calibrated political weight of the old, from 1.10 to 1.15 at $\rho = 1$.

Table 14 asks what the U.S. parameter implies for the other two economies at $\rho = 1$. Each economy keeps its own calibration of section 6 and takes $\lambda = 11.345$ from the U.S.

[45] Income, hours and group sizes are the same Luxembourg Income Study sample as table 10, regrouped. Voting propensities are only observed at the U.S. cuts; at the UK's cuts each group carries the population-weighted average of the observed values it overlaps with.

Table 13: The calibrated cost of redistribution in the UK

ρ	λ	ω	$1 - f(\theta^*)$	$1 - f(0)$
0.5	16.694	1.52	4.0%	18.8%
1.0	7.740	1.15	1.9%	9.2%
2.0	3.103	1.05	0.7%	3.8%

Note: As table 4, for the UK at its own income groups, where $\theta^* = 0.560$ and $\tilde{V} = 0.223$ at every ρ; λ is the value at which the UK electorate re-elects its observed design. β is the U.S. value of the calibration without the cost, imposed as in section 6, and ω is recalibrated with λ.

Table 14: The UK and France under the U.S. cost of redistribution

Economy	θ^* **observed**	θ **chosen, U.S.** λ	**Own** λ	$\tilde{V}$
UK	0.560	0.690	7.740	0.223
France	1.000	0.795	–	0.218
UK at U.S. income groups	0.543	0.699	7.121	0.065

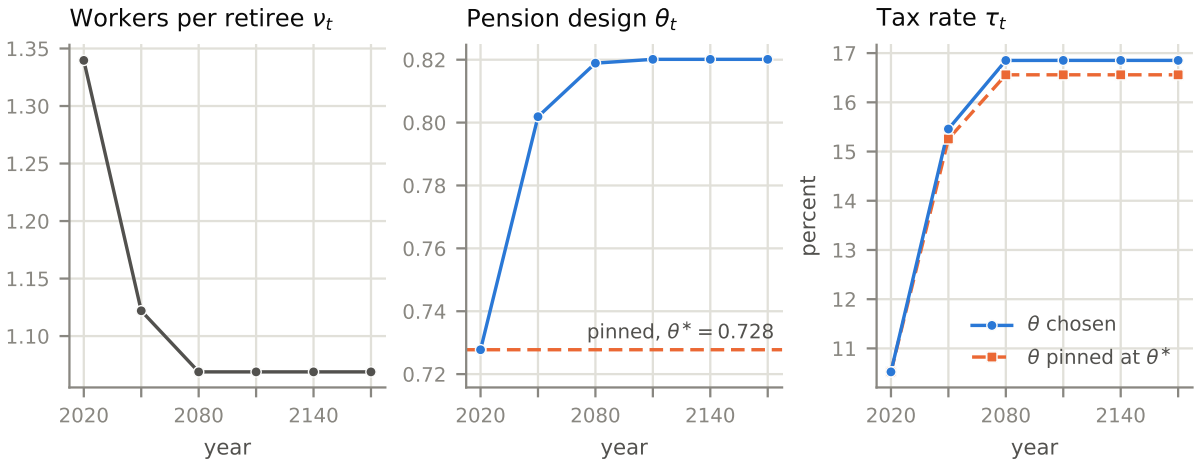
Note: Each economy is its own calibration at $\rho = 1$ with U.S. $\lambda = 11.345$. "Chosen" is the design in 2020 on the economy's own freely simulated path under the U.S. parameter, to be read against the observed one; "own" is the value at which that path re-elects the observed design. No λ makes France re-elect its observed design, the Bismarckian corner $\theta = 1$: under log preferences neither the slope of the design objective at that corner nor the tax rate there depends on λ, and France's slope there is negative.

The UK's electorate then chooses 0.690, above its observed 0.560, and France's chooses 0.795, below its observed 1.000, so the three designs are ordered as observed, with the U.S. at 0.728 between them, and the parameter accounts for about a quarter of the distance from the U.S. design to each of the other two. No finite value of the parameter makes France re-elect its own design: the slope of its political objective at the Bismarckian corner does not depend on the parameter, and without the cost the objective falls towards the corner (appendix C.2). The UK and France have nearly the same dispersion of relative incomes, 0.223 and 0.218, the latter with France grouped at the U.S. income percentiles (about 0.25 at the UK's), while France's tax rate is almost twice the UK's, 20.6% against 11.2%. Under one parameter, each unit of redistribution therefore costs France nearly twice as much as the UK, in line with France's more earnings-related choice. The last row of the table regroups the UK's households at the U.S. income percentiles, by a linear fit of the UK's group means rather than a recount of the survey (appendix F). The regrouping reads the UK's design as 0.543 and its dispersion of relative incomes as 0.065; under the U.S. parameter the regrouped UK chooses 0.699, and its own parameter is 7.121. The linear fit understates this dispersion: the means of the UK's own three groups imply that an exact regrouping at the U.S. percentiles has a dispersion of at least 0.10, so the row is an approximation.

G.2 The design along the baseline path

Figure G.1 follows the U.S. along its projected demography at $\rho = 1$, with the design chosen and with the design pinned at θ^*. Since the calibration targets only the design of 2020, the path from 2020 on is a prediction. Along it the chosen design goes from 0.728 in 2020 to 0.802 in 2050 and stays at 0.820 from 2110 on. It tracks the number of workers per retiree, which falls from 1.34 to 1.07, and settles one period after the demography does. The tax rate climbs from 10.5% to 16.9%, 0.3 p.p. above the path with the design pinned, since a more earnings-related system loses less of its revenue.[46]

Figure G.1: The design and the tax along the baseline path



Note: The paths start in 2020, the calibration year, under log preferences ($\rho = 1$); a design chosen at one date applies from the following one. The online appendix shows the paths from 1990 and for the UK and France, and its page C4 shows them at the other elasticities.

H The OECD cross-section

This appendix documents the test of section 7.3: the sample and the data, the U.S. at those data, where the political weight of the old and the cost parameter are calibrated, and the second layer of the test, in which the political weight of the old is calibrated country by country. Every economy is solved under log preferences with the cost of section 7.1, and exactly one candidate tax passes at every state and date of every solve (section 4). The online appendix repeats the test on all 29 countries of figure 1.1 and with each country's own propensities to vote.

[46] The path barely depends on the Frisch elasticity. Recalibrated at $\xi = 0.2$ and 0.4, λ changes by less than one percent and the tax rate in 2110 by about 0.3 p.p., while the design in 2110 and the design under acute ageing move by about 0.001 (online appendix).

H.1 Sample and data

The sample is the 29 countries of figure 1.1 less those in which more than a quarter of employment is informal in the ILO's measure (ILOSTAT, 2018–2020): Mexico at 56%, Turkey at 31% and Korea at 29%. The next are the UK, the Czech Republic and the Netherlands, at 20%, 17% and 14%, where the measure mostly reflects self-employment that their pension systems cover. Australia, Canada, Japan, New Zealand and the U.S. have no such measure and stay in. Korea and Turkey also stand apart in their pension systems: Korea's public pension dates only from 1988, and Turkey's retirement age for men is 52. On the 26 countries the relations in the data keep the signs they have on the 29, except the flat relation between spending and the Gini (online appendix).

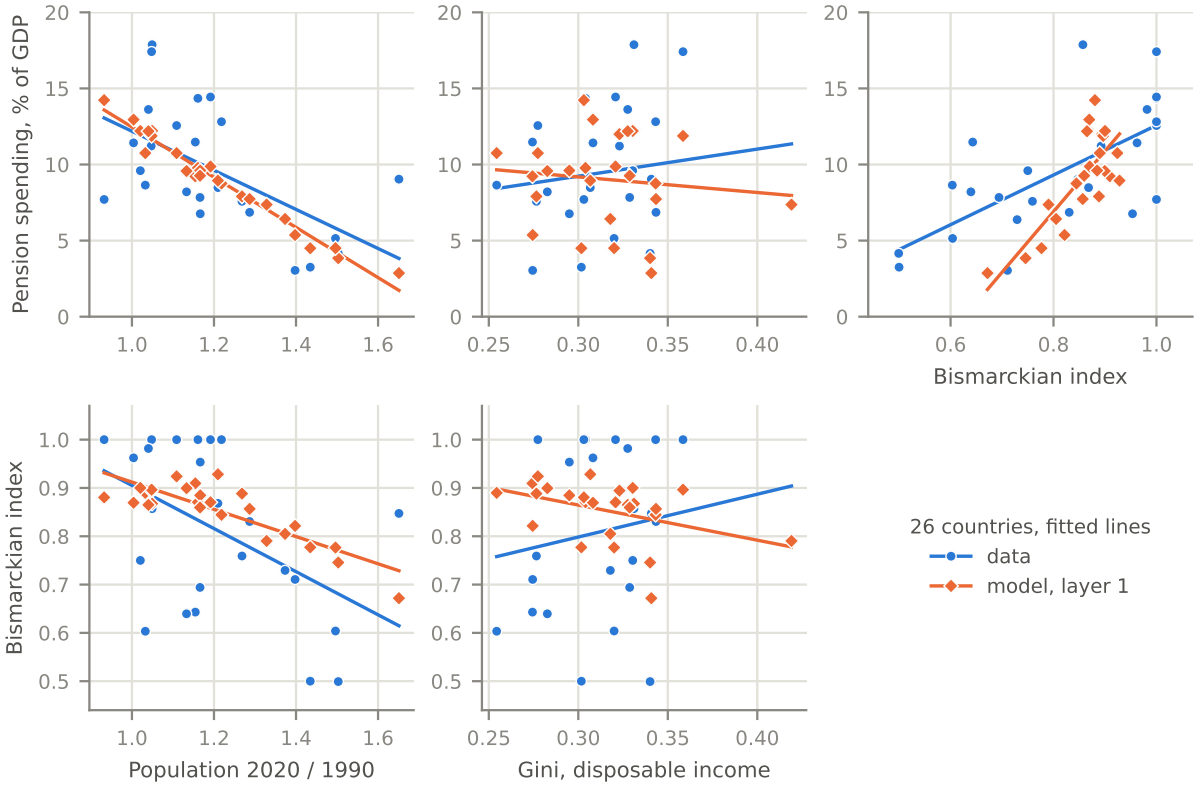
Every country, the U.S. included, is measured in the same way. The number of workers per retiree ν_t is the thirty-year growth of the total population in the medium variant of the United Nations' World Population Prospects 2024, from 1990 to 2080, with 1960 at the value of 1990 and the periods after 2080 at the value of 2080, as in the calibrations of section 6; for France it is the plain ratio, without the correction for the retirement age of appendix F. Pension spending and the index I are those of figure 1.1, and the observed design is $\theta = 2 - 1/I$, the inverse of the mapping in section 7.3, clipped to $[0, 1]$. Australia, whose means-tested pension puts its index just below one half, and Ireland are therefore at the Beveridgean corner, and Austria, Finland, France, Hungary, Italy and Spain at the Bismarckian one. The income distribution is that of the gross earnings of men in full-time employment in the OECD earnings database, in 2019 or the nearest year, through a lognormal fitted separately below and above the median to the ratios of the first and ninth deciles to the median. Households are grouped at the U.S. income percentiles of section 6, so the three groups hold 58%, 18% and 24% of households in every country. Everything else takes the U.S. values of section 6: $\alpha = \xi = 0.30$, the propensities to vote from the CPS, a taste for leisure common to all groups, which under log preferences sets hours but no rate, and the discount factor of the calibration without the cost, $\beta = 0.655$, imposed as on the UK and France in appendix G.1. Table 15 lists the inputs that differ across countries.

H.2 The U.S. at these data

At these inputs the U.S. differs from its calibration of section 6 in two respects. Its design is $\theta = 0.735$, the inverse of its index, $39.2/49.6 = 0.790$, where section 7 has 0.728, since the means of the CPS groups lie close to, but not exactly at, half the mean and the mean. Its dispersion of relative incomes is 0.333, against 0.436 at the CPS groups: the OECD series covers men in full-time work only and is fitted to three points of the distribution, so it misses the part-time and part-year earners that the CPS records. France's is 0.150, against 0.218 in the Luxembourg Income Study (table 15). With β imposed, we calibrate

ω to the U.S. tax rate and λ so that the electorate of 1990 chooses the observed design for 2020, as in section 7.2, which gives $\omega = 1.294$ and $\lambda = 11.109$, against 11.345 at the CPS groups (table 4). Figure H.1 sets the first layer of the test, in which every country takes these values, beside the data.

Figure H.1: The relations of figure 1.1 in the data and in the model



Note: The 26 countries of the test in the data and in the first layer of the model, with the least-squares lines whose slopes table 5 reports, together with the definitions of the model's variables.

H.3 Each country's political weight

In the second layer each country keeps the U.S. β and λ, and its political weight of the old is calibrated so that its tax rate of 2020 at the observed design matches its pension spending, as ω is in section 6. Its design is then predicted as in the first layer, which extends the test of appendix G.1 from the UK and France to 25 countries. Table 15 reports the political weights and the predicted designs. The weight of the old runs from 0.947 in Hungary to 1.761 in Luxembourg, against 1.294 in the U.S. The predicted designs run from 0.570 in Ireland to 0.937 in Finland, a narrower range than the observed one, and they keep the relations of the first layer with population growth and spending, while their relation with the Gini is no longer significant (table 5). For 17 of the 25 countries the predicted design lies on the same side of the U.S. design as the observed one. The UK is among the exceptions: it is predicted at 0.805, above the U.S., where appendix G.1, at its own income groups and propensities to vote, places it below. When every

country, the U.S. included, takes its own propensities to vote from the CSES, which in the UK rise less with income than in the U.S., the UK is predicted at 0.723, below the U.S. (online appendix). France is predicted at 0.903, short of its corner.

Table 15: The countries of the cross-country test, each calibrated to its pension spending

	Data					**Model, layer 2**		
Country	ν_{2020}	$\tilde{V}$	spending	I	θ	ω	θ	I
Australia	1.50	0.202	4.2	0.499	0.000	1.329	0.689	0.763
Austria	1.16	0.161	14.3	1.000	1.000	1.610	0.906	0.914
Belgium	1.16	0.104	11.5	0.643	0.445	1.458	0.930	0.935
Canada	1.37	0.171	6.4	0.729	0.629	1.291	0.756	0.804
Czech Republic	1.02	0.170	8.6	0.603	0.343	1.140	0.841	0.863
Denmark	1.13	0.116	8.2	0.639	0.436	1.202	0.865	0.881
Finland	1.11	0.094	12.6	1.000	1.000	1.411	0.937	0.940
France	1.16	0.150	14.4	1.000	1.000	1.610	0.903	0.912
Germany	1.05	0.148	11.2	0.892	0.880	1.247	0.873	0.887
Greece	1.04	0.225	17.9	0.857	0.833	1.708	0.898	0.908
Hungary	0.94	0.265	7.7	1.000	1.000	0.947	0.767	0.811
Iceland	1.44	0.112	3.0	0.711	0.593	1.145	0.618	0.723
Ireland	1.42	0.240	3.3	0.500	0.000	1.153	0.570	0.700
Italy	1.05	0.134	17.4	1.000	1.000	1.688	0.934	0.938
Japan	1.02	0.124	9.6	0.750	0.667	1.136	0.857	0.875
Luxembourg	1.65	0.187	9.0	0.847	0.820	1.761	0.836	0.859
Netherlands	1.17	0.116	6.8	0.953	0.951	1.129	0.815	0.844
New Zealand	1.49	0.141	5.1	0.604	0.344	1.345	0.750	0.800
Norway	1.27	0.101	7.6	0.759	0.683	1.274	0.868	0.883
Poland	1.00	0.240	11.4	0.962	0.961	1.203	0.832	0.856
Portugal	1.04	0.249	13.6	0.982	0.981	1.386	0.860	0.877
Spain	1.22	0.183	12.8	1.000	1.000	1.571	0.874	0.888
Sweden	1.21	0.081	8.5	0.868	0.848	1.266	0.916	0.923
Switzerland	1.29	0.127	6.9	0.831	0.796	1.240	0.811	0.841
United Kingdom	1.17	0.185	7.8	0.694	0.559	1.198	0.805	0.837
United States*	1.34	0.333	7.4	0.790	0.735	1.294	0.735	0.790

Note: ν_{2020}, workers per retiree; $\tilde{V}$, the dispersion of relative incomes at the U.S. income percentiles; spending in % of GDP; I, the Bismarckian index, and $\theta = 2 - 1/I$ clipped to $[0, 1]$. ω is calibrated to spending at $\beta = 0.655$ and the U.S. $\lambda = 11.109$; the last two columns are the model's design, in force in 2020 on the freely simulated path, chosen in 1990, and its index. *The U.S. is the anchor, where λ is calibrated.